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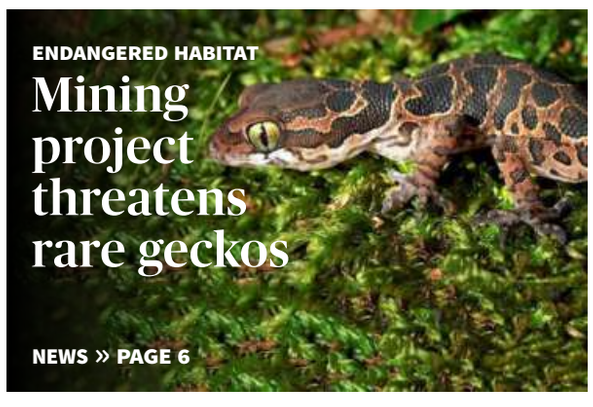
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ESCALATING CONFLICT

Houthis vow to strike more Saudi targets

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FIGHTING BACK

Hope and Paul shine as Windies pull level

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INSIDE



BoB shares tank 3.5% as founder of NMC sues it

MUMBAI
Bank of Baroda (BoB) shares fell 3.47% to ₹229.35 on the BSE on Wednesday after B.R. Shetty, founder of the failed NMC Healthcare, filed a $15-billion damages suit against the bank, alleging that the defendants acted "as an instrument in the siphoning of funds" that led to the collapse of his business. » PAGE 12

Three Indians killed in building fire in Germany

KOLLAM/IDUKKI
Three people hailing from Keralam have lost their lives in a devastating apartment building fire in Bochum, Germany. The victims were identified as Anjali Sheela Joy from Kollam, Sivin Johny from Ernakulam, and Nova Sabu from Idukki. Police have arrested a 41-year-old resident of the building on suspicion of murder. » PAGE 3

Saudi court sets aside Sri Lankan's death sentence

COLOMBO
The Supreme Court of Saudi Arabia on Wednesday set aside the death penalty awarded to a Sri Lankan migrant worker, Anojan Sivarasa, over a Facebook post that was deemed blasphemous. The case has been referred to a lower court which originally heard it and a fresh sentence is likely, according to Sri Lankan President's Counsel. » PAGE 14

ED seizes assets worth ₹2,032 cr. of Reliance Power

NEW DELHI
The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has seized assets worth ₹2,032.81 crore belonging to Reliance Power Limited in India under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA), the agency said on Wednesday. The assets include the bank balances of Reliance Power Ltd., and its shareholding in Sasan Power Ltd. » PAGE 6

Ukraine says U.S. slowed down its Starlink system

KYIV
Ukraine on Wednesday accused the United States of helping Russia, saying Washington failed to warn it of incoming missile strikes and slowed the Starlink system it relies on for its battlefield communications and frontline logistics. U.S. President Donald Trump on Tuesday insisted Washington was still helping Ukraine. » PAGE 14

Many youth held as SIR protests rock capital for fifth straight day

Youth and student groups march through Delhi escorted by a large contingent of security forces, demanding scrapping of SIR, resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, reinstatement of Jantar Mantar as a protest site; protesters have alleged assault



Pushing forward: Demonstrators attempt to remove a barricade during a protest near Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Wednesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Protesters climbed over barricades, slogans pierced through the din of police announcements, and detention buses filled up on Wednesday as hundreds of people took to the streets of central Delhi against the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

The fifth consecutive day of demonstrations saw separate marches by members of the Youth Congress and those of the Students' Federation of India and the Democratic Youth Federation of India.

The Left groups protested on Firoz Shah Road before a large contingent of police personnel and security forces moved in to control the crowd.

"*Vote chor, gaddi chhod* (vote thief, vacate your seat)," the protesters shouted while placards carried messages such as "We are Indians, not terrorists" and "Protest, not silence, is the lifeblood of democracy". The protesters targeted Mr. Kumar and opposed the removal of Jantar Mantar's status as a designated protest site.

The situation escalated as police personnel began detaining protesters who sat on the road, with several being bundled into detention vehicles. Protesters alleged being beaten up. The number of people detained was not made available at the time of going to press.

"We were detained, we were beaten up earlier also. By beating us, they cannot shut us up. Our protests will go on. Until Gyanesh Kumar resigns, we will remain on the roads. We will not back down," a protester said.

Around 800 metres away, Indian Youth Congress workers began a separate march from Patel Chowk Metro Station towards Jantar Mantar. Carrying party flags and placards, they demanded Mr. Kumar's resignation and raised slogans against the Union government.

"Modi *ji*, go back to the tea shop," read one of the placards.

The marchers initially sat outside Patel Chowk Metro Station amid a heavy security presence before proceeding along Ashoka Road.

The march was stopped near the Parliament Street police station, where protesters were detained and pushed into buses. A few climbed on top of the vehicles and continued raising slogans as the police moved to clear the area.

At both locations, extensive barricading and the deployment of security personnel turned the demonstrations into tense standoffs, with protesters resisting attempts to disperse them and police detaining those who remained on the roads.

The continuing demonstrations disrupted traffic in parts of the New Delhi district on Wednesday. Road closures, barricades, and restrictions imposed to facilitate security arrangements and control the marches led to congestion during the afternoon, leaving commuters navigating diversions and slow-moving traffic.

The demonstrations came amid a widening cycle of protests and detentions in the national capital since October 10, when the CJP called for a demonstration against SIR and Mr. Kumar. On Tuesday, members of several youth and student organisations held marches and flash protests at different locations in the city.

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CJP leaders remanded to five days custody for going to Jantar Mantar

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka were on Wednesday remanded to five days in judicial custody for allegedly entering Jantar Mantar area, which has been denotified as a designated protest site. The police registered two FIRs over allegations of trespass.

FULL REPORT ON
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SC agrees to 'take care' of Delhi voters whose names were removed

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday agreed to intervene for Delhi's voters whose names were deleted from the electoral roll pursuant to the special intensive revision (SIR), and are now effectively being asked by the Election Commission of India (ECI) to misrepresent themselves as fresh applicants by filling out Form 6 to restore their names on the roll.

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant was informed by advocates Prashant Bhushan and Neha Rathi, appearing for petitioners Anjali Bhardwaj and Amrita Johri, that voters seeking to restore their names are being compelled by the ECI to file a declaration that they had never voted before or face imprisonment.

"We are thinking of passing an order which will take care of this issue," the CJI remarked.

"The ECI should either allow them to file Form 8 [for shifted voters] or create a new form for voters deleted in the SIR," Mr. Bhushan submitted. He said the Delhi SIR case was listed on October 30, but that would be too late as the last date for filing claims and objections for the ongoing SIR was the same day. The Chief Justice advanced the date of hearing to October 28.

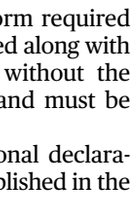
The application has asked the court to direct the ECI to frame an appropriate mechanism for restoration/inclusion of deleted voters without forcing them to apply as first-time voters.

'Fundamental anomaly'

Form 6, prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules of 1960, requires every applicant to affirm that they are "applying for inclusion in the electoral roll for the first time".

During the enumeration phase of the SIR in Delhi, 47,56,722 electors, that is 32.78% of the voters who existed prior to the start of the SIR, were excluded from the draft roll under the category of ASDD (Absent, Shifted, Dead or Duplicate). For any person on the ASDD list, the only mechanism for filing a claim for having their name restored in the voter list is through Form 6.

> The EC should either allow them [voters seeking re-inclusion] to file Form 8 or create a new form for voters deleted in the SIR
>
> **PRASHANT BHUSHAN**
> Advocate for petitioners



"This creates a fundamental anomaly as all these people were previously enrolled on the voter list but are now required to submit Form 6 and make a declaration that they are seeking inclusion in the electoral roll for the first time, which is factually incorrect and wholly inapplicable to their circumstances," the application said.

Further, it said these persons would become vulnerable to punishment for giving a false declaration under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, which provides for imprisonment for a term which may extend to one year or a fine or both.

The petition also pointed out that the additional declaration form required to be submitted along with Form 6 was without the force of law and must be struck down.

The additional declaration form, published in the SIR guidelines issued in June 2026, was subsequently modified in the SIR guidelines issued in October 2025 and the May 2026 guidelines applicable for Delhi.

It said that a clarification by the ECI that the additional declaration form would not be required during the non-SIR period creates a parallel mechanism for the same purpose.

India's exports to China grow 40%, deficit crosses $100 billion

Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING

India's exports to China grew 40% in the first three quarters of 2026 to around $20 billion, although the trade deficit with the neighbouring country has continued to widen, already crossing $100 billion this year, according to data released by China's General Administration of Customs on Wednesday.

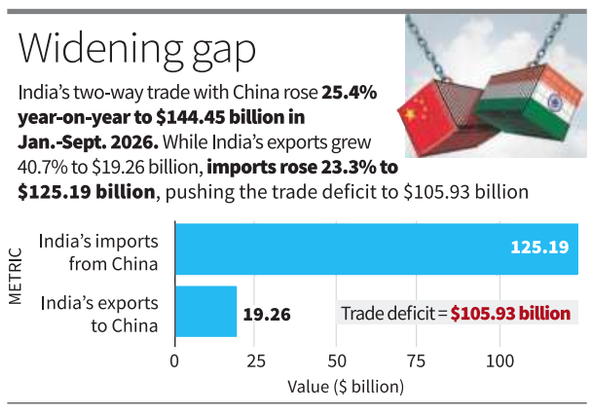
Two-way trade between January and September this year was up 25.4% to $144.45 billion, while India's imports from China continued to rise, up 23.3% to $125.19 billion.

Indian exports to China registered a robust 40.7% growth, albeit from a much smaller base, to $19.26 billion after the first three quarters, already reaching last year's total.

The trade deficit stood at $105.93 billion and is on track to surpass last year's record figure of $116.12 billion.

Indian officials say while there is no expectation for trade to be perfectly balanced, the broader concern is the heavily lopsided trade relationship, a lack of market access for Indian firms, and the nature of India's imports.

The widening imbalance has remained a source of concern for New Delhi, with the deficit figuring in last month's talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping on the sidelines of BRICS summit.



While India requires large amounts of intermediates from China for manufacturing, the continued reliance on finished goods, including large quantities of electronics and machinery, remains a concern.

India's major exports to China this year have included seafood products, naphtha, and printed circuit boards, which until recently India was buying in bulk from the neighbouring country.

Chinese export controls

India is also concerned by Chinese export controls in an increasing number of sectors, from fertilizers to rare earths.

At last month's meeting in New Delhi on the sidelines of the BRICS summit, Mr. Modi and Mr. Xi "underlined the need to address each other's concerns, including structural trade imbalance and supply chain issues, and facilitation of meaningful and predictable market access", a statement from the Ministry of External Affairs said. Both leaders also "took note of the progress in people-to-people ties and underscored the need to further promote cultural exchanges, business linkages and greater mobility between the two countries," the statement said, following the normalisation in relations since the October 2024 meeting between the two leaders.

A statement from China's Foreign Ministry, after the meeting, said the "two sides should also address each other's economic and trade concerns in a balanced way and promote the sound and steady development of economic and trade relations."

Wholesale inflation rises to 49-month high of 11.4%

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Wholesale price inflation rose to 11.4% in September, a record-breaking high during the two-and-a-half years for which there is data for the new series of Wholesale Price Index (WPI), and a 49-month-high as per the old series.

Inflation in the food articles component of WPI came in at 8.1%, up sharply from 5.7% in August.

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INBRIEF



Ankita Bhandari murder: Rahul and Priyanka meet her parents

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and his sister, Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, on Wednesday met the parents of late Ankita Bhandari, who were staging a sit-in protest near India Gate against the appointment of Dushyant Kumar Gautam as Governor of Sikkim. Ms. Bhandari, a receptionist at Vanantra Resort in Uttarakhand's Pauri district, was killed in 2022 by her employer, Pulkit Arya, the son of a BJP leader, and two of his aides. The investigation found that she was murdered for refusing to provide "special services" to a VIP. Her parents have alleged that Mr. Gautam was the VIP in question.

HC directs holding of rural polls in U.P. within 3 months

The Allahabad High Court on Wednesday directed the State Election Commission (SEC) to hold polls to panchayati raj institutions in Uttar Pradesh within three months. The order was passed by a Bench comprising Justices Ajit Kumar and Garima Prashad. The petitioner had moved the court seeking a direction to the SEC to place on record a detailed time-bound schedule for completion of the entire panchayat election process well before the expiry of district panchayats' tenure. The Congress and the Samajwadi Party lauded the HC directive and accused the BJP government of delaying the polls due to its 'fear of defeat'. PTI

Main accused in Punjab anti-drug activist murder held, shop burnt

Medical store owner arrested from Salasar in Rajasthan; local authorities demolish portion of his house in Veer Nagar, citing 'unauthorised construction'; bulldozer action also initiated at the store before angry protesters vandalise it and set it ablaze

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

A day after anti-drug crusader Parvinder Singh Jhota was shot dead in Punjab's Mansa district, the police arrested the main accused, Ashwani Kumar, from Salasar in Rajasthan on Wednesday.

A portion of the accused's house in Mansa's Veer Nagar was demolished by an excavator, with local authorities claiming that it was an "unauthorised construction". The bulldozer action was also initiated at Mr. Kumar's medical store located a few metres from the house. Protesters later vandalised the store and set it ablaze.

Jhota's murder in broad daylight at Mr. Kumar's medical store on Tuesday – when he confronted the latter for allegedly selling illegal addictive substances to a man – had sparked public outrage. A former boxer, Jhota had been running a campaign against drug abuse through the *'Nasha Roko, Rozgaar Do'* drive.



Authorities demolishing a portion of the house belonging to Ashwani Kumar, the main accused in the murder of anti-drug activist Parvinder Singh Jhota; (right) the accused's medical store engulfed in flames after protesters set it on fire in Mansa district on Wednesday. PTI, ANI

Heavy and elaborate security arrangements were put in place in the town to ensure peace as a group of people staged a protest in Mansa.

Call for shutdown

Following the murder, a joint action committee comprising various organisations gave a call for a Statewide shutdown in Punjab on October 15.

The protesters have demanded a probe by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the post-mortem to be conducted at the Post-Graduate Institute of Medical Education and Research in Chandigarh.

Jhota's family has refused to cremate the body until the demands are met.

Deputy Inspector General of Police, Bathinda Range, Harjit Singh said the main accused had been arrested and an FIR has been registered against two persons.

'Will face strict action'

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann said everyone responsible for the crime would face strict action. Urging people to maintain peace and communal harmony, Mr. Mann said, "Punjab has earned its peace through immense effort and sacrifice. We must protect this atmosphere of brotherhood and harmony at all costs. The government will take firm action against those responsible for the murder while ensuring that peace and law and order are maintained in the State."

He added that if the investigation reveals the involvement of any other individual or organisation in the murder, they will also not be spared.

Three rebel SP MLAs join BJP in Amethi

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Three rebel MLAs from the Samajwadi Party (SP) formally joined the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Wednesday in Amethi. The induction formalises a split that started in February 2024 during the Rajya Sabha poll, when several MLAs cross-voted in favor of the BJP candidate. The rebel MLAs – Abhay Singh, Rakesh Pratap Singh, and Vinod Chaturvedi – joined the BJP at an event attended by senior BJP leaders, including national general secretary Smriti Irani and U.P. BJP chief Pankaj Chaudhary.

Rakesh Pratap Singh is the MLA for the Gauriganj Assembly constituency in Amethi district, Abhay Singh represents the Goshainganj Assembly constituency in Ayodhya district, and Vinod Chaturvedi represents Kalpi in Jalaun district.

"Even after years of waiting, they received nothing more than a membership slip. Such people come and go; they will remain there for years but not as candidates, as their membership took years to come," SP chief Akhilesh Yadav said in a post on X.

BJD takes exception to Odisha Governor-designate's 'will work to strengthen BJP' statement

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

The Biju Janata Dal (BJD) on Wednesday strongly objected to a comment by Odisha Governor-designate Braj Mohan Ram, who was quoted as saying that he would work towards strengthening the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) after assuming office.

"We are shocked to hear his response to a news agency, in which he reiterates that he would work toward strengthening the BJP party organisation," said Lenin Mohanty, BJD spokesperson, in a statement.

Mr. Mohanty said, "We condemn the statement which negates the fact that Governor is above party politics."

68-year-old Mr. Ram was first elected to Bihar Legislative Assembly in 1991 and elected to the Lok Sabha in 1996 and 1998. After bifurcation of Bihar, he represented the Palamu Lok Sabha seat in Jharkhand.



Odisha Governor-designate Braj Mohan Ram. FILE PHOTO

Mr. Ram was not the first person from Jharkhand to become Governor of Odisha. Earlier, Raghubar Das, the former Jharkhand Chief Minister, had also held a gubernatorial role in the State. During his tenure, Mr. Das faced similar criticism from the BJD for his frequent visits to different districts.

BJD chief Naveen Patnaik accused the State government of incompetence, alleging that people across sections were suffering and the future of Gen Z was bleak. Addressing a gathering during the BJD's Jan Sampark Padayatra, he said the ruling party was focused on its own growth rather than the development of the State. "When the BJD's sole agenda was development of Odisha, the present 'double-engine' government's primary objective is the development of their own party," he said.

(With inputs from PTI)

J&K HC seeks clarity on accommodation for Azad and Raina

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

The Jammu and Kashmir High Court on Wednesday sought details of the government policy that allowed political persons to retain government accommodations in J&K, while hearing a case pertaining to Ghulam Nabi Azad, former Chief Minister of J&K, and Ravinder Raina, former president of the BJP's J&K unit.

"As to what is the policy in the UT of J&K which govern the retention of government accommodation, which has been applied in the present case, and wherefrom the designated committee derives its power to consider whether such government accommodation has to be retained by the political persons," observed a Division Bench, comprising Chief Justice Dr. Pushpendra Bhati and Judge Rajesh Sekhri.

The court's observations followed the submission of Additional Advocate General (AAG) Monika Kohli that the retention of the residential accommodations, by Mr. Azad and Mr. Raina, were placed before a designated committee in its meeting held on August 14, 2026.

Panel recommendation

The court was informed that the committee recommended continuation of the allotments. The competent authority allowed the retention of the residential accommodation until March, 2027, "or until the next review", the AAG informed the court.

However, the Division Bench sought further clarification. To which, Ms. Kohli sought time "to address the issues by filing an appropriate affidavit and to assist this court regarding the uniform policy."

Maharashtra declares 40 more taluks drought-hit; farmers to get ₹5,000 aid before Deepavali

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

The Maharashtra government on Wednesday declared 40 more taluks in the State drought-hit and decided to deposit an advance relief amount of ₹5,000 each in the bank accounts of farmers ahead of Deepavali.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis warned cooperative societies, district banks, nationalised banks and microfinance companies against pressuring farmers to recover loans.

The government had earlier declared 265 talukas drought-hit. With 40 more talukas added to the list, the total has risen to 305. Trigger 1 and Trigger 2 have been applied in these talukas, making them eligible for assistance under the Centre's National Disaster Response Fund (NDRF) guidelines. The measures include a complete waiver of examination fees for students in drought-hit talukas, without any eligibility criteria.



An empty water vessel sits on drought-hit farmland in Beed district. FILE PHOTO

"The government will purchase the fodder cultivated by farmers at a guaranteed price to make fodder available for animals," Mr. Fadnavis said.

Minister of State for Relief and Rehabilitation Makrand Jadhav Patil said the government had decided to implement 12 measures to provide relief to farmers. These include exemption from land revenue, restructuring of crop loans, a stay on the recovery of agriculture-related loans, exemption from current electricity bills for agricultural pumps, and a waiver of examination fees for school and college students.

The Pune Municipal Corporation has decided to suspend water supply across the city every Thursday . It will prohibit the use of drinking water for construction and initiate closure of car washing centres. "The State has received less rainfall due to the El Niño effect and as the El Niño effect is expected to continue till next year, it is necessary to manage the available water storage economically and in a very well-planned manner," the PMC said.

Kolkata roads get a splash of colour ahead of Durga Puja; rainbow-coloured flyover triggers row after bikers skid

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

Monotonous asphalt roads and busy flyovers in Kolkata are getting a colourful makeover with traditional *'alpona'* motifs as part of a beautification drive ahead of Durga Puja. The Gariahat Bridge has turned into a rainbow of pink, orange, green, and yellow, while a large *alpona* design in contrasting red and white has appeared at the Park Circus seven-point crossing.

The initiative is part of a beautification drive by the new Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government to give the city a makeover ahead of the festival.

Inspecting the work at Gariahat Bridge, West Bengal Urban Development Minister Agnimitra Paul described the initiative as a symbol of brotherhood, love and public trust.



A view of the western flank of Gariahat Flyover, with its asphalt road painted yellow, orange, green and pink ahead of Durga Puja. ANI

While making an *alpona* – the traditional art of drawing designs on floors and other surfaces using liquid rice flour – at the busy Park Circus crossing, Ms. Paul said, "At Park Circus, where anti-India slogans were raised, fires were set, and police personnel and vehicles were attacked, large *alpona* designs are now being drawn. My brothers from minority communities have joined Hindu artists in creating these motifs."

She highlighted the participation of artists from minority communities alongside Hindu artists in creating the designs, particularly at Park Circus – a collaboration she described as a demonstration of communal harmony.

Ms. Paul said similar beautification work would also be done on Red Road, while the ghats along the Hooghly were being decorated ahead of the festival. She presented the collaboration as a gesture of intercommunity trust and invoked Prime Minister Narendra Modi's slogan, *"Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas"*.

The BJP government is making an all-out effort to make its first Durga Puja in office a grand celebration. On October 10, during Mahalaya (the end of Pitru Paksha and the beginning of Devi Paksha), it also organised a mega event at the iconic Eden Gardens, featuring fireworks and drone shows.

Safety concerns

Meanwhile, videos of motorbikes skidding on a newly painted road in Kolkata went viral on Wednesday, raising safety concerns among riders and environmentalists ahead of the festival.

Ms.Paul said the roads had been painted in rainbow colours, "keeping safety guidelines in mind".

These paints will wear off in a few months, she said.

Environmentalist Somendra Mohan Ghosh said any move to beautify the city was welcome, but such paints should not be allowed on motorable roads.

(With inputs from PTI)

Weeks after probe report held him 'responsible' for Indore water tragedy, IAS officer made Collector

The Hindu Bureau
BHOPAL

Rohit Sisonia was among the officials suspended by M.P. CM after the incident

Just weeks after a judicial commission probe report on the Indore water contamination deaths was submitted to the Madhya Pradesh High Court, IAS officer Rohit Sisonia, then the Additional Commissioner (water supply) of Indore Municipal Corporation, who was one of the two officials held "primarily responsible" for the tragedy has been appointed Collector of Raisen district in a bureaucratic shuffle by the government.

The appointment has been criticised by the Opposition Congress with State unit president Jitu Patwari raising questions over the transparency of transfer and postings in the State. "Instead of accountability, favouritism is being prioritised in important postings," he wrote on X.

Mr. Sisonia, an IAS officer of the 2017 batch, was currently posted as Deputy Secretary in the Farmers Welfare and Agriculture Development Department. He has been made Raisen Collector in the reshuffle announced late on October 13 in which 23 IAS officers have been transferred.

After the tragedy in Indore's Bhagirathpura had come to light in December, 2025, Mr. Sisonia was among the officials who were suspended for negligence by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on January 2, 2026.

'Various lapses'

The one-member judicial panel of retired High Court judge, Justice Sushil Kumar Gupta, held Mr. Sisonia and the then executive engineer (water supply) Sanjeev Shrivastava "primary responsible" for for various lapses in inspections, carrying out repair works and several delays in projects to replace the water pipeline which further led to the tragedy.

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ED attaches assets of dairy firms in TTD ghee case

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The Enforcement Directorate (ED), Hyderabad Zonal Office, has provisionally attached assets worth ₹129.85 crore belonging to dairy companies, their promoters and related entities in connection with the alleged supply of adulterated ghee to the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD).

The assets belong to Bhole Baba Organic Dairymilk Private Limited; Sri Vyshnavi Dairy Specialities Private Limited, their promoters Vipin Jain and Pomil Jain and their family members; Sukriti Foods Private Limited, its promoter Kailash Chand Mangla and his family members, besides other related entities and individuals.

Three from Keralam killed in building fire in Germany

The victims were identified as Anjali Sheela Joy from Kollam district, Sivin Johny from Ernakulam, and Nova Sabu from Idukki; investigators suspect arson; a Romanian national has been arrested

The Hindu Bureau
KOLLAM/IDUKKI

Three people hailing from Keralam have lost their lives in a devastating apartment building fire in Bochum, Germany. The victims were identified as Anjali Sheela Joy from Kollam district, Sivin Johny from Ernakulam district, and Nova Sabu from Idukki district.

In the wake of the tragedy, Tourism Minister P.C. Vishnunath said the government had initiated necessary action to bring the bodies back to Keralam. He said that authorities are actively coordinating with NORKA and the Indian Embassy in this regard. He also spoke to Ms. Joy's family. Ms. Joy had gone abroad for higher education. Ms. Sabu was from Santhigram near Kattappana in Idukki. A fitness trainer, she had moved to Germany six months ago for a job. Mr. Johny had gone to Germany only about a fortnight ago for higher studies.



Tragic loss: Anjali Sheela Joy from Kollam district and Nova Sabu from Idukki. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Police have arrested a 41-year-old resident of the building on suspicion of murder. He is a Romanian national, German news channel *n-tv* reported, citing the German Press Agency *Deutsche Presse-Agentur (DPA)*. A Bochum police spokesperson told *WDR* that there were initial grounds for suspicion of murder against the man, who had been questioned by officers from the homicide squad.

Police and prosecutors announced the arrest on Wednesday.

Investigators have ruled out a technical defect as the cause of the fire and suspect arson, but whether the fire was deliberately set or started accidentally remains under investigation. The fire broke out in a multi-family residential building in Bochum's Hofstede district.

(With inputs from PTI)

'Tamil Nadu needs only 1,000 MW to meet peak demand'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI/SALEM

Amid the row over the State government purchasing high-cost power, Energy Resources Minister C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar on Wednesday said only 1,000 MW had to be procured, that too only to meet the evening peak demand, for 16 days from October 15 to 31.

Addressing the media at the Secretariat, he said that in the current situation, where only gas-generated power was available, several quotations had been received for purchasing power at a cost of ₹33 to ₹35 per unit. He said a majority of the gas power was to be purchased only through the central agency, NTPC Vidyut Vyapar Nigam (NVVN), and hence, there was no corruption involved in the purchase.

Mr. Nirmal Kumar alleged that the DMK was spreading false news that huge costs would have to be incurred on account of this power purchase, and claimed that the additional cost per day would be only ₹5 crore to ₹7 crore.

"Currently, only gas power is available throughout the country for purchase, and even thermal power, which is available only in Assam, costs ₹17 per unit. Though we have naphtha-powered electricity plants, we are not generating power through them because the cost of generating one unit is ₹45," the Minister said.



Nirmal Kumar

Mr. Nirmal Kumar alleged that the current situation had arisen primarily owing to previous governments having failed to draw up any long-term power purchase contracts.

'Mega corruption'

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Wednesday accused the TVK-led government of creating an artificial power shortage to procure electricity at higher rates. He alleged that the move had raised suspicion of "mega corruption" in the purchase of power.

Addressing the media at the party office in Omalur, he questioned the government's purchase of power from private companies at ₹35 a unit, after cancelling agreements signed by the previous DMK government for the purchase of electricity at ₹11 to ₹20 a unit over corruption allegations. The government should have continued or extended the earlier agreements to avoid high-cost procurement, he added.

The Left parties also voiced opposition to the State government's decision to purchase electricity at ₹35 per unit to address the power deficit.

LDF, UDF trade barbs over power situation

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Keralam Assembly on Wednesday witnessed heated exchanges between the United Democratic Front (UDF) government and the Opposition Left Democratic Front (LDF) over power cuts during the monsoon and a scrapped long-term power purchase deal.

Blaming the power crisis on the "inefficiency" of the UDF government, the Opposition staged a walkout after its demand that the House adjourn the day's business and discuss the issue was rejected.

Moving the adjournment motion, G.R. Anil of the Communist Party of India alleged that the crisis was artificially created with the knowledge of the government to pave the way for power sector corporates to enter the State's power sector.

Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said the Kerala State Electricity Board (KSEB), which manages power generation, transmission and distribution within Keralam, would be maintained in the public sector. He said KSEB would be transformed into the "best institution" and that his government intended to float a power policy aimed at addressing the long-term needs of the State.

The Opposition accused the government of viewing the power situation lightly and failing to take adequate precautions despite indications of a potential crisis in May and June.

Migrant workers in Bengaluru caught in SIR maze

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

In Bengaluru's Varthur-Balagere, at least five settlements sit alongside gated apartments and tech parks, where migrant workers from West Bengal have been living in makeshift tents for ₹3,000 to ₹4,000 a month. Women work in these apartments as cooks or helpers, while the men work as cleaners, scrap collectors or delivery partners for instant food and service apps.

"We are four siblings, but we were issued an SIR notice saying more than six progeny are linked to the same person [father]. What followed were multiple loans, totalling more than a lakh, that I took to make repeated trips to my native village, running from pillar to post, but the name, they [officials] say, is 'under adjudication'," said Rafiul Mohammed.

"Our neighbours say we (his family) will be sent to Bangladesh because we could not prove ourselves. But we did whatever we were asked."



Some said that even after submitting documents, their names were deleted from the rolls. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Like Mr. Mohammed, more than 3,500 people, according to the Karnataka Bengali Kalyan Samiti, formed by and for West Bengal-based workers in Bengaluru, are "under adjudication for logical discrepancy", even as the enrolment drive has started across States by the Election Commission of India, where deleted and left-out voters can reapply via Form-6 to seek inclusion.

'Family size' an issue

In West Bengal, more than 20 lakh names will not be part of this enrolment drive as these cases are currently pending before the appellate tribunals.

Many of these workers told *The Hindu* that they feel they were targeted because of their "family size".

Others described how the process had left them in cycles of debt, as they had to repeatedly travel to West Bengal to establish their identities.

Some of them said that even after submitting documents, their names were deleted from the electoral rolls, leaving them uncertain about the voter-linked welfare benefits their families received back home.

INBRIEF



Aravana production resumes at Sabarimala after a month

The production of *Aravana* (rice-jaggery offering) resumed at Sabarimala on Wednesday morning after a month-long shutdown of the production plant for renovation and capacity expansion. The Travancore Devaswom Board, which manages the Ayyappa temple in Pathanamthitta district of Keralam, said the unit will initially produce around 1.5 lakh tins a day, with output expected to rise to 3.5 lakh tins daily after October 20. The shortage of *Aravana* during last month's puja had triggered widespread protests among devotees.

A.P. SEC announces poll schedule for local bodies

Andhra Pradesh State Election Commissioner Anil Chandra Punetha on Wednesday announced the election schedule for Municipal Corporations and Municipalities, Mandal and Zilla Parishad Territorial Constituencies, and Gram Panchayats. With this, the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) came into force, prohibiting the government from launching new welfare schemes and development projects. The election process is scheduled to be completed by December 2, 2026, Mr. Punetha said at a press conference on Wednesday.

Private bus operators to begin hunger strike from October 27

Office-bearers of the Kerala State Private Bus Operators Federation will launch an indefinite hunger strike in front of the Secretariat from October 27, demanding measures to protect the private bus sector, which they claim has been adversely affected by the State government's Priyadarshini free-travel scheme. The decision to hold the hunger strike was announced following a march to the Secretariat, organised here on Wednesday, raising various demands. Hundreds of bus owners, including women, participated in the march, which began at the Martyrs' Column.

Monsoon prelude



Grey skies: Dark clouds gather over Visakhapatnam on Wednesday with the onset of the northeast monsoon. The India Meteorological Department has forecast thunderstorms and strong surface winds in coastal Andhra Pradesh over the coming days. K. R. DEEPAK

CBI probe not needed in sting operation, says Karnataka Minister

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka Home Minister Priyank Kharge on Wednesday ruled out a CBI probe into the alleged sting operation, asserting that the Karnataka Police were capable of investigating the matter.

In his reaction to Union Minister and JD(S) leader H.D. Kumaraswamy's allegations that the sting operation was part of a conspiracy to tarnish the reputation of former Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and could be linked to attempts to force him out of office, Mr. Kharge said the State police would investigate the alleged sting operation and identify those responsible.

On Mr. Kumaraswamy's demand for a CBI inquiry, Mr. Kharge questioned the need for a central agency to investigate the matter and asked, "Why is a CBI inquiry needed in this case? What is the cause of action?"

He claimed that the CBI was to complete two or three cases entrusted to it and was seeking personnel from the State to carry out the investigations. The Karnataka Police, he said, were capable of handling the case and ensuring that the truth emerged in accordance with the law.

Czech Deputy PM inaugurates aerospace facility in Hoskote

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Czech Republic Deputy Prime Minister Karel Havlíček, on a visit to Bengaluru on Wednesday, inaugurated a new production line of Gopalan Aerospace India Private Limited (GAIPL) at its Hoskote facility.

Five Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) were also signed between the company and its Czech partners in five areas of potential collaboration, which include fire-extinguishing solutions, Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs) like fixed-wing drones, quadcopters and related systems, thermo reflective coating technology, unmanned traffic management systems and jet-powered UAVs.



Karnataka CM D.K. Shivakumar with Czech Republic Deputy PM Karel Havlíček at Vidhana Soudha in Bengaluru. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The company said that the agreements establish a basis for exploring complementary technologies, industrial cooperation and potential manufacturing opportunities across aerospace, defence and advanced engineering.

GAIPL said that it has invested approximately $40 million in its 10.5-acre Hoskote facility, which houses more than 1,50,000 sq. ft. of manufacturing infrastructure.

Prashanth to carry golden howdah at Jamboo Savari

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

The 54-year-old tusker, Prashanth, has been selected as the lead elephant for this year's Jamboo Savari, succeeding veteran Abhimanyu, who has retired from active Dasara duties at the age of 60 after carrying the golden howdah for six consecutive years.

Prashanth will carry the 750-kg golden howdah during the Vijayadashami procession on October 21, leading the Dasara elephant squad before thousands of spectators.

His selection was announced at a press conference at Mysuru Palace on Wednesday in the presence of Minister in-charge of Mysuru district Yathindra Siddaramaiah.



Team lead: Prashanth will carry the 750-kg howdah on October 21, succeeding veteran tusker Abhimanyu. M.A. SRIRAM

Prashanth was selected from among four shortlisted tuskers. According to the Forest Department, Prashanth's physical fitness, load-bearing capacity, anatomical suitability, walking stability, endurance, calm temperament and experience were key factors in his selection. His nearly 18 years of association with Mysuru Dasara, and familiarity with the palace surroundings and procession route, also worked in his favour, it stated.

Assess resource availability for data centres: NITI Aayog

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

The NITI framework requires assessment of projects' economic benefits against public support

An evaluation framework jointly developed by the NITI Aayog and Deloitte India calls for data centre approvals to be linked to verified availability of electricity, water and other infrastructure, while requiring States to assess the projects' economic benefits against the public support they receive.

The document, made public on Wednesday, comes amid the rapid expansion of India's data centre industry. India had 271 data centres as of January 2026, according to a February report by the Council on Energy, Environment and Water.

The installed capacity of these data centres stood at about 1.57 gigawatts (GW) in August 2026, according to the Union government. Industry estimates project that such capacity could reach 4.5-6.5 GW by 2030.

The expansion of data centres has triggered local opposition over the water, electricity and land they will require.

The NITI framework proposes moving from project-by-project approvals to planning for entire infrastructure corridors. It calls for States to prepare 20-30-year seasonal assessments of water availability, protect existing users, and ensure developers fund grid assets built exclusively for their projects.

States must pitch economic benefits after accounting for land, infrastructure, utility concessions. Incentives could be tied to measurable outcomes, including employment, renewable energy use, efficiency and local procurement, the document noted.

A 'five-pillar framework' also covers environmental safeguards, climate risks, and governance. It proposes a central audit mechanism, with the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology as the nodal Ministry.

The presentation does not say whether the framework has been formally adopted or whether its recommendations will be binding on States.

Centre seeks public input on demographic changes

Home Ministry's portal invites govt. bodies, public, NGOs and 'international bodies' to submit their views on the impact of these changes on employment, education, healthcare, and local economies

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI


The demography panel portal says impact of changes has extended from border districts to urban centres. FILE PHOTO

The demography panel set up by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has launched a portal to allow government bodies, members of the public, NGOs, and even "international organisations" to submit their input on "frequent demographic changes in the country", preferably post-2011.

The portal said that while these changes are most visibly concentrated in border districts, their impact has extended to affect urban centres, industrial corridors, tribal regions, and other socially and economically sensitive areas, severely impacting public service delivery, local governance, resource distribution, and social cohesion.

It said that these changes are "not attributable to normal fertility or mortality trends but are instead emerging due to external abnormal factors, including illegal immigration, irregular population mobility, and administrative laxity."

The Ministry said that the inputs will help the panel to analyse and identify the causes of demographic changes and to recommend a well-organised and permanent operational system for the "legal, fair, and time-bound identification, detention, and deportation of illegal immigrants residing in the country".

The portal mandatorily seeks the mobile phone number, address, and e-mail ID of the respondents, and seeks their consent for the processing of their personal data and analysis of the information provided.

The portal – https://demography.mha.gov.in – says that the High-Level Committee on Demographic Changes (HLCDC), chaired by former Supreme Court judge Prakash Prabhakar Naolekar, was constituted on May 26 to study the "nature, causes and consequences of demographic changes being observed in various parts of the country".

The respondents have been divided into three categories: Union government Ministries, departments, and organisations; State governments and Union Territory administrations; civil society organisations, NGOs, academic institutions, industry and business associations, international organisations, and think tanks; and individual citizens, public representatives, students, and others.

There are eight questions under the individual citizen/public representative/student/others category. One of the questions asks the respondent to "describe the major demographic changes" observed or studied over the past 15 years in the geographical areas the respondent is familiar with, such as villages, towns, cities, districts, States/UTs, regions, or "across India."

The survey seeks views on the principal drivers behind these changes and their impact on sectors such as employment, education, healthcare, housing, infrastructure, public services, the environment, social harmony, and local economies. It also invites respondents to identify challenges arising from demographic trends, highlight successful interventions by governments, local bodies or academic institutions, and share any research, reports, datasets or other evidence relevant to demographic issues.

₹53,428 cr. cleared for social assistance scheme till 2030-31

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

Govt. announces the renaming of NSAP as Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana

The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved an outlay of ₹53,428 crore for the continuation of the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) for five years, from 2026-27 to 2030-31. It has also renamed the scheme and removed the "Indira Gandhi" prefix from three sub-schemes covering old-age, widow and disability pensions.

The Cabinet also revised the eligibility criteria and assistance rates for disability pension beneficiaries.

The government statement spoke of "continuation of pension schemes for old age and widows and the family benefit scheme in its existing form". The decision to lock in the budget for the next five years has raised questions, with critics arguing that NSAP is already inadequate to meet current socio-economic realities. Unlike several other welfare schemes that use the 2011 Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC) data to identify beneficiaries, NSAP caps the beneficiary base for its three pension schemes at 3.09 crore.

"Realising Rights: A Handbook of Welfare in India", published by Azim Premji University, notes that since this ceiling is "neither defined by administrative capacity nor the actual number of eligible rights holders, eligibility as determined in the guidelines does not translate into an entitlement in practice".

Rajendran Narayanan, Associate Professor at Azim Premji University said the decision overlooked the need for pension outlays to keep pace with demographic changes and inflation. "The decision appears to assume that the number of beneficiaries will remain static. Even for the existing beneficiary base, a back-of-the-envelope calculation using a 5% inflation rate shows that ₹55,698 crore would be required," he said.

The government also said that NSAP will be renamed the Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana.

Enormous potential for closer ties with India, says Canadian Minister

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI


External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar during a meeting with his Canadian counterpart Anita Anand in New Delhi on Wednesday. PTI

India-Canada relations have "enormous potential" amidst an uncertain global scenario, Canada's Foreign Minister Anita Anand said here on Wednesday. Ms. Anand met Prime Minister Narendra Modi and External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar as the two countries reviewed a wide range of issues, including a trade pact and the conflicts in West Asia and Ukraine.

"Nearly 80 years of diplomatic ties have been enriched by generations of families, students and entrepreneurs who have brought our countries closer," said Ms. Anand on X. "Canada and India have enormous potential to shape a more prosperous future, together," she said.

Ms. Anand is in India along with Minister of International Trade Maninder Sidhu for engagements with their counterparts - Mr. Jaishankar and Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal. She indicated that Mr. Modi would visit Canada in December this year.

Ms. Anand and Mr. Jaishankar participated in a panel discussion titled "Middle Power Moment" along with former British Prime Minister Rishi Sunak and former Australian Prime Minister Kevin Rudd on Wednesday. India has been advocating the cause of the "middle powers" in light of the actions initiated by the United States and Russia in the Persian Gulf and Ukraine, respectively.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) announced that the two Ministers had a formal meeting later in the day.

"The Ministers also discussed opportunities to deepen their economic partnership, expand bilateral trade and advance collaboration in education, science and technology, people-to-people ties and multilateral fora...," said the MEA in an official readout on the ministerial meeting.

Boat that capsized in Bihar had a hole and was overloaded, say police

Amit Bhelari
RAGHOPUR (VAISHALI)


Family members mourn the death of a relative who drowned after a boat capsized in the Ganga in Vaishali district on Tuesday. ANI

The boat, which capsized in the Ganga in Vaishali district of Bihar on Tuesday, killing 13 minors, was dilapidated with a hole in the deck and was overloaded, police said on Wednesday.

The Vaishali police said the country-made boat could barely carry five people and had sailed after sunset, violating the rules. They said water had entered through the hole.

The Vaishali district administration issued show cause notices to the circle officer and station house officer of Raghopur. The Patna and Bhagalpur district authorities sounded alerts over plying of boats in the Ganga.

District Magistrate Varsha Singh said, "Action will be taken against the boat owner, the operator, and everyone involved, including the officials responsible for monitoring the situation. It was a private boat."

"It is the responsibility of the circle officer and the station house officer to prevent such activities by remaining alert and utilising their administrative machinery," she added.

Authorities called off the search operation even as people at Rampur Shyamchand village in Raghopur mourned the deaths.

Union Minister Chirag Paswan, who met the families, said, "If negligence had happened at any level, action will be taken."

Bihar Deputy Chief Minister Bijendra Prasad Yadav and State Cooperative Minister Ram Kripal Yadav visited the incident site on the instructions of Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and spoke to the family members.

Health Minister Nishant Kumar visited Nalanda Medical College and Hospital and met the injured.

Ms. Singh handed over cheques for ₹4 lakh, the ex gratia amount announced by the Chief Minister, to each family.

Army reviews quality, safety of rations for personnel

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Indian Army on Wednesday reviewed its food specifications to improve the quality, safety and nutritional value of rations supplied to troops, with a focus on food preservation, packaging, and suitability for deployment in challenging operational and climatic conditions.

The 142nd Technical Standardisation Committee Meeting on Foodstuffs was held under the aegis of the Quarter Master General's Branch here.

The committee examined advancements in food technology, preservation and packaging, nutritional value, palatability and shelf life. Particular attention was paid to ensuring that rations can withstand demanding transportation, handling and storage conditions, including air-dropping and man-pack carriage.

Marco Rubio to visit Mumbai, Jamnagar; likely to skip Delhi

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI


Marco Rubio

U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio will travel to India for his second visit in six months, with energy and trade relations on the top of the agenda as he visits Mumbai and Jamnagar, the U.S. Department of State announced on Wednesday.

However, Mr. Rubio, who is expected to visit India from October 19 to 22, will skip Delhi.

"[Mr. Rubio] will meet with senior government officials to strengthen the U.S.-India strategic partnership, exchange views on regional and global dynamics, and discuss prospects for enhanced energy cooperation," the State department said in the statement, adding that Mr. Rubio will also meet business leaders to "promote investment opportunities".

Mr. Rubio's visit to Jamnagar is important as it hosts the world's largest single-site refinery operated by Reliance industries, and is expected to include a major reception hosted by the Ambani family. The Jamnagar refinery is one of the top three companies refining Russian Ural crude oil, although it has reduced its share of the imports.

The visit would follow just a day after U.S. President Donald Trump is mandated by the U.S. Congress to propose extra tariffs as sanctions on India and other countries buying Russian oil, under the Sanctions Against Russian and Iran Act (SRIA).

Rajnath calls for deeper India-ASEAN defence ties

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and DG MP-IDSA Ambassador Sujan R. Chinoy during the ASEAN-India Defence Think Tank Forum. ANI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Wednesday called for deeper defence and technological cooperation between India and the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), pitching for joint research, co-production of military equipment and enhanced maritime security to address emerging regional challenges.

Addressing the maiden ASEAN-India Defence Think Tank Forum at the Manohar Parrikar Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses in New Delhi, Mr. Singh said India sought an Indo-Pacific where countries, irrespective of their size, could make independent choices, protect their interests and pursue development peacefully.

He called for mutual trust, respect for sovereignty, adherence to international law and keeping channels of dialogue open to address conventional and emerging security threats. "India believes that security is strengthened when countries build capacity together, respect international law and maintain trust through dialogue," he said.

Mr. Singh said India's Act East policy, along with its SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region) and MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions) visions, aligned with ASEAN-led mechanisms central to New Delhi's Indo-Pacific approach.

Highlighting the shared maritime interests of India and Southeast Asian nations, he said cooperation in maritime domain awareness, interoperability and underwater surveillance was essential to maintaining a stable, rules-based maritime order. Designating 2026 as the ASEAN-India Year of Maritime Cooperation offered an opportunity to translate common interests into practical outcomes, he added.

Court makes arrest protection given to journalist 'absolute'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Abhishek Upadhyay had authored reports on the alleged theft of donations from the Ram Temple

The Supreme Court on Wednesday made absolute the interim protection granted to independent journalist Abhishek Upadhyay from coercive action in a road rage case, as well as any subsequent first information reports (FIR).

Mr. Upadhyay had authored investigative online stories on the alleged misappropriation and theft of donations at the Ayodhya Ram Temple.

A Bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi also quashed an Uttar Pradesh Police notice issued to social media platform X to provide Mr. Upadhyay's digital data, generated around three months prior to the road rage incident.

The court found the police version that the data was sought to trace/arrest the petitioner "somewhat in contradiction" with the contents of its notice to the platform.

The court said that any information received by the police pursuant to the notice would not be used against the journalist.

The "arrest of the petitioner shall remain stayed till further notice", the court said. It made absolute its interim orders of August 25 and September 7, which had protected him from arrest and directed him to cooperate with the investigation, respectively.

The Bench ordered that Mr. Upadhyay could challenge the road rage FIR on any grounds. The court has not commented on the merits of the case.

Don't stand in the way of students: Rahul to govt.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday asked Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Minister Amit Shah not to stand in the way of protesting students, describing them as the voice of India.

Mr. Gandhi made the remarks after he met students, including activists of the party's students' wing, the National Students' Union of India (NSUI), who were injured during protests against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over alleged electoral irregularities.

He asked the students to introduce themselves, narrate their ordeal after Delhi Police personnel picked them up from the protesting sites, and then, urged the students to form a human chain.

"Amit Shah *ji*, look at this properly. Here there is no Hindu, no Muslim, no caste, no gender. There is one voice, one protest – it is the voice of Hindustan," he said. Mr. Gandhi described the students as the party's *shers* and *shernis* (lions and lionesses) and assured them that the Congress would stand by them.

CJP leaders jailed for entering Jantar Mantar

Police register FIRs against 14 CJP members, alleging trespass, obstruction of personnel on duty; Dipke accuses govt. of imposing 'unofficial Emergency'; peaceful protest is not a crime, says Rahul

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Cockroach Janta Party leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka were remanded in judicial custody for five days on Wednesday, a day after they were detained along with 12 others for allegedly entering Jantar Mantar, which the Delhi Police denotified as a designated protest site on Monday.

The police registered two first information reports (FIRs) against them over allegations of trespass, disobedience of official orders, and obstruction of police personnel on duty. Ajinkya Shinde, who was also placed under preventive arrest, was released after furnishing a personal bond and surety of ₹5,000, with an undertaking to maintain peace and good behaviour for six months, according to a police statement.

The CJP members reached Jantar Mantar on Tuesday by passing through private premises. Police personnel deployed at the site attempted to stop them, but the group allegedly obstructed the personnel in the discharge of their official duties, the police said. Subsequently, Mr. Das, Mr. Ranka and Mr. Shinde were placed under preventive arrest over what the police described as repeated attempts to disturb public peace and violate the law. Their attempts to use social media to instigate others to engage in similar activities were also taken into consideration, the police said.



In judicial custody: CJP leaders Ajinkya Shinde, Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka in New Delhi on Wednesday. REUTERS

They were produced before a Special Executive Magistrate, where proceedings were initiated under Sections 126 and 170 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS). Section 126 empowers an Executive Magistrate to initiate proceedings when there is reason to believe that a person may breach the peace, and to require an undertaking to maintain peace for a period of up to one year. Section 170 empowers the police to arrest a person without a warrant to prevent the commission of a cognisable offence when it cannot otherwise be prevented.

Reacting to the development, CJP founder Abhijit Dipke accused the Narendra Modi government of imposing an "unofficial Emergency", and questioned why party members had been sent to judicial custody over their protest at Jantar Mantar.

"I want to tell Mr. Modi that if you want to impose an Emergency in the country, do it officially. Why are you running an unofficial emergency where people are sent to five days of detention just for waving the national flag at Jantar Mantar?" he said.

'Act of cowardice'

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, said on X, "Waving the Tricolour at Jantar Mantar in a peaceful protest is not a crime. Jailing youth for it is an act of cowardice."

"Students. Youth. Journalists. The INDIA bloc. Different banners, one cause. All protests are one: citizens demanding their constitutional right. Jantar Mantar belongs to the people of India. We will reclaim it," he said.

Youth organisations took out a protest against the jailing of the leaders.

Denotifying Jantar Mantar pushes dissent 'out of sight, out of mind', says plea in SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court may list for hearing on October 26 a petition challenging the denotification of the area near Jantar Mantar as a designated site of protest in the national capital.

Rendering Jantar Mantar inaccessible will push dissent "out of sight and out of mind", the plea said, noting that a protest carried out far from the earshot of ordinary citizens loses much of its practical impact.

The petition by Swaty Singh, appearing through advocate Akanksha Mehra, was successfully registered and numbered on Wednesday. It has arraigned the Union government and the Delhi Police Commissioner as respondents.

The "right to protest is not merely a right to assemble at a designated physical space", the petition said. "It is a right to communicate grievances, express dissent and draw the attention of the public authorities and society at large towards matters requiring redressal," it said.

The authorities have found three alternative sites, but the petition said they are located on the outskirts of the national capital, far away from the corridors of power, Parliament, Supreme Court, Ministries, and public offices of central Delhi.



Site of protest: Jantar Mantar site's proximity to the power centres makes it a highly visible landmark. PTI

Public accessibility

Ms. Singh said the local protest cannot be dismissed as an "inconsequential administrative consideration". The Jantar Mantar site's proximity to the power centres of the state, accessibility to the public, and visibility to the intended audience may directly affect the power of dissent, she added.

"Relocating protests to distant or outlying areas of Delhi, particularly where such relocation materially increases the burden of participation and distances demonstrators from the authorities to whom their grievances are addressed, may substantially diminish the communicative purpose of peaceful assembly," the petition noted.

Ms. Singh said that while the denotification order was imposed with immediate administrative effect, amidst the ongoing protest, the government has not issued the Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for protesters to access the three new venues.

"Thus, the standing order, on its face, alters the existing arrangement without itself setting out a complete mechanism governing access to the new venues," the plea said.

Delhi Metro network was 'fully functional' on Oct. 10, says DMRC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Over 85% of the network remained fully operational and functional for commuters, it said

The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) and its chairperson filed separate affidavits in the Supreme Court on Wednesday, stating that the Metro network remained "fully functional" on October 10, recording 32 lakh passengers.

"There was zero reduction in the total volume of metro operation or the number of train trips," the DMRC said.

Though the DMRC admitted that commuter traffic was "slightly lower" than the typical 58 lakh passengers on a "normal" second Saturday, it attributed the drop to public caution amid protests rather than administrative paralysis. It said ordinary citizens were "compelled to forgo their usual day-to-day activities".

The day saw heavy security crackdowns in the capital against demonstrations demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. Petitioners like CPI (M) general secretary M.A. Baby and advocate Shailendra Mani Tripathi had argued that widespread barricading and station closures violated an October 9 order mandating proportionate movement restrictions.

Defending its actions, the DMRC said entry and exit regulations were limited to 45 of the network's 303 stations on October 10.

"Over 85% of the network (258 stations) remained fully operational, accessible, and functional for commuters," it said.

SC to hear Opposition's plea on SIR, CEC today

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court will hear on Thursday a joint petition filed by Opposition leaders led by Rahul Gandhi seeking a full disclosure of "files, agendas, minutes, notings and objections" recorded by Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi on the special intensive revision (SIR).

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi are presiding over the Bench.

Mr. Gandhi sought an interim direction to suspend the SIR pending consideration and adjudication of the issues raised in the petition in order to protect the rights of eligible electors and preserving the integrity of the electoral process. Petitions challenging the police crackdown on protesters are also listed before the Bench.

Questions raised over police's failure to make prohibitory orders public

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The detention of protesters across the national capital while demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over alleged electoral irregularities has raised questions over the Delhi Police's failure to make publicly available Section 163 prohibitory orders that it says are in force.

The provision empowers an Executive Magistrate to issue written orders when "immediate prevention or a speedy remedy" is necessary to prevent danger to human life or safety, disturbance of public tranquillity, or other specified threats.

A Section 163 BNSS order accessed by *The Hindu*, issued on August 23 by Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP) Ajay Sharma, shows the restrictions are confined to the Parliament Street police sub-division and expressly exclude a specifically demarcated area on Jantar Mantar Road. The order, in force until October 21, prohibits assembly of five or more persons, public meetings, processions, slogan-shouting, and speeches, among other activities.



No clarity: Students being detained during a protest against CEC Gyanesh Kumar in New Delhi on Wednesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Delhi Police sources refused to confirm to *The Hindu* whether separate Section 163 BNSS orders for the other sub-divisions of New Delhi district – Connaught Place, Chanakyapuri and Barakhamba Road – or for the Jantar Mantar area had been made publicly available. They said hoardings had been put up and announcements were being made in these areas informing people that prohibitory orders were in force.

Former Supreme Court judge Abhay S. Oka said making prohibitory orders publicly available was necessary to give effect to the statutory right under Section 163(5) of the BNSS, which allows an aggrieved person to seek their rescission or alteration.

"When sub-section (5) of Section 163 expressly gives liberty to any person aggrieved by prohibitory orders to apply for modification or cancellation, there is a statutory mandate that the orders be published in the public domain. They cannot be kept confidential," Mr. Oka said. He added that public announcements or hoardings merely stating that prohibitory orders were in force would not satisfy this requirement.

Delhi-based advocate Abhinav Sekhri said the lack of public access to such orders was not new.

"For our research [for a report], we got access to a lot of these orders through Right to Information responses," he said. He pointed to the practice of reissuing "cyclostyled" orders as soon as their two-month statutory limit expired.

(With inputs from Vijaita Singh and Lavpreet Kaur)

Cong. slams Shah over 'infiltrators' remark

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Wednesday asked Union Minister Amit Shah to disclose how many alleged infiltrators had been detected, deleted from electoral rolls, and deported following the special intensive revision.

It accused the Centre of invoking the infiltration issue to divert attention from its allegations of large-scale disenfranchisement. Mr. Shah had accused Congress leader Rahul Gandhi of wanting to get infiltrators registered as voters.

"How many *ghuspaithiye* (infiltrators) were detected? How many *ghuspaithiye* were deleted? How many *ghuspaithiye* were deported," Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said.

He asked whether Mr. Shah was suggesting that the nearly 14 crore people allegedly deprived of their rights were infiltrators.

In battle of cultural narratives, Rahul blends Puranic lore and pop culture idioms

NEWS ANALYSIS

Anuj Kumar

One of the key takeaways from Rahul Gandhi's press conference on Monday was his use of *Shivji ki Baraat* to counter the BJP's narrative of top-down command and control with the Opposition's fluid, decentralised style of protest.

Shivji Ki Baraat refers to the highly unusual wedding procession of Lord Shiva as he travelled to marry Goddess Parvati. This event is central to Hindu texts like the Shiva Purana and Tulsidas's *Ramcharitmanas*. By embedding Puranic iconography into a press conference about institutional accountability, Mr. Gandhi challenged the BJP's monopoly on religious symbolism.

It is said Lord Shiva's wedding procession was an unprecedented gathering that brought together entities who were otherwise bitter enemies or social outcasts. With the INDIA alliance partners led by Yadav heirs (Akhilesh and Tejaswi) of Mandal politics on one side and the emerging face of Left politics, Neha Bora, on the other, Mr. Gandhi attempted to translate the Opposition's fight into a multi-polar collective where there is no singular 'leader' on a pedestal.

Counter imagery

The BJP leadership quickly moved to counter the imagery, aggressively reframing the metaphor to fit their established political play book. Top Ministers counter-attacked by invoking polarising terms, calling the alliance a "*Huddangiyo ki Jamaat*" (a congregation of anarchists). Despite the push-back, political observers note that Mr. Gandhi's shift to present internal contradictions as Shaivite imagery of cosmic dissidence is giving the Opposition momentum as the BJP's imagination of a moral kingdom of Ram Rajya develops cracks.

By stating that the movement is "*Tandav*, Lord Shiva's dance" and there is "no need for a plan", Mr. Gandhi subverted the BJP's frequent criticism of the Opposition being "disorganised" or "chaotic", recasting their unpredictable moves as an organic, divine, and unstoppable force.

When Mr Gandhi said, "Anyone can join *Shivji ki baraat*... any living creature (*jeev*) can come, we will not stop them," he perhaps implicitly acknowledged the highly unconventional alliance of diverse political forces, ranging from the unyielding street resistance of Left-wing student groups to the fiercely independent Cockroach Janta Party. He addressed the image of a Khichdi (hodgepodge) coalition with no ideological unity and a common goal for the *baraat*: protecting the Constitution and democratic institutions against perceived over-centralisation.



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi helps party chief Mallikarjun Kharge put on a Batman mask during a march in New Delhi. REUTERS

Mr. Gandhi also contrasted the fluidity of the protest with a more rigid political structure, historically which he described as having a designated "king", and an "operator", and where the public followed behind the chariot, suggesting that the public has moved on from the era of Rath Yatras.

While Mr. Gandhi has used the Lord Shiva's symbols inside Parliament, such as showing the *Abhaya Mudra* or posters of deities, to talk about fearlessness, this press conference was different because the metaphor materialised into real-time action on the streets and prime-time television within minutes.

Digital creators responded with Instagram reels of Neha Bora's temple run from R.K. Ashram Marg to Connaught Place with the popular background song, *Jab Zid Par Aa Gayi Parvati* (When Parvati stood her ground) from Hanuman Ansh. The song has been a rage, but by shifting the context, it has come to signify fierce feminine resistance to authority.

Over the years, Faiz Ahmad Faiz's *Hum Dekhenge* has been the default soundtrack of the progressive Leftist movement, but this Navaratri, social media is abuzz with the popular devotional number, *Sabse Bada Tera Naam O Sheronwali* (Suhag), with visuals of women protesters being detained.

Batman connection

At the same time, the Congress IT cell is working on casting Mr. Gandhi as Batman. It started with an "Ask me anything" session on Instagram in August, where a user asked Mr. Gandhi if he was Batman. When Mr. Gandhi was filmed scaling high yellow police barricades, the party's social media team spliced this footage with cinematic clips of Batman overlooking Gotham City, cementing the imagery.

During the march, a supporter passed a Batman mask through the crowd to the bus carrying senior Opposition leaders. Mr. Gandhi posed with the mask and helped Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge try it on as well.

The ruling party accused the Opposition of turning serious debate into a theatrical pop culture stunt, with Minister Jayant Chaudhary posting "Delhi isn't Gotham, and we don't need a dark superhero and Robin" on X.

A young Congress worker said that Gotham City people also believed they did not need a superhero. On a deeper, mythological level, he said, the imagery of Lord Shiva and Batman shows striking parallels.

By deploying both symbols simultaneously during the protests, the party tapped into a shared psychological image of the "righteous outsider" fighting a "compromised institutional framework" to protect ordinary citizens.

INBRIEF



4 Indian airlines cancel flights to Saudi Arabia till October 17

IndiGo, Air India Express, Air India, and Akasa Air on Tuesday announced cancelling flights connecting Saudi Arabian cities in view of the evolving situation in the Gulf country. IndiGo said that flights to and from Riyadh, Jeddah, Dammam and Madinah stand cancelled until October 17. While announcing cancellation of flights to and from Riyadh, Dammam and Jeddah till October 17, Air India said it was closely monitoring and assessing the developments in the region. The airline said it was offering a full refund on cancellation for the affected passengers. Meanwhile, Akasa Air said it has extended the suspension of all flights to and from Riyadh and Jeddah until October 17. PTI

Power bank model banned on flights after fire incident

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has prohibited MOBIKINS MK-PB-04 power bank on all flights to, from and within India. This comes after a power bank on an IndiGo flight from Chandigarh to Chennai exploded inside the overhead bin on October 11, forcing the flight to divert to Hyderabad, where emergency evacuation was carried out. In an airworthiness information circular (AIC) dated September 29, 2026, the DGCA directed airlines and passengers to ensure that the specified power bank is not carried on board aircraft, either as passenger baggage or as cargo. The prohibition covers both checked-in and cabin baggage. The circular cites potential safety risks associated with the device.

SC mandates insurance on offline railway tickets too

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has issued a mandatory directive that tickets sold across counters at every railway station nationwide must include travel insurance coverage identical to online bookings. A Bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R. Mahadevan directed the railway authorities to put the order into effect from October 27, 2026.

The order warned that failure to implement this mechanism would place direct liability squarely on the Railway Board. "At present, only people purchasing tickets online are provided the benefit of insurance coverage upon payment of a nominal additional amount. The court had granted sufficient time to the authorities to devise a mechanism extending such coverage to persons belonging to the lowest strata of society, who, in most cases, purchase their tickets at the railway reservation counters," the court observed, pointing out that the Railways had made no progress on providing insurance cover to all passengers.

The direction was based on a writ petition filed in the aftermath of the June 2023 Odisha train accident.

No order yet on extra 50 days of work for FRA title holders

Adivasis were entitled to additional work under MGNREGA; VB-G RAM G Act, which guarantees 125 days of employment per household in a year, has no tier for beneficiaries of Forest Rights Act

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

Uncertainty continues for Adivasi households holding Forest Rights Act (FRA) titles, who were entitled under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) to an additional 50 days of work over and above the 100-day annual guarantee under the UPA-era law. The new rural employment programme, the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act (VB-G RAM G), which was rolled out on July 1, is yet to issue a notification clarifying the status of this entitlement.

In a reply dated October 6 to an application under the Right to Information Act filed by Chakkradhar Buddha of the National Campaign for People's Right to Information (NCPRI), the Rural Development Ministry said that "no separate order, circular or guideline prescribing any additional wage employment entitlement for FRA title holders under VB-G RAM G has been issued as on date".

The VB-G RAM G Act, 2025, guarantees 125 days of wage employment per rural household in a financial year. It has no separate tier for FRA title holders. Section 5(4) states that the Centre or a State government may provide work beyond the guaranteed days within the limits of its economic capacity. The provision is discretionary and names no specific group. Section 7 allows the Centre, on a State's recommendation, to grant relaxations during natural calamities, including enhanced wage-employment provisioning.



In the absence of a notification, uncertainty continues over work opportunities for Adivasi households holding FRA titles. FILE PHOTO

In the absence of such a notification, uncertainty continues over whether Adivasi households holding FRA titles will receive only 125 days of guaranteed employment, on a par with other beneficiaries across the country, or 175 days, including the additional 50 days of employment available to them under MGNREGA.

Sources in the Ministry said the government would shortly be issuing a notification approving an additional 50 days of work.

"As there are six more months still available in the financial year, FRA beneficiaries can easily avail of the additional 50 days anytime during this period after completing 125 days," a senior Ministry official said.

Under MGNREGA, the additional entitlement began only in January 2014. An additional 50 days of guaranteed work had first been introduced for drought-prone areas in 2012. Even during the UPA regime, it took at least two years of deliberations within the government before the additional guaranteed work was approved.

The implementation of this additional entitlement has also remained patchy. Andhra Pradesh is the only State that performed well.

Data available with the Union Rural Development Ministry for 2025-26 reveal that under MGNREGA, only 15% of the 14 lakh households eligible for 150 days of work availed themselves of the benefit. Odisha had the highest number of registered households at 3,72,089, of which 71,696 availed themselves of the additional days.

Chhattisgarh had 3,20,651 registered households and 36,716 beneficiaries; Madhya Pradesh had 2,21,674 registered households and 29,065 beneficiaries; Andhra Pradesh had 1,70,851 registered households and 36,008 beneficiaries; Tripura had 1,08,532 registered households and 22,251 beneficiaries; and Maharashtra had 96,559 registered households and 8,063 beneficiaries. These six States account for 12.9 lakh of the registered households.

Railway staff to get bonus equivalent to 78 days' wages

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has approved payment of productivity-linked bonus (PLB) of 78 days totalling ₹2,009.61 crore to 11,40,770 railway employees.

Union Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said that the bonus was approved in recognition of "the excellent performance by the Railway staff".

Mr. Vaishnaw said payment of PLB to eligible railway employees is made each year before the Durga Puja and Dasara holidays.

"This year also, PLB amount equivalent to 78 days' wages is being paid to about 11.4 lakh non-gazetted Railway employees. The payment of PLB acts as an incentive to motivate the railway employees for working towards improvement in the performance of the Railways," Mr. Vaishnaw said.

The maximum amount payable per eligible railway employee is ₹17,951 for 78 days. The amount will be paid to various categories of Railway staff, such as Track Maintainers, Loco Pilots, Train Managers (Guards), Station Masters, Supervisors, Technicians, and other Group 'C staff'.

BJP women's wing asks for NCW action on Cong. MP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A high-level BJP Mahila Morcha delegation on Wednesday met National Commission for Women (NCW) Chairperson Vijaya Rahatkar and submitted a memorandum seeking action in the alleged sexual harassment case involving Congress MP and former JNU professor Angomcha Bimol Akoijam.

The delegation was led by Mahila Morcha incharge Daggubati Purandeswari and BJP Mahila Morcha national president Roop Kumari Chaudhary.

Ms. Chaudhary said the delegation had urged the NCW Chairperson to take cognisance of the matter. She also questioned the Congress party's "silence" on the issue.

Bauxite mining proposal in Odisha's Balda hills threatens future of rare ground gecko

Divya Gandhi
BENGALURU

In the crevices of boulders and beneath the rustle of leaf litter in the hills of the Eastern Ghats in Odisha and Andhra Pradesh lives a tiny population of the strikingly-patterned Jeypore ground gecko, which was presumed extinct for 130 years until it was rediscovered in 2010.

Just four individuals of this endangered species have been documented in the past year in Odisha's Balda hills, worryingly, within the site of a proposed bauxite mining project by an Adani-linked group.

The nocturnal gecko, some 3.6 inches long, with a comparatively large head, and a yellow-orange body, was originally documented in 1878 by the British naturalist Richard Henry Beddome. More than a century later, in 2010, herpetologists Ishan Agarwal and Aniruddha Datta-Roy rediscovered a specimen in Odisha's Koraput district.



Facing oblivion: The Jeypore ground gecko was presumed extinct for 130 years until it was rediscovered in 2010. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Later, there were more sightings: one in 2025, and three this year, including one this month. The gecko's behaviour, habits and lifecycle continue to elude scientists.

What is known, however, is that its habitat is fast shrinking. In fact, the habitat where it was first sighted in the 1870s, Potangi in Odisha, has already been lost to bauxite mining by the National Aluminium Company Limited (NALCO), where the animal is believed to be now extinct.

And today, the spectre of Adani's opencast bauxite mine proposal, covering 147 hectares of forest in the Balda hills, within the Nageswari reserve forest, threatens the future of this vulnerable species.

Adivasi uprising

The bauxite mining project has also been the site of much contention among resident Adivasis of the Nageswari reserve forest, who have protested the proposal for the past two years. The Bondo and Porja Adivasis, whose ancestral land this is, lodged a complaint against the Adani-subsidiary Kalinga Alumina Ltd. in February, but to no avail.

"The communities have also applied for forest rights over the hill, which the government has refused to recognise," naturalist Yuvan Aves told *The Hindu*. "There was a demonstration earlier this month too, and when the Adani group flew drones to scope the area, the Adivasi people stopped the exercise, asserting that this is their ancestral land."

Mr. Agarwal said that the gecko is "an ecologically and biogeographically significant species having split from its closest relatives over 20 million years ago." This is a relatively range-restricted species that is only found in high-elevation (900-1,400 metres) forests in the Eastern Ghats. "Anything that threatens their habitat is the major risk. Coffee [though we don't understand to what extent], hydel, mining are all potential threats," he told *The Hindu*.

ED seizes assets worth ₹2,032 cr. of Reliance Power

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has seized assets worth ₹2,032.81 crore belonging to Reliance Power Limited in India under the Foreign Exchange Management Act, the agency said on Wednesday.

The assets include the bank balances of Reliance Power Ltd., and its shareholding in Sasan Power Ltd. Their cumulative value is equivalent to that of foreign exchange held outside India, allegedly in contravention of the Act, according to the ED.

"Investigation was initiated on the basis of information received from the Securities and Exchange Board of India, pertaining to write-offs/provisions aggregating ₹2,101.46 crore made by Reliance Power Ltd. in its books of account. These write-offs were related to overseas investments and advances made to companies in the British Virgin Islands and the Cayman Islands," the ED said.

Meanwhile, Reliance Power Ltd. disputed the allegations, saying it would take all appropriate steps to safeguard its interests, as well as the interests of all its shareholders.

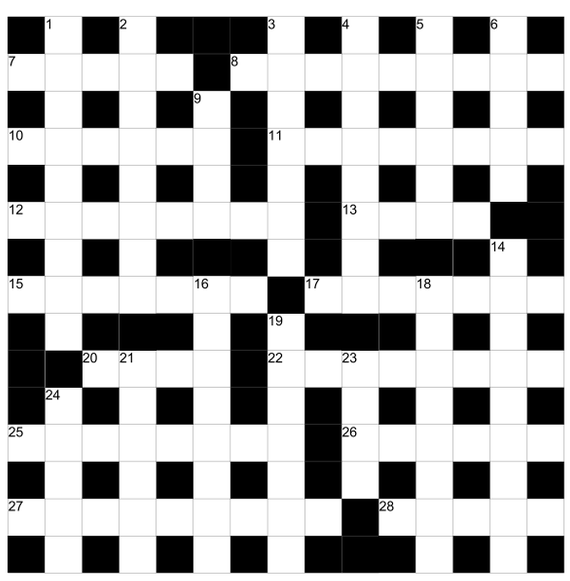
In March, the agency had conducted searches in the same matter. "Investigation has revealed that Reliance Natural Resources Ltd (since merged with Reliance Power Ltd.) raised $300 million through Foreign Currency Convertible Bonds in 2006," it said.

TH CROSSWORD + 14924

(set by Mythical)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



ACROSS

7. Tolerate burn (5)
8. Fighting with others leads individuals nowhere good primarily (9)
10. Some excitement all around? It could make one sick (6)
11. Ill-treats player's family members (8)
12. Attack popular victor when ace returns (8)
13. Be different occasionally! That's good in France (4)
15. Injured kitten ultimately recovered, healed (7)
17. Jogs memory of confused nursemaid after a uniform goes missing (7)
20. Lying about research centre on island somewhere in Indonesia (4)
22. Say, man from Zagreb ordered raincoat (8)
25. Mentioned favour after leader left with communist (8)
26. Bond with judge having lunch (6)
27. A most harsh setter offering sweetener (9)
28. Government control discussed (5)

DOWN

1. Renowned expert to fund books (9)
2. Tense agreement (8)
3. Quietly object to host (7)
4. This group row affected seam bowlers (8)
5. Likely seen going around Presidential Palace (6)
6. Foolish sign painter crossing out every other letter (5)
9. Bill given top quality fruit (4)
14. Notice vehicle near gate needing repair? Good! (9)
16. Resettle girl in Sharjah, perhaps (8)
18. Broke thin reed casually (2,3,3)
19. A scoundrel essentially surveying my school? (7)
21. Rings sound artist in recess (6)
23. Heartily dislike obscenity (4)
24. Basically, brutish evildoer always showing temper (5)

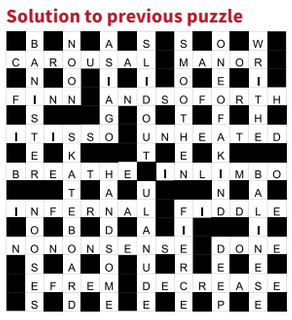
SUDOKU

	7	6						
5			1					
2	8	1				9	5	
	2	8	4	6				
	6			1			2	
				9	7	1	6	
	4	5				3	8	9
					6			7
						2	4	

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

5	7	1	6	8	2	3	4	9
9	4	3	7	5	1	6	8	2
6	8	2	4	3	9	7	5	1
2	9	8	1	4	6	5	7	3
3	5	7	2	9	8	1	6	4
1	6	4	5	7	3	2	9	8
7	2	9	3	6	4	8	1	5
8	3	6	9	1	5	4	2	7
4	1	5	8	2	7	9	3	6

FAITH

Rejection of Vidura's advice

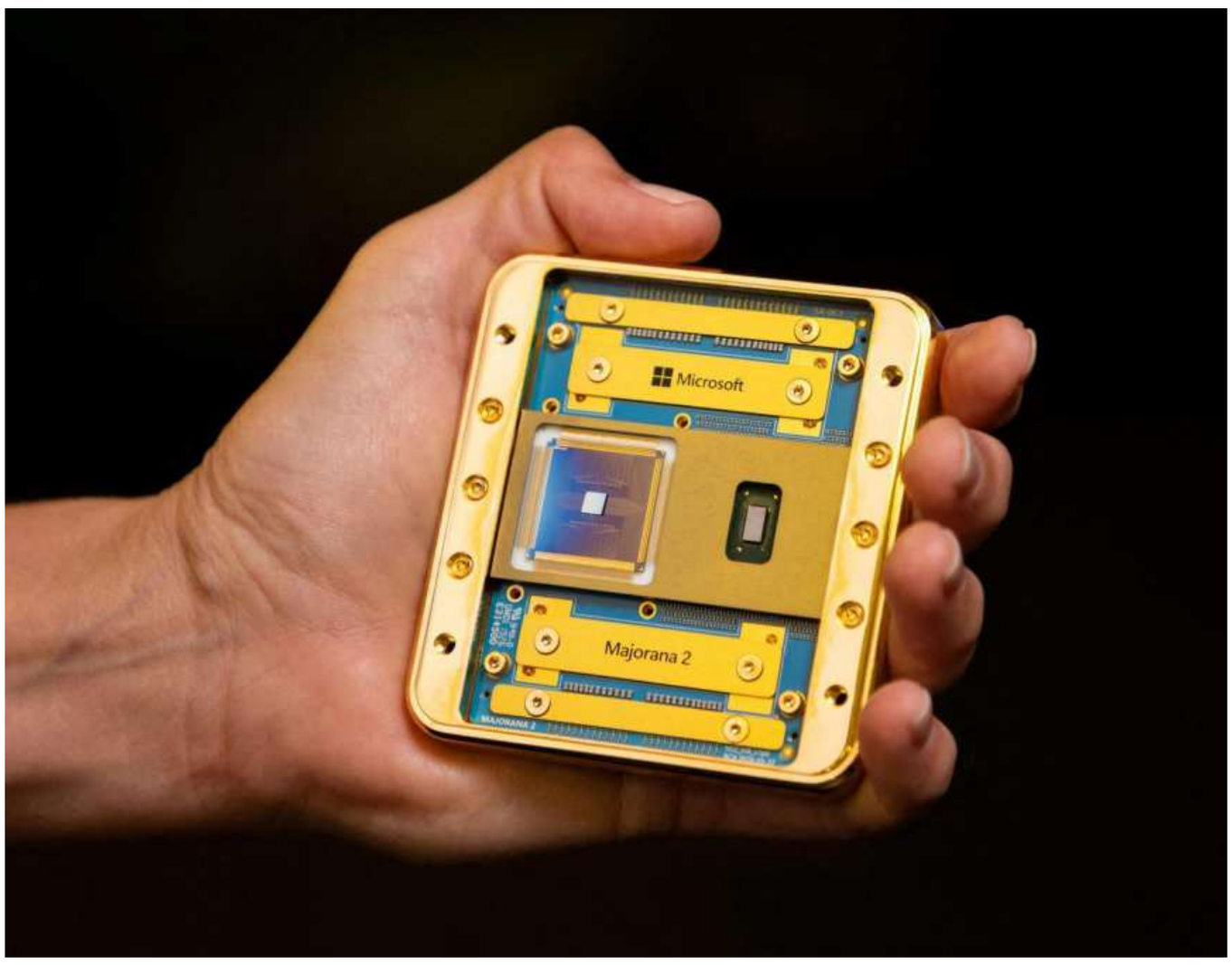
Dhritarashtra was aware that because of his envy, Duryodhana resorted to cruel ways to suppress the Pandavas, said Kidambi Narayanan in a discourse. He knew that Yudhishthira was being invited to play a game of dice when Sakuni was bent on being dishonest. He didn't lift a finger to stop Dushasana, when he pulled Draupadi's saree, with a view to shaming her in court. Because he knew that his sons were unjust, Dhritarashtra was afraid of public reaction. He was also afraid that the sins of his sons would catch up with them. So, he often sought the advice of Vidura, who was known to be level-headed, righteous and knowledgeable in the dharma sastras. Vidura never tired of answering the king's request for help. Every time he was sent for and asked to offer words of counsel, he did so without hesitation. He told Dhritarashtra how his sons should behave, and what his duties as a king were. When the Pandavas and Draupadi left for the forest, Dhritarashtra was agitated fearing that his subjects might revolt. He sent for Vidura, and sought his advice.

Vidura pointed out to Dhritarashtra how unjust his sons had been and that the only way forward was for Dushasana to apologise to Bhima in the very court in which Draupadi had been humiliated. He also must seek Draupadi's forgiveness, said Vidura. As always, Dhritarashtra was unwilling to accept Vidura's advice. He accused Vidura of being partial to the Pandavas, and of having only their welfare in mind. He felt that Vidura's advice was one-sided, and that if he followed what Vidura advocated it would be unfair to his sons. So he told Vidura to leave the court if he chose.

Old doubts linger, yet new Microsoft quantum chip raises the stakes

Not everyone is convinced Microsoft learnt the bigger lesson from its experience with announcing the Majorana 1 chip; University of Pittsburgh professor Sergey Frolov has said Microsoft's previous record has left him unwilling to treat the new work as resting on a well-understood foundation

Vasudevan Mukunth



Microsoft's Majorana 2 quantum computing chip is seen in this undated handout photo. MICROSOFT/REUTERS

In February, the Microsoft Quantum research group announced a new kind of computer processor called Majorana 1. According to the tech giant, the processor contained the world's first topological qubits, built with a new material it called a 'topoconductor'. Majorana 1 contained eight qubits, with Microsoft Quantum saying it would in future hold a million.

The group published its paper in *Nature* the same day, and that stoked the early concerns about what Microsoft Quantum had actually demonstrated.

Foremost, the paper was considerably more circumspect than Microsoft's press release. The researchers had built devices made of indium-arsenide-aluminium and discussed a way to measure, in a 'single shot', the parity of an electronic state, i.e. whether the number of electrons was odd or even in the state, in the wire.

The team called this measurement a "necessary ingredient" for a highly sought after form of quantum computing.

However, there was a significant gap between the scopes of the paper and of the press release, prompting concerns in the scientific community that Microsoft was trying to lay claim to a commercially lucrative technology without first proving that it actually worked.

Zero modes

Quantum computing is a new, more powerful form of computing that scientists believe can solve some problems much better than conventional devices can. However, the quantum bits, or qubits, these machines are based on are notoriously fragile.

A qubit stores information in a quantum state, which can be disturbed by even the slightest interactions with stray heat or stray magnetic fields. Another technology called quantum error correction can compensate but not without imposing additional technological hurdles. Many leading quantum computers encode qubits in superconducting circuits, while others use atoms, ions or light. At least on paper, topological quantum computing shows another way.

In this domain, Microsoft Quantum has been trying to build a quantum computer with qubits based on particles called Majorana zero modes (MZMs). Technically, MZMs are 'emergent quasiparticles'. The physicists Sankar Das Sarma, Roman Lutchyn, and Jay Sau had predicted in 2010 that they would occur at the ends of specially engineered superconducting wires.

Two MZMs separated by some space constitute a particular quantum state, and whether that state is occupied or not can encode information, like 0 and 1. This way, each MZM pair stores information in both particles together.

This is less like one half being stored in each particle and more like both particles storing the information together: many small disturbances affecting only one end cannot destroy the information, yet both ends are required to access it. The space between the two MZMs of a pair is crucial to achieve this.

MZMs also follow some strange rules. For example, carrying out one exchange of MZMs and then another can create a different quantum state than performing the same exchange in the reverse order.

Airtight inference

But a big problem today is to ascertain if a device with the necessary superconducting wires and other parts also has MZMs. This is because there are many impostor states that are easier to create but which lack the MZMs' unusual properties. There is no way to directly spot an MZM with some kind of microscope and claim success. Instead, scientists and engineers have to measure the device's properties in different ways, and from that infer the presence of MZMs.

This inference has to be airtight, and the dispute in the Microsoft case is that its inference is not.

The matter is still on, in fact: on June 2 this year, Microsoft Quantum announced a new processor called Majorana 2 and uploaded a new preprint paper. Here, the team replaced aluminium with lead, whose superconducting state is harder to disrupt, to make the desired state more robust. It also switched to a gallium-antimonide substrate and redesigned the semiconductor stack to reduce disorder.

The upgrade was apparently dramatic: in Microsoft's telling, the topological gap – the energy needed to excite the system out of its protected state – had increased from around 30 microelectron-volts to 70 microelectron-volts. The parity switching time had also increased from a few milliseconds to around 20 seconds.

The group presented this as proof of topological quantum computing's promise because the new numbers were indicative of the encoded information being more robustly protected from disturbances. On the back of these reported advances, the company said it would build a scalable quantum computer by 2029 – a significantly shortened deadline considering how complex the technology still is.

Rebuttal and response

However, not everyone is convinced that Microsoft learnt the bigger lesson from last time. As University of Pittsburgh professor Sergey Frolov has said, Microsoft's previous record has left him unwilling to treat the new work as resting on a well-understood foundation.

MZMs are very difficult to create and detect. For example, researchers from TU-Delft in the Netherlands published a paper in *Nature* in 2018 claiming they had spotted MZMs. But it had to be retracted three years later after independent scientists found problems in the data analysis. In its 2025 paper, the Microsoft Quantum team used the topological gap protocol it had presented in a 2023 paper: a way to use electrical conductance data to identify combinations of magnetic field and gate voltage that are consistent with gapped MZMs. The team then used a technique called radio-frequency interferometry to check one region of the device, and where the team said the data had evidence of parity switching.

But at an American Physical Society meeting a month later, scientists remained sceptical. The Microsoft team had demonstrated one measurement on one wire in the paper and itself presented additional measurements of a different kind, but many physicists still had doubts.

Cornell University professor Eun-Ah Kim said the data was quite weak while Argonne National Laboratory physicist Kartiek Agarwal called the paper's claims premature, even if not deserving to be dismissed. Henry Legg, a lecturer at the University of St. Andrews in Scotland, in particular said the headline data came from a small number of measurements on one device. Then, on June 24 this year, *Nature* published a rebuttal by Dr. Legg alongside a response from Microsoft Quantum (physicist Chetan Nayak was the corresponding author). In his rebuttal, based on his own work over the last year, Dr. Legg contended that Microsoft's device itself may not have been qualified to host MZMs, that the underlying data of how electric currents move in the device appeared consistent with a gapless and highly disordered system, and that the topological gap protocol was sensitive, rather than agnostic, to how a researcher chose to analyse the system.

In response, Nayak et al. disputed Dr. Legg's logic and said its claims were based on the radio-frequency measurements, not the protocol.

Many physicists believe Microsoft's attempts are promising and commend its transparency with data. But many physicists also remain unconvinced that the qubits in Majorana 1 and Majorana 2 are working topological qubits.

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A Thai villager paddles a foam float past a flooded home in Ayutthaya on October 6. AFP

Thailand floods villages to save capital, economic hubs

Agence France-Presse

Stilt houses in villages north of Bangkok are no longer high enough to stay dry as authorities in Thailand deliberately flood riverside communities to spare the capital.

Inside the home of Kamonchanok Sathaphonamonwut, raised more than three metres above the ground in Ayutthaya province, her family of three sleeps on makeshift platforms and cannot use the waterlogged toilet.

Her village has been flooded six years in a row, pushing some to move away, while others have raised their houses higher. "Our area simply cannot cope with this much water anymore," the 34-year-old said, wading through her soaked home. But while authorities prioritise protecting Bangkok and other business hubs from floods, "when it comes to our residential communities, they neglect us", she said.

Thailand experiences flooding every year during the monsoon season, and scientists say human-made climate change has made heavy rain and floods more frequent and severe. After devastating floods in 2011, the government expanded embankments, water gates, and other infrastructure to direct water away from Bangkok, the historic city of Ayutthaya, and industrial zones along the Chao Phraya River, which flows through the capital. The defences have largely kept commercial centres safe, but residents of other areas have been left to fend for themselves. Around 20 km from Ayutthaya's centuries-old temple ruins, a UNESCO heritage site, residents say floods that once reached their knees now rise above their heads in some areas and can take several months to recede.

Office worker Kamonchanok has been forced to commute by boat, and hoist her household appliances and other belongings above the waterline. "All we can do is deal with the consequences," she said.

Thai irrigation department spokesperson Thanet Somboon said climate change, low-lying geography, and recently built embankments that altered the natural flow of the Chao Phraya have contributed to more severe flooding of downstream communities. "Even when water is released from the Chao Phraya Dam at the same rate as before, the impact is greater than it used to be," Mr. Thanet said. And after irrigation channels were completely full of diverted water, he said, authorities had "no choice but to discharge the remaining water downstream". But Mr. Thanet acknowledged that officials may need to review infrastructure to "ensure floodwater can be kept within the intended limits".

As flooding in hard-hit districts has become more severe, many who remain have paid to lift their stilt houses higher and keep their living space dry. Ms. Kamonchanok's family raised their home twice in the 1990s, the second time by 1.5 metres.

The government's flagship fix is a $780-million flood diversion canal, designed to carry 1,200 cubic metres of water – around half the volume of an Olympic-size swimming pool – per second around the bottleneck where the Chao Phraya narrows through Ayutthaya. It is expected to be completed by 2030.

Until then, Ms. Kamonchanok said her community was not even demanding an end to intentional flooding, but rather a cap on water levels and financial support for those whose homes sit below the flood line. "All we're asking for is to be able to live comfortably in our own homes," she said ."Why can't they give us that?"

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

Movie names that are also scientific concepts

Vasudevan Mukunth

Please send in your answers to science@thehindu.co.in

QUESTION 1

In astrophysics, the _____ _____ is the boundary around a black hole beyond which not even light can escape to a distant observer. The film, released in 1997, stars Laurence Fishburne and investigates a spaceship that has mysteriously reappeared near Neptune. Fill in the blanks.

QUESTION 2

Name the effect that describes how extremely small differences in the initial conditions of a system — like water vapour levels, temperature, winds, etc. — can produce drastically different outcomes over time, like a cyclone taking shape or not. In the 2004 film of the same name, a young man is able to travel back in time in a strange way.

QUESTION 3

What is the form of energy transferred between two systems because of a temperature difference called? This transfer happens spontaneously and the form can exist only in transit. The 1995 film with this name is considered to be one of the best crime films of all time.

QUESTION 4

A _____ is an arrangement of numbers or other mathematical objects that allows mathematicians to understand systems of equations. They are central to quantum mechanics, computer graphics, and machine learning — just as the turn-of-the-century film of this name is considered a cornerstone of sci-fi filmmaking. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION #5

The 1958 Alfred Hitchcock classic X is centered on some characters' extreme fear of heights, accompanied by the titular condition. In reality, the condition makes a person feel like they are moving when they are not. Name X.



Visual: Name the film in which this nail-biting scene appears. Its director Alfonso Cuarón said he named the film for a physical entity that played a major role in its plot. WARNER BROS./YOUTUBE

Answers to October 13 questions:

1. American physicist who won the physics Nobel Prize twice – **Ans: John Bardeen**
2. Laureate who won the physics Nobel for inventing optical tweezers – **Ans: Arthur Ashkin**
3. Physicist born Maria Skłodowska who named an element after her homeland – **Ans: Marie Curie**
4. Concept for which Hinton and Hopfield won the 2024 Nobel – **Ans: Machine learning**
5. Superconducting device that shows macroscopic quantum tunnelling – **Ans: Josephson junction**

Visual: **IceCube Neutrino Observatory**

First contact

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For feedback and suggestions
for 'Science', please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Daily page'

Illogical reasons

Delhi's 'logical discrepancy' flags suggest a design that targets Muslims

That the ECI's SIR of electoral rolls has been flawed by design and tuned to exclude genuine electors rather than ensure their full enrolment is now well established. *The Hindu*'s investigation of Delhi's draft rolls and the names that the ECI flagged as "logical discrepancies" shows that the process is not only exclusionary but also insidious. The arbitrary nature of these "discrepancies", especially those relating to family size, suggests that they were chosen to target communities with higher, though declining, fertility rates, for exclusion. Muslims make up 13.6% of Delhi's draft rolls – in line with the 2011 Census – but accounted for 20.3% of those flagged for "logical discrepancies". This number goes up to 30% for those flagged under the five reasons linked to family size. None of these criteria bears on the eligibility of an elector, who should be an Indian citizen, at least 18, ordinarily resident in the constituency and should not be disqualified under the law. Following *Lal Babu Hussein* (1995), a name on an earlier electoral roll has probative value as evidence of citizenship and cannot be struck off without inquiry. The children an elector has, a parent's age at the elector's birth or name spelling are unconnected; neither the ECI's Manual on Electoral Rolls (2023) nor its SIR of 2002-03 provided for such checks.

When the ECI began the SIR in Bihar, the enrolment and claims and objections phases had their infirmities but there was no direct or indirect discrimination by religion. *The Hindu* estimated that 18.4% of those deleted from Bihar's pre-SIR rolls were Muslims, in line with their population share (17.7%, 2011 Census). But in the SIR's Phase 2 in West Bengal, the ECI introduced the "logical discrepancies" check midway. Electors already on draft rolls were flagged on unexplained criteria with ECINET software rather than the statutory Electoral Registration Officers deciding on who got flagged. The impact was severe – 27 lakh electors were deleted following adjudication by judicial officers, after being flagged overwhelmingly for "logical discrepancies"; 22 lakh appealed but just 1,607 electors were reinstated in time for the vote. By September, nearly 93% of the 1.26 lakh appeals that were decided had restored electors to the rolls – an indication of large-scale disenfranchisement before the vote. A sample-based analysis of those excluded after adjudication estimated a much higher share of Muslims than their population share. The same process has now been carried over to Phase 3, including Delhi, where *The Hindu*'s investigation shows a clear skew against Muslim electors. The Supreme Court must now halt the SIR, as a process built on arbitrary criteria with no basis in electoral law, and which discriminates against specific communities, should not be allowed to firm up electoral rolls.

Drugs and bullets

Punjab is seeing a rise in narcotrafficking and targeted killings

A chemist has been charged with killing anti-drug-trafficking activist Parvinder Singh Jhota after his allegedly illegal drug business came under threat. Separately, social media influencer Mad Sandhu was allegedly the victim of a premeditated, transnational syndicate hit that used interstate escape routes. Both events in Punjab involved digital platforms and both events expose a dire gap in public safety. While Mr. Jhota's alleged murderer was a local chemist, the macro-level drug trade in Punjab is intertwined with gangster networks, with the cross-border drug smuggling known to be a key source of illicit funds. Together with a string of targeted killings of police personnel and local politicians, the incidents depict a Punjab caught between local drug trafficking and citizens resorting to vigilantism and crime syndicates carrying out assassinations with disquieting ease. Some events have also raised suspicions of cross-border support and a demand to involve enforcement agencies. The AIIMS Magnitude of Substance Use in India survey estimated that in 2017-18 – the latest year for which it is available – 1.28% of Punjab's population aged 10-75 years had an opioid dependence, versus 0.26% nationally. NCRB data also recorded 106 drug overdose deaths in 2024 versus 89 in 2023, in Punjab, likely an undercount since attribution depends on medical certification and excludes long-term complications and unhygienic habits associated with drug use.

Punjab's geopolitical location renders it an important entry point and market, with the security apparatus hampered by smugglers using multiple transport modes. The Global Initiative Against Transnational Organized Crime reported in June that India's pharmaceutical and chemicals industries also provide bad actors with ample opportunities to divert controlled substances or precursors for illicit use. The State's 'Yugh Nashian Virudh' campaign of 2025 has also claimed 68,850 arrests of alleged traffickers and the attachment or confiscation of assets valued ₹319 crore. However, cases registered differ from convictions and asset attachment differs from forfeiture. Mr. Jhota's hostile tactics also enjoyed public support, and authorities need to examine why the people are overlooking formal reporting channels. Under its narcotics policy, the State has to reduce the availability of harmful drugs, disrupt wholesale supply chains, identify corrupt facilitators, and expand access to rehabilitative care. Paralleling investigations into the coordination of targeted killings, an anti-trafficking strategy must also probe the financing and logistics of networks, to dismantle institutional collusion, and better protect threatened individuals.

A split verdict, faltering remedies and people's power



Kaleeswaram Raj

A lawyer who argued in support of the Petitioners in Anoop Baranwal (2023) and Dr. Jaya Thakur (2026)

Jaya Thakur underscores the limits of judicial intervention and the enduring power of people's movements to defend the Constitution

In *Dr. Jaya Thakur vs Union of India*, a two-judge Bench of the Supreme Court of India was faced with a challenge to the 2023 law governing the appointment of the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and Election Commissioners (ECs). On September 23, 2026, the Court delivered a split verdict. Justice Dipankar Datta held that, since a Constitution Bench in *Anoop Baranwal* (2023) had settled the constitutional position on the mechanism for selecting the CEC and the ECs, the challenge to the 2023 Act needed to be examined in light of the principles laid down in that judgment. The *Baranwal* approach is simple and straightforward: a committee with executive predominance cannot be entrusted with selecting impartial umpires such as the CEC and the ECs. A three-member committee comprising the Prime Minister and another Union Minister clearly demonstrates such executive predominance.

Therefore, the law governing the selection and appointment of the CEC and the ECs must consciously avoid these vices. Justice Satish Chandra Sharma, however, held that, given the importance of the issues involved, the case should be referred to a larger Constitution Bench. After delivering separate and divergent opinions, the judges also passed a common order expressing their desire for an expeditious hearing of the case by a Constitution Bench.

There will be a further delay

The net result of the present order is that a decision on the validity of the legislation governing the appointment of the CEC and the ECs will take further time. A statute that is, on the face of it, illegitimate and unconstitutional will have an extended lifespan solely because of the reference ordered on the basis of Justice Satish Chandra Sharma's opinion. This law, as it is now evident, envisages a Prime Minister's Committee to select the CEC and the ECs, with the Prime Minister and the Cabinet Minister chosen by him forming two-thirds of the Committee, making the Opposition leader's presence merely ornamental.

Had this Bench struck down the controversial law on its own, it would have radically altered India's electoral and judicial history, particularly at a time when people at large are sceptical of electoral institutions and the electoral process. That did not happen. The legitimacy of the 2023 law and the decisions of the Commission are now being questioned by Opposition parties and others, including the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP). Protests are mounting across the country, with many people calling for the resignation of the Chief Election Commissioner, Gyanesh Kumar.

The impact

This demand has a strong moral basis. However, replacing an individual alone cannot provide a permanent solution to systemic flaws. The Court has failed to take up the issue in time, and the present order referring the matter to a larger Bench in Dr. Jaya Thakur will, in effect, amount to an institutional confession of this failure. The statute that overturns the *Baranwal* principle and grants the CEC and the ECs lifelong immunity for their acts and words while in the office, needs to be repealed. A fresh law that incorporates the principle of a neutral body selecting the CEC and the ECs, thereby ensuring neutral umpires in the Commission, should be put in place. It is equally important to revisit the controversial revision of electoral rolls and undo its consequences.

The order in Dr. Jaya Thakur contains certain political and moral lessons. Although it does not decide the challenge, some of Justice Datta's observations are significant. The judge quoted Dr. B.R. Ambedkar's speech of October 28, 1951: "We also find that the Government servants are influencing the elections in favour of the party which is feeding them and their dependents. No less a personality than Dr. Shyama Prasad Mukherjee, at the inaugural session of the Bhartiya Jan Sangh at Delhi recently, openly charged the Government servants of helping the Congress and thereby nullifying the elections from being free and fair. ..... If Parliamentary Democracy fails in this country and it is bound to fail for the reasons mentioned by me, the only result will be rebellion, anarchy and Communism".

History magnifies and inverts reality, inviting the ruling dispensation, which claims the legacy of Shyama Prasad Mukherjee, to confront its own mirror image. Today, amid institutional capture and what is described as centrally orchestrated mass disenfranchisement, Dr. Ambedkar's warning is all the more relevant.

The split judgment has become controversial for another reason as well. The fact that Justice Satish Chandra Sharma's son has served as an empanelled standing counsel for the Election Commission before the Madhya Pradesh High Court raises the possibility of a conflict of interest.

The judge's failure to disclose this association at any point has invited speculation about the impartiality of the adjudicative process. This shatters the moral and even legal foundation of Justice Sharma's order referring the matter to a Constitution Bench, thereby further delaying a decision on the case. Recently, petitions have been filed in the Court for recalling and nullifying Justice Sharma's order. In *Rupa Ashok Hurra vs Ashok Hurra* (2002), a Constitution Bench had indicated that failure on the part of a judge to disclose his connection with the subject-matter or the parties would vitiate the judgment, warranting a revisit.

The Bangalore Principles of Judicial Conduct state that "a judge shall avoid impropriety and the appearance of impropriety in all of the judge's activities". They also stipulate that "a judge shall not participate in the determination of a case in which any member of the judge's family represents a litigant or is associated in any manner with the case". The Restatement of Values of Judicial Life, adopted by the Court in May 1997, contains similar prohibitions.

Beyond the courts

Now, back to the 2023 law. As the country's history has shown, political struggles can have a larger dimension than judicial proceedings. As regarding the draconian laws, the Terrorist and Disruptive Activities (Prevention) Act (TADA) was allowed to lapse and the Prevention of Terrorism Act (POTA) was repealed by the Centre, even though they had earlier received the Court's endorsement.

The National Emergency (1975-77) was upheld by the Court in judgments, including the infamous ADM Jabalpur case (1976), which upheld the suspension of fundamental rights. Ultimately, the people voted Mrs. Gandhi's regime out of power in the subsequent election. Likewise, the controversial farm laws were repealed by Parliament in 2021 following massive protests.

In short, a political and moral reading of the split verdict in *Dr. Jaya Thakur* takes us beyond the Court to recognise the Constitution's potential for survival through peaceful people's movements.

India's China+1 lessons lie within its own States



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Karnataka and Tamil Nadu are leading examples of how industrial ecosystems attract global manufacturers

"Don't look at India – look at what's happening with specific States," a veteran investor told these writers in one of 50 interviews with senior industry executives, policymakers and experts for a 2026 study at the East Asian Institute on how global firms are reworking their China+1 plans.

However, the national conversation tends to run the other way. Every few months, someone advises India to study Vietnam's industrial parks, Mexico's nearshoring or Poland's supply chains. Meanwhile, two instructive case studies sit right at home – in Tamil Nadu and Karnataka. Global firms do not choose "India" as a homogenous monolithic edifice. They choose a State, and with it, the land, power supply, approvals, workers and suppliers.

Two States, their approaches

At Sriperumbudur, near Chennai, Foxconn employs tens of thousands of people assembling iPhones. Tata Electronics has expanded at Hosur. In January 2026, the Centre approved projects in Tamil Nadu under its Electronics Components Manufacturing Scheme (ECMS), including mobile-phone enclosure units by Yuzhan Technology, a Foxconn-linked firm, and Tata Electronics. These are commitments rather than finished factories, but they reflect the advantages of an industrial ecosystem that has taken decades to build.

None of this began with China+1. Tamil Nadu invested in technical education, built an automobile and components industry around Chennai, and developed the suppliers, skills and administrative experience that new manufacturers look for. Several investors told us that policy continuity is essential and that commitments must be honoured regardless of political turnover. That is now being tested following the change of government in Tamil Nadu in May 2026. One academic respondent argued that Tamil Nadu would have done well irrespective of China. Its industrial base took four or five decades to build; no announcement of an industrial park or round of subsidies can conjure that up. Karnataka followed a different path. Bengaluru began with software and engineering talent, and not Chennai's automobile base. Foxconn's 300-acre campus at Devanahalli, where women reportedly form about 80% of the workforce, aims to create around 50,000 jobs. Tata Electronics took over Wistron's iPhone plant at Narsapura, in a deal agreed in late 2023, and has grown rapidly since.

Tamil Nadu faces limits in land, power and labour, and relies on migrant workers from the northern and central States. It is now seeking to move beyond labour-intensive assembly towards more capital-intensive manufacturing and innovation-led exports.

National policy, State-level delivery

National incentives are integral, too. One manufacturer explained the combined effect of tariffs and production-linked incentives (PLI): "If the duty is 20 per cent and I get a PLI of 6 per cent, competitors cannot compete with me. This is working right here." The PLI scheme for large-scale electronics manufacturing ended on March 31, 2026, and the Cabinet approved a successor on July 15. In January, the Centre cleared 22 proposals under the ECMS, worth ₹41,863 crore and expected to create 33,791 direct jobs across eight States. The Centre describes this spread as "geographically balanced industrial growth". In March, the Cabinet approved easing Press Note 3, which introduced curbs in 2020 on investment from countries sharing a land border with India. These measures help attract investment, but whether that investment takes root depends on what individual States can offer. The factory still has to come up somewhere.

Still, Tamil Nadu ranks only fifth in the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade's (DPIIT) data on foreign direct investment (FDI) equity inflows for October 2019 to March 2026, accounting for about 6%. This is behind Maharashtra (31%), Karnataka (21%), Gujarat (15%) and Delhi (13%).

However, DPIIT records FDI against the State in which the receiving company has its head office, rather than where the money is spent. So, the figures tell us little about where factories are being built.

Assembly is only the first step. One electronics executive told us that "very few components are manufactured in India" and that there is still a "huge reliance on China for major parts and supply chains". Backward linkages remain thin. Another respondent said his firm had set a billion-dollar target for sourcing in India but, after two or three years, had managed to source "about 600 million out of that". Such ecosystems cannot be built in a hurry: "Value addition is a process which takes time – it is a four-to-five-year process."

Electronics exports touched about $48 billion in 2025-26, while imports stood at about $116 billion. Although export growth is impressive, the trade gap suggests that India still has considerable ground to cover in component manufacturing. One executive described the exports as "assembled products with 20 per cent inputs in India".

India's industrial divide

Concentration also carries risks. One respondent said growth is "largely happening in the southern and western parts, not in the most populous States such as Bihar, Chhattisgarh and Jharkhand".

Spreading subsidies thinly will not, by itself, replicate Tamil Nadu's supplier networks or Karnataka's technical labour pool. The key questions are what these States did to prepare land, train workers, clear approvals, nurture suppliers and retain investors, and which of these measures can be replicated, and what rests on decades of accumulated capacity.

India's China+1 debate keeps looking abroad for a model, even as some of the most instructive factories have been coming up all along on the outskirts of Chennai and Bengaluru.

This article draws on 50 interviews for the EAI Special Report, "India, China, and the 'China+1' Strategies of Global Firms" (September 2026), and on P.S. Srinivas, Frank N. Pieke and Alfred Schipke, "India, China and the China+1 Strategy", Global Policy (2026)

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Grand goals, ground reality

On completing 25 years in power, the Prime Minister has set ambitious goals: making India one of the world's three largest economies, venturing into space, achieving Atmanirbhar Bharat, turning India into a global manufacturing hub and hosting the Olympics. The new slogan is "We can do it". We certainly can. But these goals do little to address the immediate concerns of ordinary citizens. While economic growth has created billionaires and numerous multimillionaires, it has failed to ease the common man's daily struggles. With space opening up to private players, public resources could further enrich them, while the common man will have to be content watching rockets being launched. Atmanirbhar Bharat remains an aspiration, with India still dependent on China for critical imports. The ambition to become a global manufacturing hub is welcome, but industrial growth has yet to generate adequate employment or move decisively beyond assembly to domestic production. Hosting the Olympics, too, seems misplaced when millions struggle to access basic necessities. A leader's greatness should be measured not merely by years in office or grand ambitions, but by how many people are freed from material hardship.

A.G. Rajmohan,
Anantapur, Andhra Pradesh

Protest grounds

It is a calculated move to say citizens may protest anywhere, as long as nobody in power will hear them. Jantar Mantar mattered because it sat near Parliament, and its replacements are four, 13 and 15 kilometres away (October 13). Distance alone might be defended, but the details are worse. Ramlila Maidan, the nearest, reportedly has just three dates, all in the last week of December, with an initial booking cost of over ₹1.21 lakh. Jantar Mantar had no comparable fee. A right to protest that must be booked months ahead and paid for in lakhs is a right for the well-funded, not the aggrieved. Students, farmers and workers protest because they have little, and they cannot buy their way to a hearing. Call it an order on venues if you like. In effect, it prices dissent out of the capital, then points to the fine print to say nothing was banned.

Yashvi Patel,
Anand, Gujarat

The gaps in health care

Modern medicine increasingly suffers from a "tunnel vision" approach. The result is fragmented care, where prescriptions are issued in isolation. Equally troubling is the growing reliance on lab reports, with doctors rarely examining patients. Strengthening primary health care, expanding geriatric medicine and fostering communication among specialists can restore trust and safety.

H.N. Ramakrishna,
Bengaluru

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Satyagraha for Constitution-as-commons



Kalpana Kannabiran

Advanced Fellow, Vienna Centre for Advanced Studies, University of Vienna. Views expressed are personal

The events unfolding on the streets of India signal the emergence of a new language of citizenship and a new language of the Constitution. This has been in the making over the past decade and a half. It has taken its time as fashioning a new language and grammar of justice is a process that has to distil public anger against the criminal dispossession by this government. The public face of criminal dispossession brazenly glares down at us: from dwellings and homes, savings, education, and now voting rights.

This is the time when it all comes together – through the fearless confrontation of young protesters with a disproportionately weaponised police; when only those political leaders, who are out on the streets engaging with the armed state in the same manner in which these (extra)ordinary protestors are, retain public credibility and legitimacy; when lawyers preparing to defend resisters (and themselves) know that they will be huddled into vans and booked for practising their profession. This is the time when self-styled monarchs who took possession of their seats of power, grabbed through a daylight robbery of votes, can no longer sit on them, but instead hide behind them, cowering in fear.

This is also the time when judges repeat endless platitudes about how the only protests deserving of judicial attention are 'lawful protests', and assert meekly (within the enclosure of the court) that they are bound by 'judicial discipline' in considering the lawful right to bail for prisoners such as Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam. They make this assertion without stopping to reflect on the unlawful mayhem let loose by the 'rulers' against whom 'lawful protest' is an oxymoron. How does one 'lawfully' challenge the government's politics of maiming, when what has been maimed is the law and courts? To protest is unlawful under authoritarianism; it is lawful in a constitutional democracy. The ruling *diktat* has labelled the common citizen as an *andolanjeevi* – a new extra-statutory category of criminal – who stands accused of the crime of being a citizen who knows their rights. That judges and courts fail to redefine the fundamental meaning of 'judicial discipline' and 'lawful public action' at a time when the Constitution is under siege is tragic.

> The resisters out on the streets today are those who hold Gandhi's talisman and Ambedkar's Preamble in their fight to restore to the people of this country control over their lives

Duty to the nation

This is the country where satyagraha was born and takes new forms at different times. We have now reached a turning point as a country. This fire in our belly must be quelled; not through the use of pellet guns, lathis, and courtly intimidations, but through peaceful protest. It is our birthright.

The Constitution is our commons. It provides the normative ethical framework for citizenship and shared humanity. It speaks to a just future that guarantees dignity, self-respect, autonomy and solidarity while being mindful of discrimination and structural violence, that must be eliminated. Dignity and shared humanity lie at its core – a guarantee of citizenship as birthright. This idea of the 'Constitution-as-commons' helps in bridging different pathways to imagine an idea of justice. In elaborating on this, we need to bring together popular imaginations of justice that we see opening out before us, predicated on the constitutional convivialities made possible by this popular uprising and its precursors.

Courts and judges need to understand this 'constitutional jurisprudence from the streets' and its interpretive methods through a welcoming acknowledgement of the pedagogic import of this collective constitutionalism. This shift in the country has been nothing short of a glimpse at a utopia; therefore, it is important, theoretically and politically, to trace the contours of this possibility – not just for India, but through the Indian experience for a more holistic, pluriversal understanding, without losing sight of the fact that justice is always spatially rooted. That space is now no longer the reductionist enclosure of the court, nor even the fortified monument that is Parliament, but the 'outside'. The streets, under the open skies, is where the Constitution resides today.

Conviviality and the cultural politics of care, as the conscientious resisters demonstrate to us today, can only be located in the context of civic resistance against state violence in India. This politics of care, of which protest and resistance is part, challenges crimes by the state. The resisters out on the streets today are those who hold Gandhi's talisman and Ambedkar's Preamble in their fight to restore to the people of this country control over their lives.

The myth of 'unskilled' labour



Vasudevan Mukunth

According to the Safe in India Foundation, unskilled workers earning under ₹8,000 a month in the automotive sector lost 2.27 fingers per accident on average in 2024 versus 1.54 fingers for skilled workers earning more than ₹20,000. Earlier this year, thousands of industrial workers protested their stagnant wages across Noida and New Delhi. The Uttar Pradesh government responded by giving 'unskilled' workers an interim hike of ₹13,690 a month and 'skilled' workers ₹16,868, despite both groups facing the same inflation.

Based on assessing migrant labourers in Keralam's construction and hospitality sectors, the International Institute of Migration and Development, Thiruvananthapuram, has estimated that 'unskilled' workers experienced 40% more wage theft than skilled workers. Factories often use the label 'unskilled' to justify withholding annual increments, health benefits, and safety training. The Safe in India Foundation report attributed the higher severe injury rate among 'unskilled' workers to employers often tasking such workers with operating dangerous power press machines without adequate training or safety measures. Contractors likewise deny construction workers personal protective equipment and often deny the final month's pay knowing labourers lack legal recourse, and exclude sanitation workers from safety protocols in hazardous occupations.

In fact, the 'unskilled' status is one the state sustains rather than what naturally arises in society. Across sectors, supposedly 'unskilled' workers are expected to have skills such as handling construction materials, coordinating physical work, identifying defects or irregularities in finished products, using hand and power tools effectively, aligning and placing materials accurately, maintaining tolerances during repetitive production, troubleshooting routine production issues, responding appropriately to process issues, carefully handling human waste, working safely in confined spaces, and recognising hazardous gases and other dangerous conditions, among many others.

> The 'unskilled' status is one the state sustains rather than what naturally arises in society

Stratified labour market

'Skill' in India has become an occupational as well as a social category: workers may acquire a considerable amount of embodied knowledge through experience yet remain 'unskilled' in the eyes of institutions because they lack the formal credentials used to recognise, and pay for, skill. India's labour market also remains stratified along caste, class, gender, and, increasingly, migration lines, influencing which forms of labour are considered 'skilled', and so remunerative. The informalisation of jobs – such as municipal corporations hiring contractors to hire sanitation workers on contracts – has also weakened the relationship between competence and occupational status. Ultimately, economic production is sustained on the engagement of millions of workers whose job security it fails to improve.

The Code on Wages requires governments to account for a worker's skill level when fixing minimum wages, together with geographical area, whether the work is arduous or hazardous, and so on. The wage schedules of the Union government then assign floors for workers performing otherwise comparable work. In agriculture, thus, the daily rates in September were ₹528 for unskilled work, ₹578 for semi-skilled work, ₹627 for skilled work, and ₹694 for highly skilled work (in urban centres with the highest costs of living).

Per the government, 'unskilled' agricultural work encompasses weeding and manually watering crops and requires 'only' physical effort and no training or judgment. 'Highly skilled' work, however, demands advanced technical expertise, like calibrating a combine harvester or managing pest outbreaks. But weeding and irrigation also involve learned techniques such as identifying weeds, assessing soil conditions, using tools without damaging plants, and planning work according to weather conditions.

Yet the way India classifies skills, compounded by its preference for institutional recognition, disproportionately concentrates 'unskilled' workers in informal jobs. And the classification is self-reinforcing: lower wages reduce workers' ability to obtain institutional qualifications or avoid precarious employment while precarious employment makes employers less inclined to invest in their workers' training and safety.

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What 107 innings reveal about the Smriti-Shafali opening pair

In their last 15 innings, Shafali's strike rate exceeded 170 and Mandhana's 150, career highs over any 15-innings stretch

DATA POINT

Kapil Gupta

India's new T20I captain Smriti Mandhana and vice-captain Shafali Verma have added 4,080 runs together as openers, 50% more than any other pair in women's T20Is.

On October 6, Smriti was named India's white-ball captain and Shafali her deputy in T20 Internationals (T20Is). India's two leaders are also its openers.

When India meets Zimbabwe in Raipur from October 16, they will face the first ball together. Their partnership is already the most productive in the format. Ball-by-ball data for every women's T20I till October 7 show that in 107 innings since 2019, the two have added 4,080 runs for the first wicket, averaging 39.2 runs per dismissal at 8.34 runs an over.

Australia's Alyssa Healy and Beth Mooney are second with 2,715 runs in 84 innings; the UAE's Esha Oza and Theertha Satish third with 2,588.

The Indian pair also has 32 stands of 50 or more, 12 more than any other pair, and a shared-record six century stands.

The lead is recent: the Indian line steepens from 2025, just as the Australian one stops **(Chart 1)**.

Quick and reliable

Chart 2 compares the 31 opening pairs with at least 20 innings together. A typical pair averages 26 runs per dismissal at under seven an over.

Among the 10 pairs with 1,000-plus runs, none scores faster. England's Danni Wyatt and Sophia Dunkley come closest (8.23 an over) but average 28; South Africa's Laura Wolvaardt and Tazmin Brits average 44.4 but score at 6.85. Only Oman's pair, over just 20 innings, is ahead on both counts. The pairing has changed Smriti too: with Mithali Raj, she opened at 7.07 an over; with Shafali, 8.34.

A pair can average more by surviving longer or by scoring faster. The Indian pair lasts 28 balls per wicket against 25 for other established pairs, but scores over one and a half runs an over faster **(Table 1)**. Of their 11 extra runs per wicket, about seven come from speed and four from staying in longer.

The gap is sharpest in the powerplay: 8.4 an over against 5.8 for other openers, about 15 extra runs in six overs, with boundaries off 22.7% of balls, twice the rate of others. Survival barely differs: 26% of their stands last six overs, against 23%. Bowlers dismiss them as often as any good pair; they just cannot stop the runs first.

After a dip in 2023, when they scored at 7.04 an over, the pair has averaged 48 runs an innings at 9.27 an over since January 2025, against 34 at 7.91 before **(Chart 3)**. Their 973 runs in 2026 are the most in any year.

India won 60 of the 100 completed matches in which this pair opened, but their results varied sharply with the size of the opening stand. When the pair added fewer than 20 runs, India won 51% of matches; for stands of 20-49, the figure was 50%. But once they crossed 50, India won 24 of 29 matches (83%). Until the stand reaches 50, India's win rate barely shifts; beyond it, their chances improve sharply.

Added responsibilities

The appointment puts India's most crucial phase in the hands of its leaders, but carries a risk. In 18% of their innings together, both fell for under 15, leaving India without its captain and vice-captain early. Yet in 65% of innings, at least one scored 30 or more.

Both are currently scoring faster than ever. In their last 15 innings, Shafali's strike rate exceeded 170 and Mandhana's 150, career highs over any 15-innings stretch. The Zimbabwe series will show whether leadership changes their tempo.

Partnership goals

The data for the charts were sourced from Cricsheet (cricsheet.org) ball-by-ball records of women's T20 Internationals till October 7. Run rates use legal deliveries. Win figures exclude ties and no-results

Kapil Gupta is an Assistant Professor of Decision Sciences and Operations Management at IIM Kozhikode



CHART 1: Cumulative opening partnership runs over time for the six most prolific pairs in women's T20Is. Each step represents a partnership

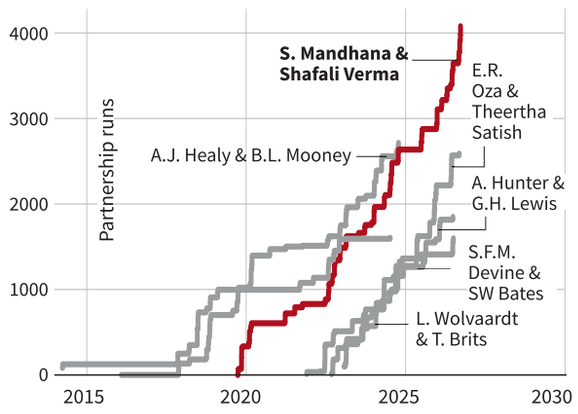


CHART 3: Opening-partnership runs by calendar year, alongside the scoring rate and number of innings. Blue bars represent 2025 and 2026 (through October 7)

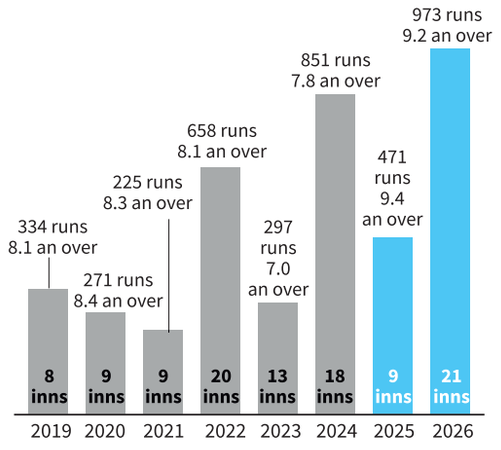


CHART 2: Runs per dismissal versus runs per over. Each circle represents an opening pair with at least 20 innings together. Circle size indicates total runs, while the axes show average runs per dismissal and runs per over. Dashed lines mark the typical pair

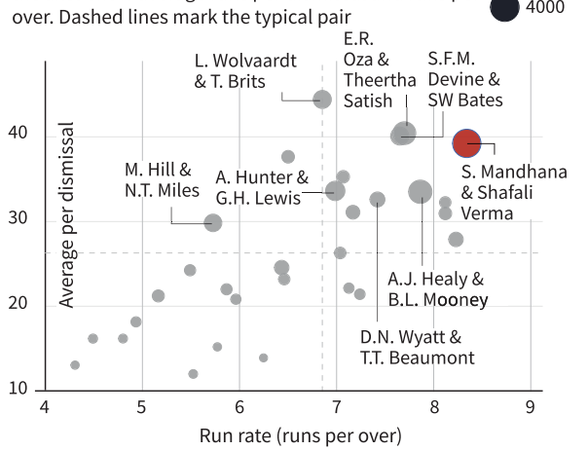


TABLE 1: Comparison of the Smriti-Shafali partnership with other established opening pairs, covering balls faced per wicket, scoring rate and runs per dismissal

Measure	Smriti-Shafali	Other openers
Whole partnership		
Balls faced per wicket	28.2	25.2
Runs per over	8.34	6.79
Runs per dismissal	39.2	28.5
Powerplay (first six overs)		
Powerplay runs per over	8.4	5.8
Powerplay balls hit for four or six	22.7%	11.3%
Powerplay dot balls	46.5%	56.7%
Stands still unbroken after six overs	26%	23%

Note: Powerplay figures count only balls bowled while the opening stand was intact. "Other openers" refers to the other 30 pairs with at least 20 innings together for whole-partnership figures, and all other opening pairs for powerplay figures

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 15, 1976

'Nobody for President' campaign in U.S.

San Francisco, October 14: The 1976 U.S. Presidential campaign is not all Jimmy Carter, Gerry Ford, television debates and fundraising dinners. There's another candidate nobody has yet seen, not even his supporters.

Confetti and tickertape rain down on an open car as it arrives with nobody in the back seat. Nobody is the evening's speaker. Nobody is introduced.

When the cheering dies away, a set of chattering clockwork teeth is placed on the speaker's lectern and clatters on for three minutes.

This is the "Nobody for President" campaign now going into its final weeks with a coast-to-coast tour starting here and ending up in New York on election day, November 2.

Who is behind it? "Nobody" answers campaign organiser Huge Romney, a former poet who calls himself Wavy Gravy.

"We think the office (of President) is ridiculous", he explained in an interview. "I think nobody should have that much power and I want nobody to run my life."

Mr. Gravy claims that Democratic candidate Jimmy Carter may be a tacit supporter of the "Nobody for President" movement.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 15, 1926

Imperial Indian mail

As there was no issue dated October 15, 1926, from the issue dated October 14, 1926

The following is from "The Statesman" of the 13th: A new era as regards comfortable and expedient long-distance railway travelling in India will commence next month, when the East Indian Railway Overland mail train will be replaced by a magnificent train, the Imperial Indian Mail, which, with its handsome colour design of Royal blue and gold, will undoubtedly attract admiring attention throughout its journey from Calcutta to Bombay and vice versa.

Two trains, embodying the latest ideas in luxury travel, are being constructed – one by the East Indian Railway in their Carriage and Wagon Workshops at Lillooah, and the other by the Great Indian Peninsula Railway at Matunga.

'The Statesman' understands that the first train will be sent to Bombay in time to convey to Calcutta.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of households in Rajasthan awaiting tap connections

44 in lakh. Former Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot accused the BJP government of failing to implement Jal Jeevan Mission effectively, claiming that 44 lakh households were still awaiting tap water connections. He said work on 90% of drinking water projects had come to a standstill. PTI

India's trade deficit with China from January to Sept.

105.93 in $ billion. India's trade deficit with China crossed $100 billion in the first nine months of this year, even as Indian exports grew by 40%, sustaining their upward momentum amid a continued surge in Chinese exports. PTI

Railway employees for whom bonuses were approved by Cabinet

11 in lakh. Payment of productivity-linked bonus (PLB) to eligible railway employees is made each year before the Durga Puja/Dusshera holidays. "This year also, PLB amount equivalent to 78 days' wages is being paid to about 11.40 lakh non-gazetted Railway employees," the government said. PTI

Amount mobilised by the World Bank for job creation in India

36 in $ billion. The World Bank Group said it has helped mobilise $36 billion over the last four years for development across sectors and to support efforts to boost investment and create jobs. Of this, $9.6 billion was channelled towards micro, small and medium enterprises. PTI

Share of people who lived with mental health struggles

53 in per cent. More than 50% of people waited over a year to seek professional mental health care, while 56.2% reported thoughts of self-harm before accessing care, according to mental healthcare provider Amaya's 'Mental Health Report 2026'. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Why is Spain facing a housing crisis?

How are tourism and investment funds worsening the crisis? Why is Spain struggling to provide affordable housing? How has the housing crisis affected Sánchez's government? What measures has the government proposed to tackle the crisis? What is at stake in Spain's snap election?

EXPLAINER

Sonikka Loganathan

The story so far:

Last month, 87-year-old María del Carmen Abascal was evicted from her home of over seven decades. Her father first rented Abascal's apartment in Madrid's upscale Retiro neighbourhood in 1956. She stayed there under rent control after her parents died. The building changed ownership in 2018, and Abascal was offered the option to buy the unit. Since she couldn't afford it, investment fund Urbagestión bought the unit and raised the rent from 500 euros to 2,650 euros. The fund then lowered the rent to 1,650 euros, but Abascal, who was living on pension funds, still could not afford it.



Voicing concerns: People take part in a protest demanding action to alleviate Spain's housing crisis in Barcelona on October 9. REUTERS

How severe is Spain's housing crisis?

Her eviction sparked tens of thousands of people to protest nationwide over a housing crisis that is crippling the European nation. Hundreds of people set up tents in Madrid's Puerta del Sol plaza, with some camping out there for over a week. They are demanding stronger protections for tenants, lower rents and a ban on investment funds buying property. Protesters say the problem is one of supply and demand – there simply are not enough affordable homes. Rental costs have risen by an average of 84% over the last 10 years, according to property outlet Idealista. The southern city of Malaga has seen an increase of 113%, while Marbella's increase was just under 150%. Average incomes in recent years have failed to keep up with rising costs. According to the National Statistics Institute, the average gross monthly salary in Spain is around 2,460 euros. According to Idealista, in September, a 50-square-metre apartment in Madrid cost about 1,170 euros a month – about half the average income.

The Bank of Spain's latest reports also estimate that the country has a housing shortfall of about 750,000 homes. The bank's deputy governor, Soledad Núñez, said the housing deficit could increase by another 300,000 homes between 2026 and 2028, crossing the one-million mark.

Why is this happening?

Three key issues are worsening the crisis. First, household construction has not been able to keep up with Spain's demographic boom. About 1.2 million new households came about between 2021 and 2025, driven by an increase in migration. But that same period saw fewer than half a million new homes being constructed. The 2009 Eurozone crisis, which followed the 2008 Global Financial Crisis, caused Spain's construction industry to shrink. The COVID-19 pandemic pushed up material costs, and political differences continued to restrict construction initiatives.

Tourism is worsening the problem, as more houses are being used as short-term rentals. Madrid's tenants' union, Sindicato de Inquilinas de Madrid, estimates that over 4 million homes and 400,000 vacation rentals are currently empty.

Spain's Ministry for Consumer Rights ordered the short-term rental platform Airbnb to remove about 66,000 unlicensed listings, but locals say it isn't enough. Limited public housing is also worsening the situation, forcing many young adults to leave their parents' homes only after turning 30 – far older than in other European countries. Spain ranks towards the bottom among countries in the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development in terms of government-owned rental properties, which account for less than 2% of the total housing stock. Madrid has only around 10,000 public housing units for its 3.5 million residents.

Investment funds are further exploiting the problem by buying whatever homes and units are available and hiking rents dramatically. Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez's government calls them "vulture funds".

How has the crisis shaken Sánchez's government?

As protests continue to swell, Sánchez presented two emergency measures to tackle the housing crisis, largely aimed at providing tenants with more protections. On October 1, Spain's Congress rejected both proposed decrees, prompting further protests. The defeat showed that Sánchez's socialist government does not have congressional backing. Following the blow, Sánchez called for a snap general election on November 29. The next general election was meant to be held before the end of next summer. Sánchez is hoping to capitalise on public anger over the housing crisis to win votes and maintain his position. His Spanish Socialist Workers' Party is up against the far-right Vox party, the conservative People's Party and the pro-independence Catalan party Junts. If Vox wins, it would be the first time a far-right party has governed Spain since the death of dictator Francisco Franco in 1975.

THE GIST

- Rents in Spain have risen by an average of 84% over the past decade, while the country faces a housing shortfall of about 7,50,000 homes
- A shortage of new homes, the growth of short-term tourist rentals, limited public housing and investment funds driving up rents have worsened the crisis
- After Congress rejected his proposed housing measures, Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez called a snap general election for November 29, hoping to capitalise on public anger over housing

How has the SC strengthened arrest safeguards?

What makes written grounds of arrest mandatory, and what happens if they are not provided?

R.K.Vij

The story so far:

The Supreme Court recently, in *Jaskaran Jeet Singh Deol v. State of Punjab* (September 2026), held that the investigating agency would require permission of the magistrate to re-arrest the accused after his previous arrest was held illegal for the non-supply of the grounds of arrest in writing. It also recommended departmental action for the negligent investigating officer (IO) and change of the IO in the case.

What governs the communication of grounds of arrest?

The genesis of informing the grounds of arrest to a person flows from the Constitutional safeguard provided in Article 21 that no person shall be deprived of his life and personal liberty except according to procedure established by law. Article 22(2) says that every person who is arrested and detained in custody shall be produced before the nearest magistrate within a period of 24 hours of such arrest, excluding the time necessary for the journey from the place of arrest to the court of the magistrate, and no such person shall be detained in custody beyond the said period without the authority of a magistrate.

The Constitutional safeguard is incorporated in Section 50 of the CrPC (now Section 47 of BNSS). Section 47 of BNSS casts a duty on the police officer to communicate the grounds of arrest to an accused person arrested without a warrant. However, neither Article 22(2) of the Constitution nor Section 47 of BNSS specifies the mode of communicating the grounds of arrest to an accused person.

How has the law evolved?

In *Pankaj Bansal v. Union of India & Ors.* (2023), the Supreme Court while dealing with a case of Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002 (PMLA) held that there was no valid reason as to why a written copy of the grounds of arrest could not be provided to the arrestee as a standard procedure without any exception. The court cited two reasons for it. First, in case the grounds of arrest are orally read out to an accused person, those orally stated facts could be disputed in a given case. Second, the accused person may seek legal counsel to avail bail. The court therefore held that furnishing a copy of written grounds of arrest to an accused was mandatory without exception.

This principle was reiterated by the court in *Prabir Purkayastha v. State (NCT of Delhi)* (May 2024) while dealing with a case under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967. It held that communicating the grounds of arrest was not merely a procedural formality but a vital safeguard with the ultimate objective of enabling the arrested person to effectively consult legal aid and be prepared to raise objections in the remand hearing and apply for his/her bail. Also, any breach of Article 22(2) would vitiate the lawfulness of arrest and subsequent remand, and entitle the person to be set at liberty.

However, in *Vihaan Kumar v. State of Haryana and Another* (2025), the court observed that although the ideal mode of communication of grounds of arrest is to provide such grounds in writing, there is no such statutory requirement to do so.

What did the court rule in the Rajesh Mihir Shah case?

The Supreme Court in *Rajesh Mihir Shah v. State of Maharashtra and Another* (2025) held that the constitutional mandate of informing the arrestee of the grounds of arrest is mandatory in all offences under all statutes, including offences under the IPC (now BNS). Second, the grounds of arrest must be communicated in writing to the arrestee in the language he/she understands. Third, in cases where the arresting officer is unable to communicate the grounds of arrest in writing on or soon after arrest, it needs to be done orally. The said grounds of arrest are to be communicated in writing within a reasonable time and in any case at least two hours prior to production of the arrestee for remand proceedings before the magistrate. Fourth, in case of non-compliance, the arrest and subsequent remand would be rendered illegal.

What are the consequences?

The court in the *Jaskaran Jeet Singh Deol* (supra) case said that if the IO still needs to re-arrest an accused for custodial interrogation during investigation, the IO has to file an application before the concerned magistrate for custody, stating the reasons.

The IO would also need to explain the reasons for non-supply of the grounds of arrest to the accused. However, the application could be filed only after furnishing the grounds of arrest to the accused. Also, the application must have the endorsement of the immediate superior authority. It is only after the receipt of such application that the magistrate shall decide the same expeditiously.

Second, the investigation of the case shall be handed over to another officer by the superior authority, and he shall also direct departmental enquiry for the serious lapse of not providing the grounds of arrest in writing to the accused.

Additionally, the High Court may direct payment of compensation as part of the public law remedy for the violation of Article 22(2) of the Constitution, with liberty to the accused to avail his remedy under the private civil law.

(R.K. Vij is a former IPS officer)

THE GIST

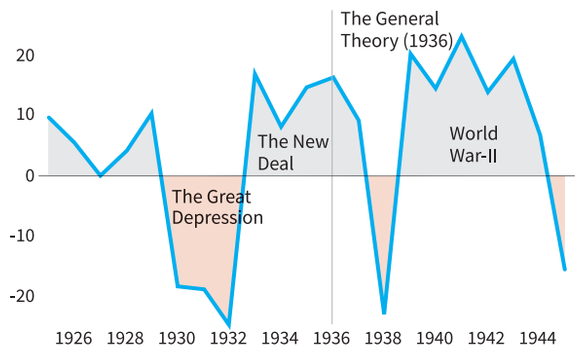
- The Supreme Court ruled that grounds of arrest must be communicated in writing, in a language the accused understands, at least two hours before remand proceedings
- If this safeguard is violated, re-arrest requires the magistrate's permission. The court also called for a change of investigating officer and a departmental inquiry into the lapse

KEYWORD

Economics of growth

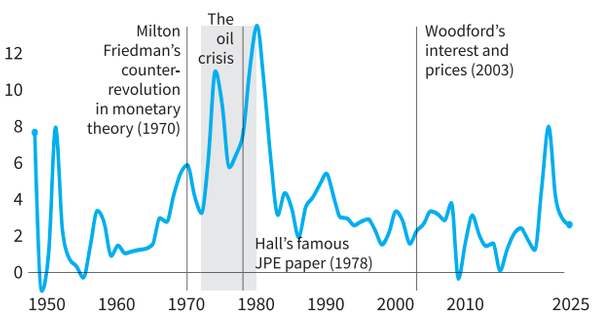
From business cycles to long-run growth, Keynes-Kalecki and orthodox economists differ on the role of demand

Chart 1 (a): The Great Depression and the rise of Keynes-Kalecki
(CAGR of U.S. industrial production, 1925–1945)



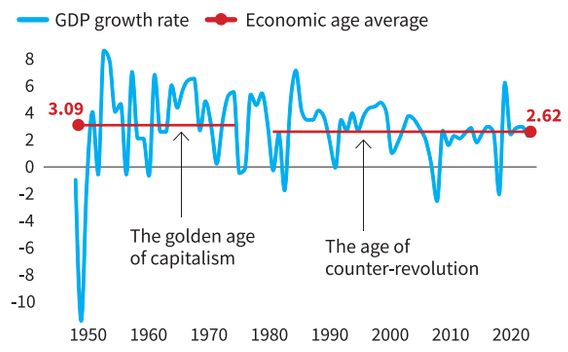
Source: Industrial Production – Total Index (IPB50001SQ), Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System (U.S.) via FRED

Chart 1 (b): Inflation and a monetarist counter-revolution in the U.S.
(1948-2025, CPI annual per cent change from year ago)



Source: Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers: all items in the U.S. city average, index 1982-1984=100, seasonally adjusted

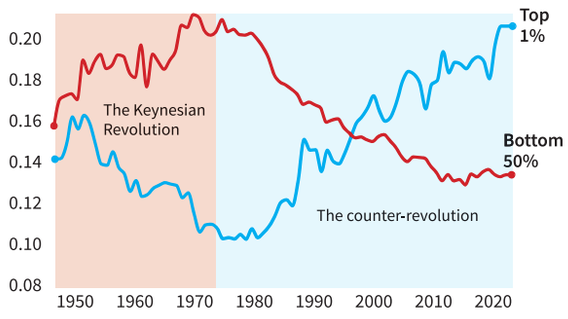
Chart 2: Long-run trend and business cycles in the U.S.
(Annual growth rates of real GDP, 1945-2025, in %)



The red lines: CAGR = geometric average, i.e., the constant annual rate that compounds to the same cumulative real GDP change over the phase: 1945-1973 (3.09%) and 1980-2025 (2.62%).

Source: Authors' calculations. Federal Reserve Economic Data, Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis

Chart 3: Economic ideas are not class agnostic
(Ratio of class-wise pre-tax income to total income)



Source: World Inequality Database

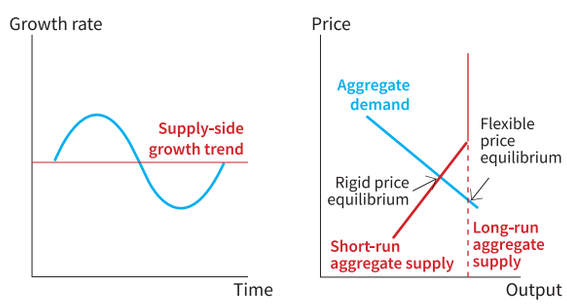


Robert E. Hall

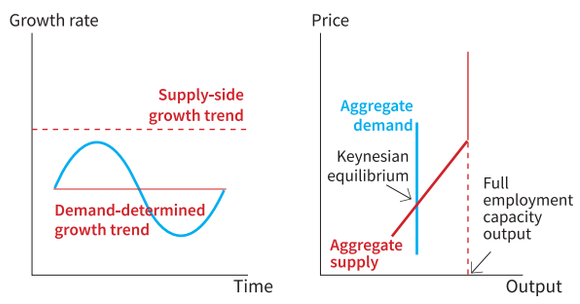


Michael Woodford

Graph 1: Schematic representation of the orthodox framework



Graph 2: Schematic representation of the Keynes-Kalecki framework



Why the debate between Keynesian and orthodox economics matters

Keynes-Kalecki framework holds that demand, particularly private investment, shapes short-term fluctuations and long-term growth, unlike orthodox supply-led approaches; the shift towards inflation targeting coincided with falling wage shares and a greater burden on workers

Rohit Azad
Indranil Chowdhury



GETTY IMAGES

Economists are products of their times. While KK wrote against the backdrop of the Great Depression, the deepest economic crisis faced by capitalism, this year's Nobel laureates wrote in the aftermath of unprecedented inflation of the 1970s

Professors Robert E. Hall and Michael Woodford have been awarded the Nobel Prize in Economics this year "for microeconomic foundations of macroeconomic stabilisation". In this piece, we take a longue durée view of macroeconomics to situate their work within the context of political economy. In many ways, the field has come full circle from the days of John Maynard Keynes and Michal Kalecki (henceforth KK)

Economists are products of their times. While KK wrote against the backdrop of the Great Depression, the deepest and longest economic crisis faced by capitalism (Chart 1a), this year's Nobel laureates wrote in the aftermath of the unprecedented inflation of the 1970s (see Chart 1b).

These are two watershed moments in both the history of capitalism and the field of macroeconomics. The former brought the Keynesian revolution (though a misnomer, as Kalecki had an equal part in it), while the latter are part of a counterrevolution to reestablish pre-Keynesian orthodoxy in many ways.

Ideas matter a great deal. The arguments and policy flowing out of the KK framework led to what is considered the golden age of capitalism (1945-1973), a period that recorded the highest sustained growth rates (compare the average growth rates across time in chart 2).

What creates a business cycle?

What is a business cycle? Like a ship navigating the ocean, a capitalist economy moves through ebbs and flows in economic activity. Just as a ship cruises smoothly when the waters are calm, an economy has an underlying long-term trend rate of growth. Both the cycle and the underlying trend rate of growth have been the subject of intense debates in economics. There are two broad poles in this debate – with some variations within each: heterodox and orthodox approaches.

Heterodox approaches hold that demand influences both the cycle and the trend, while orthodox approaches believe demand plays a role in the cycle but not the trend, albeit for different reasons. The Nobel laureates work within the latter tradition, while KK did within the former. Why should the readers bother about these esoteric questions? Because our livelihoods, jobs, cost of living, and much else depend on which side is steering the ship.

Consider the orthodox approach. Before KK, it was believed that in the long run, economies move along full-employment paths with cycles arising from external shocks, which did not require policy interventions from the State. These arguments, however, were built on ad hoc assumptions. In the 1980s, a newer version of this orthodox approach sought to build the framework from the bottom up, moving from micro-foundations to a macroeconomic model. This led to the development of real business cycle (RBC) theory, associated with economists Finn Kydland and Edward Prescott, who won the 2004 Nobel Prize in Economics. The economy functions along the full-employment path, with the trend determined by the growth of the labour force and its productivity (Graph 1(a)). For them, output and labour markets clear in the short run, so even the cyclical movements were caused by the supply side, thereby precluding the possibility of any State intervention.

Economists such as Hall and Woodford, while keeping the RBC framework intact, argued that economies can fall off the full-employment path if prices do not adjust fast enough to clear the markets. The argument they made was that not all firms change their prices at the same time; some do so in one period, while others in another. As a result, prices do not fully adjust between these periods. If household demand for goods is less than what firms collectively wish to supply (Graph 1(b)), prices may not fall enough to restore equilibrium. The economy then operates at lower levels of demand (recession). The opposite happens if demand is greater than supply (boom with signs of overheating).

If you consider a time period long enough (over a business cycle), on average, the prices would have adjusted fully, in which case demand also adjusts fully to what the firms would like to supply. Demand creates supply in the short run while supply determines the demand in the long run. It is obvious, therefore, that policy is required only for the short run and not the long run.

Demand and long-term growth

The KK tradition is markedly different from this. They argued that demand matters not just in determining the cyclical component of growth but also the underlying trend. Kalecki had famously said, "the long-run trend is but a slowly changing component of a chain of short-period situations; it has no independent entity". If the economy is underemployed through the short run, it remains so in the long run as well (see graph 2 (a)). And if policy changes the short-run equilibrium, it affects the trend rate of growth too.

But even more importantly, their analysis of the short term differs as well. Economies are stuck at below-capacity output or with unemployed workers not because prices and wages are rigid but because capital investment by the capitalists is not enough to employ all those who seek employment. Rigidity of investment, not prices, causes unemployment. In Keynes, prices are not even rigid, let alone being the cause of the business cycle. In Kalecki, they are, but that is not the cause of the shortage of demand. Unless the fall in prices could affect investment, it would have no impact on demand. Demand is vertical in prices (Graph 2(b)).

A fall in prices may in fact have a negative impact on investment through debt defaults, etc. All of this had a profound impact on both understanding the workings of a capitalist economy as well as policy prescriptions.

Non-neutrality of money

Having looked at their understanding of how capitalism functions, consider their take on policy, particularly monetary policy.

Before Keynes, it was believed that money could not affect the 'real' economy, i.e., it was neutral in its impact on output. It was believed that a larger pool of money would chase the same amount of goods, which simply leads to a rise in their prices. The role of monetary policy, therefore, was to stabilise prices. The New Keynesian Model (NKM) agrees that this is indeed the case in the long run; however, in the short run, since prices are sticky, a rise in the money supply increases real balances in the hands of households, who increase their consumption, thereby making money non-neutral. But this holds only in the short run. While money is non-neutral in the short run, the primary role of monetary policy nevertheless is to stabilise inflation. No wonder that this policy approach is called inflation targeting. The KK framework, on the other hand, did not believe that money leads to inflation. Given that the ebbs in activity were caused by a lack of adequate private investment, their policy recommendations foregrounded policies which increased the level of activity directly, i.e., through fiscal intervention by the State. If private investment is not coming through, public investment fills the gap.

As for monetary policy, it mostly played a second fiddle to fiscal policy in their framework. Monetary policy on its own may not work because it is an indirect route of increasing private investment by decreasing the cost of loans. KK believed that low investment is because the demand for the products the factories produce is low, so a mere fall in the cost of loans will not reverse the 'animal spirits' of the capitalists.

Class politics of inflation

All of this is not just a theoretical debate. While the Keynesian revolution improved the lot of the workers on the whole, the monetarist counter-revolution has made them the scapegoats in this fight against inflation, which we have written about in these columns earlier. It is not surprising that the wage shares were rising during the KK years and a reversal has taken place since the RBC counterrevolution took hold over the discipline (Chart 3). Economic frameworks and policy prescriptions, therefore, are not, and can never be, class agnostic.

(The authors are a part of the DevMac (Development Macroeconomics) network, which seeks pluralism in Economics)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning and origin of the idiom "to live the life of Riley"? (K. R. Manohara, Chitragupta)

When you say that somebody is "living" or "leading the life of Riley", what you are implying is that he/she is leading a very comfortable life. He/she is leading the kind of life that all of us wish we had – a life where one doesn't have to work hard or spend sleepless nights worrying about making ends meet. When you lead the life of Riley, you lead a very "cushy" life.

While Prabha worked all day, Sunil stayed home living the life of Riley.

What is the origin of this expression? Well, no one is really sure as to who this Riley was. Some scholars argue that this Riley (originally spelt "Reilly") referred to the character that appeared in a song written by Pat Rooney in 1890. In the song, Riley says if he ever became the President of the US then "New York" would "swim in wine when the White House and Capitol are mine." It tells you something about the kind of President he would have made, doesn't it? Some others argue that it was an American poet by the name of James Whitcomb Riley who gave rise to this idiom. Apparently, Riley (1849-1916) wrote sentimental poems about young boys, which were very popular during his time. The poems told the stories of young boys lazing around during the summer without a care in the world – wandering about barefoot, swimming in the river, and fishing.

What is the meaning of "sixth sense"? (T. Srinivas, Siddipet)

Sometimes when you get up in the morning you have a feeling that you are going to have a really bad day. There may not be any logical explanation why you feel this way. You just have this strange feeling and, funnily enough, you end up having a perfectly lousy day. This intuitive feeling that you sometimes have that tells you that something good or bad is going to happen is your "sixth sense". We all have five senses – taste, hearing, sight, smell, and touch. This sixth sense cannot be explained by the other five senses; it is something that cannot be explained by logic. Here are a few examples.

Atul's sixth sense warned him not to trust his new lawyer.

Prem's sixth sense told him that something bad was going to happen.

The expression means the same thing as "gut reaction" or "gut feeling". Your gut feeling about something is your personal or intuitive feeling about something. For example,

Satish had a gut feeling that he was going to get some bad news.

What should a sign say? "No admission" or "No admittance"? (G.K.S. Kandasubramanian, Sivaganga)

Both are correct. When you find these signs on a door, what they imply is that you do not have the right to enter. Of the two, "admittance" is the more formal. It stresses on the physical act of entering the premises. "Admission", on the other hand, is far less formal and has several different meanings. For example, we talk about "admission to a club or university". Here the focus is not on the physical act of entering the university or the club, but in the general sense of participating with others. Admission gives you the right to join others and participate in an event/programme.

Published in The Hindu on April 9, 2002

Word of the day

Mendacity:
the tendency to be untruthful

Synonyms: lie, falsehood, fabrication

Usage: *The politician was known for his mendacity.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/mendacity

International Phonetic Alphabet: /mɛndæsəti/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



Govt. to roll out BS-VII norms for new cars from April 2029

The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) is planning to roll out stricter BS-VII emission standards for new cars and SUVs from April 1, 2029, according to a draft gazette notification. The ministry said in an October 12 draft notification that it will implement all new norms in three phases spanning 6 years from April 2029 to April 2035. PTI

Jio Platforms to launch 'India's biggest ever' ₹30,213-cr. IPO

Jio Platforms Ltd. will launch a ₹30,213-crore initial public offering (IPO), making it India's biggest ever, surpassing Hyundai Motor India's ₹27,859-crore issue. The price band has been fixed at ₹1,065-₹1,119 per equity share, with a face value of ₹10. Investors can bid for a minimum of 12 shares and in multiples of 12 thereafter. The IPO will open for subscription on October 21, 2026, and close on Friday, October 23.

Tata Trusts row: Noel, Neville move courts with caveats

Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata and his son Neville have filed caveats in city courts in the row surrounding Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh, sources said on Wednesday. The caveats filed in the Bombay High Court and also in the Mumbai City Civil Court will ensure that they are heard before the passing of any orders. Both the father and son moved the courts with their caveats on October 7, as per official records. PTI

Cabinet okays IDBI Bank sale to Fairfax for ₹52,878 cr.

Largest FDI deal in the financial sector in India's history; with the sale, the government's stake in the bank will decline to 15% and the Life Insurance Corporation's stake will come down to 19%

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved the 'strategic restructuring' of IDBI Bank, with Fairfax set to acquire a stake in the lender for ₹52,878 crore, the Centre announced. With this, the government's stake in the bank will fall to 15% and Life Insurance Corporation's (LIC) stake will come down to 19%.

The government termed the deal a strategic restructuring rather than strategic disinvestment, adding that it would be the largest foreign direct investment in the financial sector in India's history. The government currently holds 45.5% of IDBI Bank, while LIC holds 49.2%.

IDBI Bank, having suffered from poor financial health for years, had been put under a Prompt Corrective Action (PCA) framework in 2017.



Ailment history: IDBI Bank, which suffered from poor financial health, was put under Prompt Corrective Action in 2017. REUTERS

In January 2019, LIC took over controlling stake in the bank by infusing ₹21,624 crore into it and being allotted preferential shares in return.

As a result, the government's stake in the bank fell below 51% and the RBI classified it as a private bank since then.

"It was against this backdrop that the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) approved strategic restructuring of the IDBI Bank Ltd., and in compliance thereof, it was decided that an aggregate 60.72% of the equity stake in the IDBI Bank Ltd be sold to a strategic buyer, of which, the GoI share would be 30.48% and the LIC share would be 30.24%, leaving a residual shareholding of 15% with the GoI and 19% with the LIC," the government said.

It further said that the winning bidder, out of two parties that finally qualified for bidding, was Canada-headquartered Fairfax Financial Holdings with a bid fixed at ₹81 per share.

Sources in the Ministry of Finance said this strategic restructuring does not change anything for the regulation of the banks or its customer-facing duties.

The bank has seen a significant turnaround in its financial health since it became a private bank. Its gross non-performing asset ratio fell from 31.8% in September 2018 to 2.3% as of March 2026. Its capital adequacy ratio rebounded from 6.22% in 2018 to 26.65% in March 2026. It recorded a net profit of ₹9,513 crore in FY26.

BoB tanks 3.5% as NMC founder sues it for $15 bn

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Bank of Baroda (BoB) shares fell 3.47% to ₹229.35 on the BSE on Wednesday after reports that B.R. Shetty, founder of the failed UAE-based NMC Healthcare, had filed a $15-billion damages suit against the bank and 25 others.

The bank said it had not been served with any such suit. Mr. Shetty, 84, has approached the Bombay High Court, alleging that the defendants acted "as an instrument in the siphoning of funds" that led to the collapse of his business empire. The suit names BoB, 10 current and former bank officers, former NMC executives Prasanth and Promoth Manghat, their family members and associates, and two domestic entities.

The suit seeks $5 billion each in direct and consequential damages jointly and severally against the defendants, besides $5 billion exclusively from BoB for loss of reputation and goodwill, along with 18% annual interest.

BoB said it was pursuing recovery of about ₹2,800 crore from Mr. Shetty and had obtained decrees against him in the UAE and DIFC Courts.

The bank added that a similar suit filed by Mr. Shetty in New York was dismissed in July 2024.

Centre to unveil national power data sharing framework

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI


Pankaj Agarwal

The government is set to roll out the National Electricity Data Sharing Framework in October to facilitate structured and secure data sharing in the power sector, Pankaj Agarwal, Secretary at the Union Power Ministry, said on Wednesday.

A national-level data governance committee, comprising government officials and industry representatives, will also be constituted to ensure a coordinated approach. The committee will be chaired by the Central Electricity Authority (CEA) Chairperson.

"After consultations with stakeholders, we have prepared the National Electricity Data Sharing framework and would want to assure that we would be launching this in October itself," Mr. Agarwal said. The Power Ministry had floated the draft framework for stakeholder consultation in June.

It lays down broad principles for structured, secure and transparent data sharing, while ensuring non-discriminatory access and protecting critical information infrastructure.

The voluntary framework is intended to help utilities establish common data structures and provide clarity on what information can be shared, enabling startups and other industry players to use large datasets for analysis and decision-making, he told reporters on the sidelines of the Central Electricity Authority's Brainstorming Conclave on the use of artificial intelligence in the sector.

Providing clarity

"The whole idea is to give clarity, rather a starting point to utilities about data sharing – what kind of data they can share, what should be the data structure. If you want the industry, [potentially] start-ups, to utilise the large volume of data sets – then they have to be consistent, similar in structure, so that they can be gainfully leveraged for giving various decision options," Mr. Agarwal said.

Separately, Jitin Prasada, Minister of State for Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), said the government would roll out a policy for data centres, positioning India as a potential destination for hyperscale facilities.

Hyundai Pune unit to get ₹4,000 cr. more

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Hyundai Motor India Ltd. (HMIL) will invest an additional ₹4,000 crore in it's Pune plant by 2030 taking the total to ₹11,000 crore.

The plant's current annual installed capacity of 1,70,000 units will rise in phases to 3,20,000 units by 2030, MD & CEO Tarun Garg said. The firm said it would raise localisation from 83% to 92%.

The plant, the firm's second after Chennai, was opened by Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis.

Euisun Chung, executive chair - Hyundai Motor Group HMG, Jaehoon Chang, vice chair - HMG, José Muñoz, president & CEO - Hyundai Motor Company (HMC) were present.

HMIL also celebrated the achievement of cumulative exports of 4 million passenger vehicles from India since 1999, underscoring its contribution towards establishing India as a global automotive manufacturing and export hub.


Devendra Fadnavis at the Pune plant inauguration.

Mr. Euisun Chung, said, "India is one of Hyundai's most important and strategic markets globally. The inauguration of the Pune plant reflects our long-term commitment to India's growth."

Food, fuel nudge wholesale inflation in Sept. to 11.4%

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Wholesale price inflation rose to 11.4% in September, a record-breaking high during the 2.5 years for which there is data for the new series of the Wholesale Price Index (WPI) and a 49-month-high as per the much longer old series on pricier food and fuel.

The new series of the WPI has 2022-23 as base year and so the data goes back till only April 2024. The older series, with base year of 2011-12, has a much longer historical database.

"The non-food manufactured goods (core WPI) segment accounted for more than half of the 147 bps uptick in the headline inflation print in September relative to August 2026, reflecting the impact of the pass-through of input cost pressures," Rahul Agrawal, principal economist at ICRA said.



Inflation in fuel and power rose to 25.85% in September.

Food sharply up

Inflation in the food articles component of the WPI came in at 8.1% in September 2026, up sharply from 5.7% in the previous month. However, this was also on a low base as prices in this component had contracted 6.8% in September last year.

The non-food primary articles segment also saw elevated inflation levels of 10.3% in September though this was the lowest in four months. Inflation in manufactured goods stood at a series-high of 9.8%, up from 8.4% in August 2026.

"The increase in wholesale inflation across food articles, fuel and power, and manufactured products highlights the need for businesses to closely monitor input costs and pricing conditions," Anil Gupta, president, of the PHD Chamber of Commerce and Industry said.

Inflation in fuel and power rose to 25.85% in September though this was the highest in only three months with the pace of price rise having been higher in May and June.

TCS looks to quantum computing to solve complex 'what if' problems

Balasubramanyam C.P.
MUMBAI


Using precision oncology as an example, TCS CTO Harrick Vin said it should make a tangible difference to patients' lives. REUTERS

Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) is exploring quantum computing to solve complex problems ranging from personalised cancer treatments and financial portfolio optimisation to molecule discovery and severe-weather prediction, as conventional computing architectures struggle to address such challenges at scale.

Speaking at IBM's Think 2026 event in Mumbai, TCS Chief Technology Officer Harrick Vin said the company's interest stemmed from the technology's potential to tackle problems involving an enormous number of possible outcomes and decisions.

Mr. Vin outlined four layers of reasoning intelligence: descriptive, diagnostic, predictive and prescriptive. While conventional computing is relatively effective at understanding what is happening, why it is happening and, to some extent, what might happen next, more complex predictive and prescriptive problems require evaluating numerous possibilities.

"Solving sort of more complex predictive and prescriptive problems requires you to solve a lot of what if and if what problems," he said.

While "what if" explores the possible consequences of an action, "if what" works backwards from a desired outcome to determine the action required to achieve it.

In healthcare, for instance, identifying the most effective drug for an individual cancer patient could involve evaluating numerous treatment options. Quantum computing could eventually help address such computationally intensive challenges, opening new possibilities for precision medicine.

'Look beyond'

Mr. Vin urged businesses to look beyond marginal efficiency gains and identify areas where quantum computing could fundamentally transform customer outcomes.

Using precision oncology as an example, he said the objective should not merely be to improve doctors' productivity but to make a tangible difference to patients' lives.

"It's not about improving the productivity of doctors by a little bit here and there," he said. "It is the difference between actually saving lives or not."

Banking and financial services, particularly portfolio optimisation, and healthcare and pharmaceuticals, including molecule and protein discovery, are among the sectors where Mr. Vin sees the greatest potential.

However, he cautioned that the technology remains at an early stage. "We are in an early stage of AI era. We are probably even in an earlier stage of the quantum era," he said.

Hybrid computing

Mr. Vin envisaged a future computing architecture combining conventional central processing units, graphics processing units (GPUs), tensor processing units (TPUs) and quantum processing units (QPUs). Applications would need to distribute workloads across these architectures according to their capabilities and costs.

He also highlighted neuromorphic computing as a potential route to low-power, low-cost intelligence at edge devices, alongside the need for software to adapt to evolving computing infrastructure.

Quantum computing also poses cybersecurity challenges, as advances could eventually compromise existing cryptographic protocols, he said, adding organisations must therefore prepare to migrate towards quantum-safe encryption.

TCS joined IBM and the Andhra Pradesh government in a quantum-computing initiative announced in May 2025. Mr. Vin said TCS had chosen to invest early to build capabilities before the technology became mainstream.

SEBI targets 4 lakh accredited investors via expanded AIF

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is likely to issue a circular shortly to expand the framework for alternative investment funds (AIFs), including provisions to recognise assets with high growth potential, said Sandip Pradhan, whole-time member of the capital markets regulator.

"The revised framework is evolving, we already had a board meeting and very soon we will be coming out with a circular that we are also adding one more aspect, that is the assets of high growth or movement in the security market," Mr. Pradhan said at the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) Alternative Investments Summit here.



SEBI will be shortly coming out with a circular on revised AIF.

The inclusion is expected to expand the pool of accredited investors in the AIF industry to four lakh from the current 1 lakh.

AIFs are privately-pooled investment vehicles that raise capital from institutional investors and high-net-worth individuals to invest in alternative asset classes, including unlisted securities and other non-traditional investments. Given exposure to complex and potentially illiquid assets, they carry higher risks and are subject to a regulatory framework distinct from that governing retail investment products.

SEBI's August 2026 consultation paper proposes easing the eligibility criteria for accredited investors. Under Proposal 6, individuals with at least ₹5 crore and companies with at least ₹20 crore invested in securities could qualify, with electronic consolidated account statements (eCAS) or broker statements accepted as proof.

Panel to study issues of sugarcane farmers

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The panel will also examine the demand for revision of the ex-mill Minimum Selling Price of sugar

The Centre set up a four-member panel under former NITI Aayog Member Ramesh Chand to examine issues raised by sugarcane farmers and recommend "appropriate measures" for addressing these. Representatives of sugarcane farmers from Karnataka and Maharashtra met Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan and Union Minister of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution Pralhad Joshi demanding the Centre raise support price for sugarcane.

A release issued by the Union Food Ministry said the panel would examine the demand taking into account cultivation costs and other factors. "It will also examine the demand for revision of the ex-mill Minimum Selling Price (MSP) of sugar in the context of sugar output cost, market realisation and the financial viability of sugar mills.

Other key areas of examination would include existing mechanisms for testing and reporting sugar recovery, steps to ensure transparent verification of recovery and prevailing sugarcane weighment practices at sugar mills.

Trump tariff threat built a U.S. copper mountain, but effects fading



Locked, loaded: Container ships are docked at the APM Terminal at the Port of Los Angeles, California. AFP

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
LONDON

President Donald Trump's tariff threat helped to build copper stockpiles of more than 1 million metric tonnes in the U.S. without spending public money, but the flow is slowing as traders await a decision on the levies.

The prospect of levies left Comex-approved warehouses in the U.S. holding roughly 70% of the world's visible copper stocks. This has created shortages elsewhere, fuelling a price surge despite a global surplus.

"Only traders are making money. There are cheaper ways they could have got the copper. They could have quietly collected metal around the world from the off-exchange market," said Panmure Liberum analyst Tom Price.

Whether and when tariffs are imposed on U.S. imports and whether the possibility will keep attracting copper will be a key talking point at LME Week, the industry's annual gathering in London starting October 18. Traders have been shipping copper to the U.S. since Trump ordered a study on the potential for tariffs in February last pushing Comex prices to record highs, reaching $6.83 a lb or $15,057 a tonne, on September 22.

Democratic midterm wins may bring scrutiny for Wall Street, crypto firms

Democratic win in one chamber would bring authority to summon agency heads and CEOs; Democrats already preparing probes into Trump family ties to crypto, prediction markets; added oversight may slow pace but not derail regulatory easing; Congressional oversight creates reputational risks

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
WASHINGTON



All eyes: A view of the dome of the U.S. Capitol building on Capitol Hill in Washington, D.C. REUTERS

A Democratic victory in one or both chambers of Congress would not stop President Donald Trump's administration from handing regulatory breaks to Wall Street banks, prediction markets and crypto firms, but it would give Democrats powerful tools to probe the industries and their watchdogs.

Polls suggest Democrats are poised to win the House of Representatives and have an edge in the race for the Senate. If the party prevails in either chamber, it would gain subpoena power, larger investigative staffs and the power to call in agency heads and corporate CEOs to testify, creating headaches and potential legal entanglements for those under scrutiny.

"Everything that has gone on in the first two years of this administration is fair game for investigations," said Kevin Edgar, a partner at Baker Hostetler and former chief counsel of the House Financial Services Committee.

The administration's financial policy agenda includes easing rules and supervision it says are too onerous and impeding economic growth, while promoting innovation that it says will boost the economy, including crypto and prediction markets.

> The administration's financial policy agenda includes easing rules and supervision it says are too onerous and impeding economic growth

Prediction market

Democrats are already preparing to investigate Trump's and his family's ties to the crypto and prediction market industries, *Reuters* reported. They say such dealings are a conflict of interest. The party has also been pushing for more oversight of prediction markets, which they say may be creating new avenues for misconduct and undermining national security by allowing government insiders to broadcast confidential information.

Prediction markets say they vigilantly guard against misconduct. The administration says supporting crypto and prediction market innovation will keep American jobs and capital onshore.

Asked about such potential probes in a September 30 phone interview, Representative Ro Khanna, a Democratic member of the House Oversight Committee, told *Reuters*: "I absolutely think we need to look at these financial transactions, these crypto transactions, and see if any of our national security has been compromised.

Crypto firms worry

Crypto executives said they are especially worried that Representative Sean Casten may challenge Maxine Waters, currently the top Democrat on the House Financial Services Committee, for the chair if Democrats win. Punchbowl News reported last month Casten weighed such a move. His spokesperson declined to comment. Casten has been a vocal proponent of probing the administration's crypto ties and of tougher crypto rules. In 2024, he introduced a bill curbing crypto tools he said aid money laundering. He also voted against the industry's Clarity Act bill in 2025, saying it would put Americans at risk.

"He is no friend of the industry," said Ron Hammond, head of policy and advocacy at Wintermute, a crypto trading firm.

White House spokesperson Olivia Wales said Trump is focusing on retaining Congressional Republican majorities so he can continue to "put more money back in Americans' pockets," among other goals. "Democrats clearly have no agenda to improve the lives of the American people, just plans to obstruct and baselessly target President Trump's common sense agenda."

AI, affordability

Other likely Democratic targets include Trump's regulators, which have relaxed oversight of lenders and pulled back on enforcement. Wall Street's role in financing the AI boom and data centres, a contentious election issue, as well as its influence on housing and other affordability challenges, is also likely to draw scrutiny, said attorneys and analysts.

Senator Elizabeth Warren, the top Democrat on the Senate Banking Committee and a veteran Wall Street critic, is seen as the frontrunner to chair that committee. She has recently focused her criticism on major AI companies, saying the industry has gained special access to the administration and influence over policy.

Both Warren and Waters have also repeatedly raised concerns over affordability, including housing issues, and accused the administration of eroding consumer finance protections. When Waters previously ran the House committee, she called the CEOs of the largest U.S. banks to testify on a range of issues, and is widely expected to do so again if she reprises its leadership.

A spokesperson for Warren declined to comment, while a spokesperson for Waters did not immediately provide comment.

Kevin Barstow, an attorney at O'Melveny who previously handled probes while working in the Biden White House, said Congressional investigators are already laying the groundwork.

"Some of our clients have received letters, regarding a variety of issues, including their interactions with the administration. We are preparing our clients that some of the enquiries are likely to become formal investigations," Barstow added, without specifying which committees or clients. Trump's regulators are handing Wall Street banks major capital relief, and have already clashed with Democrats when defending policies during Congressional hearings.

RBI's rupee pressure concerns and steps to control forex volatility

EXPLAINER

Lalatendu Mishra

Story so far: In view of the evolving geopolitical conditions, fluctuations in oil prices and to ensure orderly functioning of the foreign exchange market, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on October 10 issued two circulars, announcing several regulatory measures.



Wait and watch: Medium-to-long-term impact of RBI's steps depends on external factors like geopolitical worries. REUTERS

The measures

Curbs on rebooking cancelled forex derivative contracts: Authorised Dealers (ADs) will not permit users to rebook any foreign exchange derivative contract involving INR, whether deliverable or non-deliverable, which has been cancelled with any AD after issuance of the directions. Rollover of foreign exchange derivative contracts on maturity will continue to be permitted, subject to compliance with regulatory provisions.

Cut in threshold: The existing threshold of $100 million equivalent for undertaking foreign exchange derivative transactions to hedge contracted exposures without establishing the existence of the underlying exposure has been cut to $5 million equivalent, across all ADs. The corresponding threshold for taking positions in exchange-traded currency derivatives involving INR, without establishing the existence of underlying exposure, has also been reduced from $100 million to $5 million equivalent, across all recognised stock exchanges taken together.

More documents:ADs will be required to obtain and retain an undertaking from users entering into foreign exchange derivative contracts involving INR to hedge contracted exposures, confirming the same underlying exposure has not been hedged with any other AD.

FERR: In respect of all foreign exchange derivative contracts involving INR that are for notional value exceeding $2 million equivalent, ADs will be required to maintain with the Reserve Bank an Foreign Exchange Risk Reserve (FERR) in cash, equal to 20% of INR equivalent of the notional amount of each transaction.

This FERR will be applicable for foreign exchange derivative contracts involving INR undertaken to hedge current account exposures where the user buys foreign currency against INR.

The RBI said these steps would boost market discipline and ensure appropriate risk management in the foreign exchange market while maintaining an orderly and transparent market environment.

What the steps mean

The RBI's forex exchange measures are likely to prompt banks to reduce speculative positions, unwind excess exposures and reassess forward books, particularly following the reduction in the limit for derivative positions without underlying exposure from $100 million to $5 million, said Kunal Sodhani, Head of Treasury, Shinhan Bank. "The restrictions on rebooking cancelled INR-linked derivative contracts should also curb repeated speculative activity," Mr. Sodhani said.

According to him the new FERR, requiring a reserve equivalent to 20% of eligible derivative notional exceeding $2 million, is likely to increase banks' funding and opportunity costs, which may be passed on to customers through wider spreads and higher hedging costs, particularly for longer-tenor transactions.

Other steps

To arrest the aggressive slide of the rupee, the Reserve Bank of India shifted strategy away from conventional interest rate hikes, such as the 25bps repo hike on October 7 that failed to halt the depreciation, toward direct plumbing and structural market interventions, said Devarsh Vakil, Head of research, HDFC Securities.

The RBI has taken various measures apart from regularly intervening in the OTC and NDF markets to manage rupee volatility including conducting sell buy swaps in the forward market to drain rupee liquidity, said Ritesh Bhansali, Dy. CEO, Mecklai Financial Services.

The other measures include Dedicated Dollar Facility for Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs), Liberalising External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs), Encouraging Non-Resident Indian (NRI) Deposits, placing position limits on ADs by restricting the Net Open Position Limit (NOPL) of commercial banks to curb proprietary foreign-exchange trading, International Rupee Invoicing via Vostro Accounts, tightening the rules for booking forward contracts by not allowing to rebook cancelled contracts, lowering the threshold for undertaking foreign exchange derivatives without establishing an underlying economic exposure from $100 million to $5 million and introducing FERR, he said.

Facility for OMCs

Overall, the measures should improve market discipline and curb speculative dollar demand, although the impact on USD-INR will continue to depend on crude oil prices, foreign portfolio flows and underlying dollar demand, Mr. Sodhani said.

According to Mr. Bhansali the special window for OMC will divert bulk crude purchases away from open exchanges helping to curb sharp currency swings.

"It acts only as a band-aid that steadily burns sovereign reserves without curing the trade deficit; hence, it remains viable solely as a brief crisis buffer rather than an enduring strategy," he emphasised.

"While it stabilises spot volatility, it does not reduce India's actual import bill or stop foreign capital outflows. Instead of soaking up market liquidity, it shifts the burden directly onto the RBI's foreign exchange reserves. It is a tactical bridge than a permanent fix," Mr. Vakil said.

The implications

On forex reserves, the RBI's decision to directly supply dollars to OMCs from October 12 could initially put pressure on reserves, but it should simultaneously reduce their dollar demand in the interbank market and moderate pressure on the rupee, Mr. Sodhani said.

Dollar strength

The rupee faces depreciation headwinds from persistent U.S. dollar strength, elevated global yields, high crude import bills widening the current account deficit, and geopolitical uncertainties triggering sustained foreign portfolio outflows Mr. Bhansali said.

Need for FCNRB

Deploying concessional dollar swaps was a smart emergency shield that quickly restored liquidity and defended the currency, Mr. Bhansali said.

"Yet it carries sharp trade-offs: the central bank assumes open exchange-rate risk on its balance sheet, while building an aggressive maturity overhang that could trigger severe dollar outflows upon expiry if not managed well," he pointed out.

According to Mr. Vakil, the Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits [FCNR(B)] and associated swaps have helped mobilise foreign capital directly into the banking system without immediate spot market depletion.

"Underlying risks remains as large bulges of maturing dollar deposits require eventual redemption or rollover, creating future liquidity bottlenecks. The central bank or commercial banks bear the ultimate hedging/conversion cost if domestic interest rate differentials or severe depreciation pressures complicate repayment terms," he stated.

Rupee headwinds

India remains heavily dependent on energy imports. Even with RBI supplying OMCs directly, the underlying national oil import bill remains massive, said Mr. Vakil.

The prolonged West Asia conflict keeps crude oil prices elevated, maintaining structural pressure on the current account balance, he said. Sustained capital outflows from domestic equities and debt markets continue to exert downward pressure on the currency, he added.

Ongoing global macroeconomic factors and persistent interest rate differentials between advanced economies and emerging markets keep greenback broadly resilient, he stated.

West Asia conflict

Because India buys most of its oil from abroad, rising crude prices mean more dollars must leave the country to pay for fuel. At the same time, ongoing global panic makes foreign investors pull money out of India and flee to the safety of the U.S. dollar, causing the rupee to drop, Mr. Bhansali said. As per Mr. Vakil, the prolonged conflict in West Asia had disrupted international energy supply chains, causing periodic spikes in Brent crude prices.

Higher energy prices directly inflate India's import bill, expand the current account deficit, and drain foreign exchange reserves faster, directly translating into depreciation pressure on the Rupee.

What is the outlook?

The latest measures taken by RBI will definitely help to arrest the recent fall in rupee in the short term and lead to short term rupee appreciation towards 95.5 to 96 in the short term but the structural issues facing rupee will still continue to keep rupee under pressure in the medium term, Mr. Bhansali said.

Rupee weakens 7%

The rupee has depreciated by approximately 7% year-to-date. "The RBI's intervention is entirely sensible to quell reckless speculation and insulate domestic inflation from global price shocks," Mr. Bhansali said.

"That said, its mandate is rightly limited to dampening erratic volatility rather than protecting a rigid currency level, since opposing persistent global dollar strength would only bleed vital forex reserves," he added.

Is RBI justified?

With the rupee trading near historical lows (touching 96.96 earlier in the year and closing at 96.73), year-to-date (YTD) losses reflect relentless structural pressures. At YTD fall of 7.09% it is the worst performing among the Asian peers, Mr. Vakil said.

Central banks typically intervene not to override long-term macroeconomic fundamentals, but to curb excessive volatility, prevent disorderly market conditions, manage imported inflation, and maintain financial stability across corporate balance sheets heavily exposed to unhedged foreign debt, he added.

Rupee Vs EM currencies

Compared to regional peers that face localised debt crises or sharper macroeconomic structural shocks, the rupee's decline has been managed via active central bank intervention.

As a major net importer of commodities (especially oil), the rupee tends to be more sensitive to energy price swings and global USD liquidity cycles than export-oriented or commodity-surplus EM currencies, Mr. Vakil said.

Why is RBI so worried?

A rapidly depreciating currency drives up the cost of essential imports (crude oil, electronics, edible oils), feeding domestic retail inflation, Mr. Vakil said. Unhedged foreign currency borrowings by Indian corporations become prohibitively expensive to service, raising systemic default risks within the banking sector, he stated. Unchecked one-way depreciation bets can trigger self-fulfilling panic, capital flight, and rapid reserve depletion, he added.

Handling the situation

*Strictly adhere to the new $5 million unhedged exposure limit and tighten documentation compliance.

*Utilise permissible vanilla hedging tools early rather than relying on speculative "cancel-and-rebook" strategies.

*Optimise realisation timelines but avoid over-speculating on extreme currency movements given sudden regulatory curbs.

*Monitor forex reserve updates, weekly RBI interventions and Brent crude movements as key risk factors before taking unhedged foreign currency exposure, said Mr. Vakil.

What next

The short-term implication of RBI's steps is positive but the medium-to-long-term depends on many external factors. Broadly, spot USD INR may trade between 94.50 to 97.50, said Mr. Vakil.

JERUSALEM

Netanyahu says he is not seeking to attack Iran before Israel election



AP

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said on Wednesday that he was not in favour of a pre-emptive strike against Iran before Israel's October 27 election but also warned Tehran and its proxies against striking Israel. "It is not convenient for us, it's no good," Netanyahu said in an interview on Israel's Army Radio. REUTERS

WASHINGTON

Russian diesel deal 'not for us', but for world markets, says Trump



REUTERS

Facing criticism over the diesel deal with Russia, U.S. President Donald Trump said the fuel from Moscow's refineries was meant to stabilise the global market, which has been hit by high prices. "That's a diesel deal. Not for us. That's being released into the world. That's not being released to us," he said on Tuesday. PTI

MIKHMAS

Israeli settlers set fire to mosque, graffiti outside walls in West Bank



REUTERS

Israeli settlers set fire to a mosque and graffitied its outside walls on Wednesday in the occupied West Bank village of Mikhmas, sources and the Israeli military said. Rouhi Fattouh, president of the Palestinian National Council, described the attack as "a barbaric act and a dangerous escalation in settler terrorism". AFP

WASHINGTON

U.S. judge backs *CNN*, *MS Now*, *Politico* access to White House



AFP

A federal judge blocked on Tuesday the White House from banning *CNN*, *MS Now* and *Politico* journalists, following U.S. President Donald Trump's decision to ban the news outlets last month. District Judge Timothy Kelly ruled that the Trump administration must grant the journalists access to the White House. AFP

Houthis vow more strikes on Saudi airports, oil sites after Aramco hit

An attack on Aramco's Dhahran headquarters reportedly caused a blaze spreading across several floors; the group says its strikes on 'legitimate targets' are a retaliation for Saudi attacks on Yemen and the kingdom's support for Yemeni govt. forces

Reuters
RIYADH/DUBAI

Yemen's Houthis (Ansar Allah) vowed on Wednesday to press on with attacks on airports and oil facilities in Saudi Arabia, a day after a strike that sources said caused extensive damage to the headquarters of oil giant Saudi Aramco.

The Houthis said the threatened locations were legitimate targets and described their attacks as retaliation for Saudi strikes on Yemen, threatening to escalate a conflict reignited by the U.S.-Iran confrontation in the Gulf.



Critical strike: The headquarters of Saudi Aramco in Dhahran, Saudi Arabia, before it was attacked on Tuesday night. REUTERS

Saudi Arabia has faced widening Houthi strikes over the past week, including an attack on King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh on Saturday that killed 13 people.

Tuesday night's attack on Saudi Aramco's base in the eastern city of Dhahran caused a fire that spread across several floors, three people with knowledge of the matter told *Reuters*. The Saudi Energy Ministry had said the strike caused a limited fire.

Operations at Aramco were continuing normally, with employees working from home, according to two of the sources.

The escalating conflict has dealt a blow to Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman's ambitious plans to transform and diversify the Saudi economy and reduce its reliance on oil.

The Houthis say they have been retaliating for the kingdom's backing of Yemeni government forces in the Yemen war that restarted last month.

The Saudi-led coalition said it had intercepted a ballistic missile fired by the Houthis towards Riyadh on Wednesday, and several loud booms were heard in the Saudi capital.

Saudi authorities earlier issued an alert for a possible aerial threat in Riyadh on Wednesday before the warning was lifted, a witness said.

In their statement on Wednesday, the Houthis said they had launched ballistic missiles, cruise missiles and drones at the Saudi Aramco facilities in Dhahran, Riyadh airport and an Aramco refinery in Riyadh.

Ukraine accuses U.S. of aiding Russia amid strikes

Agence France-Presse
KYIV



Ukrainian firefighters extinguish a blaze at the site of a Russian missile strike at an apartment building in Kyiv on Wednesday. AFP

Ukraine on Wednesday accused the United States of helping Russia, saying Washington failed to warn it of incoming missile strikes and slowed the Starlink system it relies on for its battlefield communications and frontline logistics.

U.S. President Donald Trump on Tuesday insisted Washington was still helping Ukraine, while a U.S. official said on Wednesday that its policy had "not changed". The EU also said there were "no indications" sharing had stopped.

Ballistic missiles have now struck the Ukrainian capital, Kyiv, for two nights running – before air raid sirens could sound in time to warn people to take cover in basements, bomb shelters or metro stations.

Energy facilities were targeted, cutting power to more than 600,000, despite Mr. Trump's surprise announcement of an "energy ceasefire" in the nearly five-year conflict.

"Russia has never before shown such ostentatious disrespect toward the United States," Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said.

Six people were killed and dozens more wounded in Kyiv on Wednesday, the authorities said, while significant damage to facilities and equipment knocked out power to swathes of the city.

Iran says a ship sank after hitting a mine in Strait of Hormuz

Agence France-Presse
DUBAI

Iran's Revolutionary Guards said on Wednesday that a ship caught fire and sank in the Strait of Hormuz because of a mine, while British security firm Vanguard also reported a sinking.

"A container ship attempting to cross the Strait of Hormuz using an unauthorised and dangerous shipping lane struck a mine that exploded," said the navy of the Revolutionary Guards, the ideological arm of Iran's military.

Images released by the Guards show a plume of black smoke rising from a ship, while dozens of containers that have fallen into the sea float on the water. The Guards said the ship was carrying more than 2,500 containers.

According to Vanguard, the *GFS Pride*, a Singapore-flagged container ship, was struck by a projectile on Tuesday and sank. It was not clear if the two statements referred to the same ship. Vanguard reported three other ships struck on Tuesday, with two of them continuing on their way and the fate of the third unknown.

The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations Centre reported on Wednesday that two container ships were struck on Tuesday by projectiles.

Public dissent



Expressing disapproval: Demonstrators take part in a nationwide protest against the government of Colombian President Abelardo De La Espriella and its proposed labour and pension reforms, in Cali, Colombia, on Wednesday. REUTERS

UN wants Lebanon stability as UNIFIL mandate nears end

Agence France-Presse
BEIRUT



Jean-Pierre Lacroix

A visiting senior United Nations official on Wednesday reaffirmed the UN's commitment to stability in Lebanon as the mandate of its peacekeeping force in the country is set to expire.

Under-Secretary-General for Peace Operations Jean-Pierre Lacroix met officials as well as representatives of countries contributing to the UN Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL), which counts some 7,500 personnel from nearly 50 countries.

"I thanked them for their critical support to UNIFIL and reiterated the UN's strong commitment to supporting peace and stability in Lebanon," Mr. Lacroix said.

UNIFIL has served as a buffer between Israel and Lebanon since 1978.

Under U.S. pressure, the UN Security Council last year voted to end UNIFIL's mandate on December 31, 2026.

Saudi top court sets aside Sri Lankan migrant worker's death sentence

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

The Supreme Court of Saudi Arabia on Wednesday set aside the death penalty awarded to a Sri Lankan migrant worker over a Facebook post that was deemed blasphemous.

"On 13 October 2026, the Supreme Court of Saudi Arabia set aside the judgment imposing the death penalty on Anojan Sivarasa. This follows sustained diplomatic and legal efforts by the Government of Sri Lanka," Sri Lanka's Deputy Foreign Minister Arun Hemachandra announced in a social media post, terming the development "a major relief" for the 24-year-old engineer hailing from the island's eastern Ampara district.

According to senior lawyer and President's Counsel Upul Kumarapperuma, who was on the team sent to Riyadh by the Sri Lankan government, Anojan's death penalty was set aside by the Supreme Court of Saudi Arabia and referred to the lower court that originally heard the case. "The case is expected to be heard within two weeks, and a fresh sentence is likely," he told *The Hindu* on Wednesday.

In a social media post, President Anura Kumara Dissanayake said the development "brings immense relief to Anojan, his family, and all Sri Lankans who have followed his case with deep concern". The move "reflects the value of patient diplomacy, respect for the legal processes of a friendly nation, and the tireless work of those who stood by a Sri Lankan citizen abroad," he said, adding: "No Sri Lankan who leaves our shores in search of a livelihood should ever feel that they stand alone."



Sivarasa Anojan

Anojan's Facebook comment, posted in June this year, was part of a heated exchange among social media users over a video of a Muslim man attacking a dog named Subramani, which had drawn media attention even as it accompanied Hindu pilgrims to the Kataragama temple, a famed shrine for the deity Skanda in southern Sri Lanka. Accused of "verbally insulting and offending Prophet Muhammad", Anojan – who subsequently posted a public apology – was sentenced to five years in prison initially. In September, the Saudi Court of Appeal in the Eastern Region awarded him a death sentence.

Macron believes French protesters 'exploited' by political forces, says govt.

Agence France-Presse
PARIS



Protesters hold a placard which reads as 'Be young and shut up' while taking part in a demonstration in Nantes on Tuesday. AFP

French President Emmanuel Macron believes the students waging three weeks of protests that have closed many schools have "legitimate" grievances but are also being "exploited" by political forces, a government spokesperson said on Wednesday.

The leader, who is in his final six months of office, has asked the government to come up with "concrete responses" to the unrest by high school pupils within weeks, spokesperson Maud Bregeon told presspersons.

She spoke following Mr. Macron's weekly meeting with his Cabinet, a day after nationwide solidarity demonstrations showed significant support for the students.

The Interior Ministry said 161,500 people turned out for Tuesday's demonstrations held in Paris and other cities. Unions organising the rallies put the figure at 480,000. Some violent scenes erupted on the sidelines of marches in Paris and Lyon, with police firing tear gas in response.

In his Cabinet meeting, Mr. Macron "stressed that young people have legitimate concerns, but said these are being exploited for political purposes and turned into urban violence", Ms. Bregeon said.

With French presidential elections due in April and May next year, some Opposition parties have seized upon the demonstrations.

Jean-Luc Melenchon, the presidential candidate for the far-left France Unbowed (LFI) party, participated in one of the Paris protests.

The far-right National Rally (RN) party of Marine Le Pen, leading opinion polls, has voiced support for police deployed to the demonstrations and blamed students for violent episodes.



The New Yalu River Bridge connects China's Dandong city with North Korea's Sinuiju. REUTERS

China-North Korea bridge will open over a decade late

Associated Press
BEIJING

A new bridge linking China and North Korea is set to open on Thursday after more than a decade of delay in the latest sign of closer ties between the two countries.

The official Chinese news agency Xinhua reported on Wednesday that both sides will hold a ceremony for the launch of the New Yalu River Bridge. The four-lane, 3-km bridge will connect the northeastern Chinese city of Dandong to the North Korean city of Sinuiju.

The bridge initially was expected to enter use in 2014 after China apparently completed construction of access roads, customs facilities and other related infrastructure on its side. But the date passed with no sign of an opening and without North Korea doing corresponding works on its side.

A Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson said on Wednesday the new bridge will further promote economic, trade and "people-to-people exchanges."

"China and the DPRK are friendly neighbours linked by rivers and mountains," said Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning. She added the bridge is an important "project for connectivity" between the two countries.

The new link is expected to lessen the burden on an existing yet aging bridge on the Dandong-Sinuiju route, which handles more than 70 per cent of official trade between the two countries.

The bridge's opening comes about a month after North Korea and Russia opened a 1-km road bridge over the Tumen River as part of their efforts to cement relations.

Vietnam buries remains of 731 war dead six decades after Tet Offensive

At a park, excavators painstakingly recovered the remains of communist fighters and civilians buried in three large trenches; hundreds were buried in mass graves after bloody fighting in 1968; remains of 1,75,000 Vietnamese soldiers have yet to be recovered, and thousands yet to be identified

NEWS ANALYSIS

Associated Press
HANOI

Thousands carrying white flowers lined the roads in Vietnam's Ho Chi Minh City on Wednesday as the remains of 731 people believed to have been killed during the 1968 Tet Offensive were taken for burial nearly six decades after their deaths.

Vietnamese Prime Minister Le Minh Hung attended the memorial services at Le Thi Rieng Park, where the remains were recovered from mass graves after over three months of excavations. They were laid to rest at Ho Chi Minh City Martyrs' Cemetery in the city previously known as Saigon.

Generations in Vietnam have spent decades searching for loved ones who never returned from war, hoping to recover their remains, give them a proper burial and finally find some measure of closure.

The Tet Offensive began on January 31, 1968, when North Vietnamese communist forces launched coordinated surprise attacks across South Vietnam during the Lunar New Year holiday, known in Vietnam as Tet. One of the largest campaigns of the Vietnam War, it sparked fierce fighting and heavy casualties, including in the southern capital Saigon, where communist fighters attacked the U.S. Embassy, military installations and government buildings.

Although the communist forces suffered a military defeat, the offensive shocked Washington, undermined U.S. public support for the war, and became a turning point in the conflict. "The resultant conflict has changed the pattern of the war," The Associated Press reported in February 1968.

Mass graves

The South Vietnamese government collected the bodies of communist fighters and civilians and buried them in mass graves during and after the fighting, according to Vietnamese government news.

The remains at Le Thi Rieng Park, which was previously the site of Do Thanh Cemetery, were discovered during excavations that began on June 23. Over weeks, excavators painstakingly unearthed bones and fragments, along with weapons, ammunition, military hammocks and personal belongings, said the Vietnamese government's official news portal.

They discovered a wallet containing a faded military document bearing the name Huynh Van Quen, which helped authorities identify one of the dead as a soldier from the 1st Long An Battalion, a communist unit that fought a fierce seven-day battle at Saigon's Y-shaped Bridge.



Fallen fighters: A woman stands in the middle of caskets bearing the remains of soldiers recovered during excavations at Le Thi Rieng Park in Ho Chi Minh City on Wednesday. AFP

Among the mourners was Vo Huy Thinh, 70, who remembered watching bodies being buried there when he was 12. "The memory of that burial pit has stayed with me," he told Vietnamese state media.

For years, architect Nguyen Xuan Thang pored over photographs from the Vietnam War, searching for clues to the location of the burial site.

A breakthrough came when he found a colour photograph taken by an AP photographer on February 12, 1968, with a caption describing three large burial trenches that each contained about 300 bodies, he told state media.

The photograph shows two men carrying a body as two others look on. Three boys stand nearby, one of them wearing shorts and a short-sleeved shirt and looking directly at the camera. A water tower is visible in the background, providing a crucial clue to the site's location. The image was shot by a French photographer credited as Gautron.

Long search for graves

Mr. Thang told state media that he spent months riding his motorbike through Ho Chi Minh City, comparing old military maps with present-day landmarks, including the water tower. His research was part of a nearly eight-year effort, from November 2018 to May 2026, involving his team and the military, which helped authorities narrow their search to the park.

Investigators worked with researchers, historians, journalists and witnesses to piece together the location of the mass graves. They examined other wartime photographs, satellite images, military maps and archival records from Vietnam and abroad, comparing them with field surveys and accounts from people who witnessed the burials, said the Vietnamese government's official news portal.

The recovery is part of a nationwide 500-day campaign running through July 2027 to locate the remains of about 7,000 war dead and identify them.

More than half a century after the war ended in 1975, many Vietnamese families are still searching for relatives who never returned home. The remains of about 1,75,000 Vietnamese soldiers have yet to be recovered, while hundreds of thousands more lie in graves without confirmed identities, according to government figures.

Identification work on

Of the 731 sets of remains recovered in Ho Chi Minh City, 307 were found with personal belongings, according to state media. Most have not yet been identified.

"Due to the harsh conditions of war and the passage of time, we have been unable to identify the names, ages, or hometowns of the majority of the martyrs in this group," said Nguyen Manh Cuong, who heads the city's war dead identification efforts.

Samples have been sent to the Vietnam Academy of Science and Technology in Hanoi for DNA testing and comparison with samples from relatives.

Similar memorial and burial ceremonies will be held on Thursday in three other parts, with the remains of what are believed to be 93 people to be buried in Tuyen Quang province, another 65 in Hai Phong and 120 in Can Tho.

As Ebola spreads in eastern Congo, mothers and children shun vital care

Reuters
BUTEMBO

The fear of Ebola is keeping women and children from seeking healthcare in eastern Congo, health workers and aid agencies say, contributing to soaring maternal deaths and falling childhood immunisation rates that could strain the healthcare system for years to come.

Health workers say that misplaced anxiety about contact with Ebola is the primary reason women are forgoing crucial prenatal care and opting to give birth at home, and dying more often in the event of complications.

There is still limited data available but figures for Ituri province are raising alarm. UN figures show that maternal deaths in the province soared nearly 70% between May and July compared with a year earlier, a troubling indicator of the impact of the Ebola outbreak – currently Congo's worst on record – on the primary healthcare system.



Spread of misinformation: Nurse Liliane Adronga says people think the medicines given to them contain Ebola virus. REUTERS

Steep international aid cuts have also led to shortages of some life-saving medications.

In eastern Butembo city, nurses at the Masiki healthcare centre told *Reuters* that births have fallen sharply at their maternity ward since the Ebola outbreak was declared in May. Just one mother was resting with her newborn during a recent visit, among rows of empty beds.

"They think the medicines we give them contain the Ebola virus," head nurse Liliane Adronga told *Reuters* – highlighting just one of many unfounded suspicions circulating about the virus and healthcare.

Hospital deliveries drop

Ms. Adronga described how women often avoided seeking care until it was too late, recalling a recent case where a woman was believed to have lost her baby while suffering from untreated malaria.

The UNFPA has reported a more than 30% drop in hospital deliveries and 50% drop in treatment for obstetric complications for the May to July period since the outbreak began.

Fuel shortage



Long lines: Vehicles wait outside a gas station in Denpasar, Bali, Indonesia, on Wednesday as fuel deliveries across the resort island of Bali were disrupted this week by a combination of technical problems, bad weather and surging demand. AP

Trump says oil, mineral exploration in Greenland is set to begin; it's not that simple

Associated Press

U.S. President Donald Trump said "massive" oil, gas and mineral exploration is set to begin in "our new and beautiful Greenland " early Wednesday.

It was not immediately clear what exploration or developments the U.S. President was referring to in his socila media post, and Greenland is a self-governing territory of Denmark, rather than a part of the United States.

Mr. Trump posted on his Truth Social platform following a campaign event on Tuesday in Wasilla, Alaska, to stump for Republican U.S. Sen. Dan Sullivan as he seeks his third term to represent the state in an election against Democratic former U.S. congresswoman Mary Peltola.

Rising energy prices – a direct result of Mr. Trump's war in Iran – are creating serious and sustained financial hardships for America's working class ahead of the midterm elections next month. Mr. Trump's comments on Wednesday are likely aimed at addressing voters' concerns before they head to the polls.

Harsh conditions

But despite Mr. Trump's optimism, resource exploration and extraction in Greenland has stymied companies for decades thanks to the island's harsh climate, lack of key infrastructure and difficult geology. Previous efforts to extract so-called rare earth minerals, as well as oil and gas, have never progressed beyond the exploratory stage.

Mr. Trump's comments about the Arctic island come less than a month after he signed an agreement with the leaders of Denmark and Greenland to strengthen security in the Arctic and North Atlantic following months of tensions with NATO allies over the U.S. President's repeated demands to take control of the semi-autonomous Danish territory. It does not grant the U.S. any special exploration rights, but does place some limits on investments by non-NATO countries in strategic sectors.

The deal also paved the way for more U.S. bases in Greenland and eased tensions over Mr. Trump's repeated calls for Greenland to become part of the United States. The agreement would still apply if Greenland eventually chooses independence.



Tough nut to crack: Harsh climate, lack of key infrastructure and difficult geology have dissuaded from exploration in Greenland. AFP

Mr. Trump has expressed his desire to acquire Greenland since as long ago as 2019 and, during his second term, issued threats to seize the territory from Denmark, a NATO ally.

Representatives of the leaders of Denmark and Greenland did not immediately return requests for comment on Wednesday.

Rare earth deposits

Greenland has large deposits of the rare earth minerals that are needed to make everything from computers and smartphones to batteries, solar and wind technologies that will power the transition away from fossil fuels. China currently dominates the world's supply of these critical minerals and the Trump administration is seeking to break Beijing's chokehold on them.

The U.S. Geological Survey has also identified major potential offshore deposits of oil and natural gas.

But tapping these resources could be prohibitively difficult: the rare earth minerals are encased in rock, and the offshore oil and natural gas deposits are covered by Arctic ice.

Mr. Trump's Truth Social post also touted Greenland's strategic location, saying that "from a Security Purpose in the Defense and Offense of both the United States of America, and Europe," the island is "second to none."

"Any future attack on the United States will have to come across Greenland, where our Defense will routinely knock down drones, missiles, or any other form of weapon not yet even conceived," he wrote. "It gives us time, location, and sightline, like nowhere else in the World!"

The United States was prominent in Greenland for decades but, since 1945, the U.S. military presence in Greenland has decreased from thousands of soldiers on 17 bases and installations to roughly 200 soldiers on the remote Pituffik Space Base in the northwest. The base supports missile warning, missile defence and space surveillance operations for the U.S. and NATO.

Mr. Trump said last month that the United States would "immediately begin the process of developing a large military presence in the appropriate locations", including "building two very major military bases".

GREAT FEAT

Hope becomes first Windies batter with three tons in men's T20Is



NAGARA GOPAL

Shai Hope became the first West Indies batter with three hundreds in men's T20Is and the fifth player (after England's Phil Salt, Indians Sanju Samson & Tilak Varma, and Pakistan's Sahibzada Farhan) from a full member nation to do so. Incidentally, each of Hope's T20I centuries have been identical scores of 102 not out.

'SELECTION' TALK

Parthiv doesn't apply, Ojha set to be full-time chairman

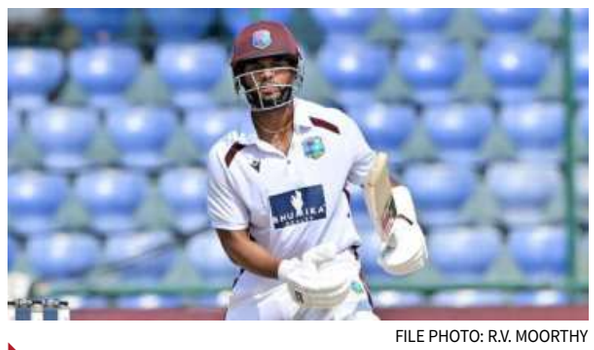


FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

Parthiv Patel, tipped to replace Ajit Agarkar as the West Zone representative on the BCCI senior men's selection committee, has not applied for the position, paving the way for Pragyan Ojha to continue as chairman. "The situation could change if the deadline is extended or he changes his mind," a BCCI source said.

A BREAK

Hope rested for West Indies' Test tour of Bangladesh



FILE PHOTO: R.V. MOORTHY

West Indies squad for the two-Test series against Bangladesh: Roston Chase (Capt.), Jomel Warrican, Joshua Bishop, John Campbell, Tagenarine Chanderpaul, Joshua Da Silva, Justin Greaves, Kavem Hodge, Amir Jangoo, Shamar Joseph, Brandon King, Keemo Paul, Kemar Roach, Jayden Seales, Kevin Wickham.

IPL BUZZ

Natarajan returns to SRH, Zeeshan joins DC after player trade



FILE PHOTOS: R.V. MOORTHY & K.V.S. GIRI

Left-arm pacer T. Natarajan returned to Sunrisers Hyderabad while leg-spinner Zeeshan Ansari moved to Delhi Capitals in a player trade between the two IPL franchises on Wednesday. Natarajan will join the 2016 IPL champions for a revised fee of ₹five crore. Zeeshan moves to Delhi Capitals at his existing fee of ₹40 lakh.

Hope and Paul sizzle as West Indies trumps India

The skipper smashes his second century of the series to power the visiting team to 247 before the seamer derails the host's chase with a five-for; the blistering start by Samson not enough



Leading from the front: Hope scored the lion's share of West Indies' runs. NAGARA GOPAL

WI IN INDIA

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

It arrived dressed as a stranger, this refreshed pitch at the Rajiv Gandhi International Stadium, with the promise of a different story. India, squinting into the unknown, chose to chase. But the night peeled back the disguise soon enough, and beneath it lay that same old batting paradise.

Shai Hope's sensational unbeaten century lit the fuse for West Indies' 24-run win over India on Wednesday, dragging the series level at 2-2.

Jewel Andrew, having taken the pitch's measure, got to work for the Windies, raining down on Arshdeep Singh with two boundaries and a six that sailed high over mid-wicket.

Mayank Yadav's pace and bounce backfired, costing him 11 extras.

The visitor tore past 50 in just 15 balls. After Andrew fell to Axar Patel, Shai Hope and Shimron Hetmyer ensured the respite was brief. The Windies registered 79 in the Power-Play, the joint-highest score in this phase (with New Zealand in Thiruvananthapuram earlier this year) against India in T20Is.

The team 100 came in just 42 balls with India reduced to a hapless spectator.

Hope then found a cautious partner in Rovman Powell, who then burst free to help plunder Axar for 22 runs in an over.

Sherfane Rutherford then joined Hope to stitch together a 91-run stand off just 43 balls, Hope raising his arms to celebrate a ton for the second time in the T20I leg.

Sanju Samson loves Hyderabad and his affection shone bright as he clobbered his way to his joint-fastest T20I fifty off 20 balls, with a daunting 248-run chase before him.

Hope turned to executioner of choice Keemo Paul, who came good not once but twice, first striking Samson off the ledger before sending Ishan Kishan back a few deliveries later.

Abhishek Sharma, who regularly renders his partners obsolete, found himself floundering for rhythm.

As the Sunrisers Hyderabad star dealt with his demons, Shreyas Iyer decided to turn aggressor, injecting life back into the packed stands here at Uppal until an athletic effort from Andrew brought an abrupt end.

Just when Abhishek began to find the fence, left-arm spinner Gudakesh Motie struck to remove him and Naman Dhir in consecutive balls. The ask: 116 runs from 48 balls.

Tilak Varma and Nitish Kumar's 32-ball 72 stand lifted hopes high but Paul led the charge with a fifer to dampen any hopes of a win.

Arshdeep retiring hurt was merely the final twist of the knife, hastening a defeat that India tried, in vain, to avoid.

SCOREBOARD

WEST INDIES

Shai Hope (not out) 102 *(50b, 4x4, 9x6)*, Jewel Andrew lbw b Axar 21 *(16b, 2x4, 1x6)*, Shimron Hetmyer c & b Prince 33 *(12b, 4x4, 2x6)*, Rovman Powell c Samson b Arshdeep 24 *(17b, 2x4, 1x6)*, Sherfane Rutherford (not out) 49 *(26b, 4x4, 3x6)*; Extras (lb-4, nb-1, w-13): 18; Total (for three wkts. in 20 overs): 247.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-52 (Andrew, 4.2 overs), 2-110 (Hetmyer, 8.2), 3-156 (Powell, 12.5).

INDIA BOWLING

Mayank 4-0-52-0, Arshdeep 4-0-52-1, Prince 4-0-36-1, Axar 4-0-45-1, Dhir 1-0-19-0, Nitish 3-0-39-0

INDIA

Sanju Samson c Hetmyer b Paul 56 *(23b, 6x4, 4x6)*, Abhishek Sharma c Springer b Motie 29 *(24b, 3x4, 1x6)*, Ishan Kishan c Andrew b Paul 6 *(3b, 1x6)*, Shreyas Iyer c Andrew b Springer 16 *(11b, 2x4)*, Tilak Varma c Powell b Shepherd 43 *(25b, 2x4, 3x6)*, Naman Dhir st. Hope b Motie 0 *(1b)*, Nitish Kumar c Powell b Paul 41 *(20b, 1x4, 4x6)*, Axar Patel c Rutherford b Paul 3 *(5b)*, Prince Yadav b Paul 0 *(1b)*, Arshdeep Singh retd. hurt 5 *(4b, 1x4)*, Mayank Yadav (not out) 0 *(1b)*; Extras (b-4, lb-3, nb-1, w-16): 24; Total (in 19.3 overs): 223.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-60 (Samson, 4.1), 2-67 (Kishan, 4.4), 3-97 (Shreyas, 8.2), 4-130 (Abhishek, 11.3), 5-130 (Dhir, 11.4), 6-200 (Tilak, 16.6), 7-212 (Nitish, 18.2), 8-212 (Prince, 18.3), 9-213 (Axar, 18.5).

WEST INDIES BOWLING

Chase 4-0-43-0, Shamar 2.3-0-47-0, Shepherd 3-0-32-1, Paul 4-0-41-5, Springer 4-0-40-1, Motie 2-0-13-2.

Toss: India; **PoM:** Hope.

West Indies won by 24 runs to level series 2-2.

Fifth and final T20I: October 17, Bengaluru, 7 p.m.



Too hot to handle: Paul ran riot with the ball to seal the win and keep the series alive. NAGARA GOPAL

The bowlers are trying to catch up: Santner

S. Shrivathsan

It is not often that an exceptionally skilled cricketer like Mitchell Santner hopes and prays for a certain setting instead of banking on his box of tricks.

But such has been the ferocity of India's T20 batting that the New Zealand white-ball captain wished for surfaces with some assistance for the bowlers in the forthcoming five-match home series.

"We know how good India is. It has power all the way through, as we have seen against the West Indies with high scores and on flat pitches. Hopefully, the pitches are not too flat here because we know what India can do in small grounds," Santner said during a virtual interaction on Wednesday.

"But if that is the case, we have to find a way to neutralise a powerful attack. We have to turn up, see what is in front of us and adapt as quickly as we can." The left-arm tweaker, who is a master of subtle variations, spelt out possible tactics to keep the batters in check, but it is easier said than done.

"The only way to stop a team like India is by taking wickets throughout [the innings]. It will be good to take wickets in the Power-Play even if we go for a few runs. We need to combat the explosive nature of the batters with plans. In the middle overs, we must see if we can go for six singles [in an over] and apply pressure on them," Santner added.



Santner.
FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

The 34-year-old stressed that the bowlers were left helpless in the shortest format in this day and age. "The batters have adapted faster while the bowlers are trying to catch up. But with the boundary sizes and flat pitches, there is not much we can do."

Santner, however, is not one to shy away from a challenge.

(Watch India tour of New Zealand live and exclusive on Sony Sports Network and Sony LIV starting October 22).

Lot of areas to improve in T20s, says Smriti

ZIM WOMEN IN INDIA

Press Trust of India
RAIPUR

Newly appointed India captain Smriti Mandhana on Wednesday said her team will look to make the most of the six T20Is ahead of the inaugural edition of the Women's Champions Trophy early next year.

Smriti is set to lead India in her first assignment as full-time captain when the hosts take on Zimbabwe in a three-match T20I series starting here on Friday, followed by three ODIs.

"The first bilateral (series) with Zimbabwe, I think, it is very exciting. It is our first time playing against them," said Smriti.

"Sometimes, playing with Zimbabwe and all the Associate nations, it feels like you can learn a lot from them as well because they enjoy playing their cricket."

Smriti said there were a lot of areas of improvement for the Indian team in the shortest format. "We have won the World Cup in the last one-and-a-half-years but there are a few things which we needed to work in the T20 format especially," she said.

"But I would say our strength has been the players who have come in. They've done extremely well."



New era: Smriti is excited about the first-ever series against Zimbabwe. X@BCCIWOMEN

Knights, Marathas continue to excel

APL

Sports Bureau
HYDERABAD

Kakatiya Knights and Mighty Marathas remained on top of the table with 10 points after registering wins over Rajputana Royals and Chola Chiefs in the Archery Premier League Season 2 at People's Plaza on Wednesday.

Yodhas in third spot

In the opening match of the day, Prithivraj Yodhas downed Chero Archers to move into third place with eight points.

Three sudden-death tie-breakers were needed to separate Yodhas and Archers when they met the previous time. In the reverse fixture, however, the former made light work of the latter. Yodhas were led by the 16-year-old recurve archer Gatha Anandrao Khadake, who shot 58 out of a possible 60, and Asian Games compound medallist Ganesh Thirumuru (59). While Yodhas arrested their own mini-slump, Archers slumped to their third straight defeat.

In the day's final contest, Chiefs' woeful run of form continued as they stayed rooted to the bottom with just one win in seven matches, suffering a fifth successive loss.



Pulling strings: Gatha was the architect of Yodhas' facile win.
ARCHERY PREMIER LEAGUE

Five straight wins

In contrast, Marathas, who had started the season with two reverses, have now won five on the bounce.

The scores:

Prithviraj Yodhas bt Chero Archers 5-1 (75-75, 77-75, 77-74).

Kakatiya Knights bt Rajputana Royals 6-2 (74-73, 79-78, 74-75, 76-74).

Mighty Marathas bt Chola Chiefs 6-0 (77-76, 75-72, 78-75).

Bouli's brace helps Punjab edge Odisha

ISL

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

Raphael Messi Bouli enjoyed a dream debut for Punjab FC in the Indian Super League on Wednesday, giving his new club a 2-1 win over Odisha FC at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium.

The 34-year-old, who was a free agent after playing for Jamshedpur last season, remarkably scored in the first and final minute of the game.

All of 39 seconds in, the host opened the scoring through the striker from Cameroon.

With Muhammad Uvais sending in a lovely cross from the left – the pass was perfectly weighted along the turf to carve open the Odisha defence – Bouli had to simply tap the ball into the back of the net.

Punjab had a few other half-chances in the opening exchanges, but Odisha found its footing thereafter. The visitor's equaliser came in the 15th minute. Having been awarded a corner, Lalthathanga Khawlhring exhibited his set-piece prowess by finding an unmarked Thoiba Singh Moirangthem. The 23-year-old from Manipur headed the ball powerfully past Punjab goalkeeper Arshdeep Singh.

Punjab gained the upper hand after the interval. In the 56th minute, Muhammad Suhail did extremely well to run into space on the left flank and cross with the outside of his right boot. The pass picked out Alfred Moya, but the Spaniard's first-time shot sailed well over the crossbar.

Just as the contest seemed set to end in a stalemate, Bouli pounced on a cross from substitute Bishu Sharma on the right wing to seal the deal in the dying seconds of stoppage time.

The result: Punjab FC 2 (Raphael Messi Bouli 1, 90+5) bt Odisha FC 1 (Thoiba Singh Moirangthem 15).

INBRIEF



Harsh packs off Lakshya; Monodip stuns Paranjay

Harsh Marwaha stunned second seed Lakshya Chukka 6-2, 6-4 in a third round boys' under-16 match of the 31st Fenesta Open National tennis championship in New Delhi on Wednesday. Monodip Dey, the 12th seed, knocked out third-seeded Paranjay Siwach 6-4, 6-4.

Other results (third round): Under-16: Boys: Ribhav Saroha bt Gyansh Manchanda 6-2, 6-4; Yaj Malik bt Kaustubh Singh 6-4, 6-1; Kushagra Arora bt Jeevith Sathish 6-2, 6-0; Vivaan Mirdha bt V. Gunampally 6-3, 6-1.
Girls: Pooja Nagaraj bt T. Sathesh 7-5, 6-1; Aaradhya Meena bt I. Kannan 6-0, 6-2; Akshita Antil bt Vrandika Rajput 7-5, 5-7, 6-1; Ranjhana Sangram bt A. Brahadeeswaran 6-0, 6-1.
Under-14: Boys: Aarav Chhallani bt Jegan Senthil 6-1, 6-2; Puneeth Manohar bt Devansh Kamboj 6-3, 6-3; Nibras Hussain bt Manav Patel 6-3, 6-3; Sparsh Patil bt Aditya Kamat 6-4, 6-1.
Girls: Rishita Yadav bt Sarena Gahlot 6-4, 7-6(3); Sidhhi Pandey bt Tanya Bhatnagar 6-1, 6-1; Zoha Qureshi bt Aaral Vashishta 6-1, 6-1; Aaradhana Tehlan bt P. Vattaprambil 7-5, 6-2.

Sindhu, Lakshya exit in first round; Srikanth, Tanvi win

P.V. Sindhu and Lakshya Sen made early exits while K. Srikanth and Tanvi Sharma advanced to the second round of the Denmark Open badminton in Odense on Tuesday.

The results (first round): Women: Yvonne Li bt P.V. Sindhu 13-21, 25-23, 21-19; Tanvi Sharma bt Natsuki Nidaira 21-17, 16-21, 21-19; Han Qianxi bt Unnati Hooda 23-21, 16-21, 21-16.
Men: Chou Tien Chen bt Lakshya Sen 21-18, 13-21, 21-15; K. Srikanth bt Arnaud Merkle 22-20, 21-19; Alwi Farhan bt Ayush Shetty 21-11, 13-21, 21-10.
Doubles: He Jiting & Ren Xiangyu bt Satwiksairaj Rankireddy & Chirag Shetty 12-21, 21-15, 21-19.

Ankur, Diya reign supreme in National ranking table tennis

Ankur Bhattacharjee and Diya Chitale lifted the men's and women's titles of the National ranking table tennis tournament, which concluded in Panchkula, Haryana.

The results: Men: Final: Ankur Bhattacharjee (Har) bt Raegan Albuquerque (Mah) 11-8, 3-11, 6-11, 11-8, 11-9, 6-11, 11-5. **Semifinals:** Ankur bt Jeet Chandra (RSPB) 13-11, 8-11, 11-7, 12-10, 11-6; Raegan bt Manav Thakkar (PSPB) 5-11, 11-5, 11-9, 8-11, 12-10, 11-8. **Women: Final:** Diya Chitale (RBI) bt Syndrela Das (WB) 11-6, 11-8, 11-7, 6-11, 9-11, 8-11, 11-9. **Semifinals:** Syndrela bt Sutirtha Mukherjee (RSPB) 9-11, 7-11, 11-4, 11-4, 12-10, 9-11, 11-6; Diya bt Swastika Ghosh (PSPB) 11-4, 8-11, 11-6, 11-9, 11-9.

BCCI steps in to halt forfeitures by Arunachal

The BCCI has stepped in to prevent Arunachal Pradesh from forfeiting further matches this season by organising selection trials for the State's men's and women's teams across age groups and at the senior level. BCCI Apex Council member M. Khairul Jamal Majumdar will convene the selection process, which will be overseen by an independent panel.

LIVE TELECAST

Golf: India Championships, day 1, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 11.30 a.m.
Archery Premier League: Sony LIV app, 7.30 p.m.

TN's match peters out into a draw, Rajasthan picks up three points

The host sets a safe target 282 which the visitors don't pursue in earnest; Lomror notches up his second half-century of the match; Jagadeesan and Sai Sudharsan get some batting time

RANJI TROPHY

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
JAIPUR

For Rajasthan, the final day of the Elite Group-D Ranji Trophy match against Tamil Nadu at the Sawai Mansingh Stadium here on Wednesday was a matter of prudence. Assured of three points for its first-innings lead, it batted to set a safe target. Tamil Nadu, needing 282 runs in just under two sessions, chose preservation over adventure. By tea, the captains shook hands, settling for a draw.

In the morning session, Kartik Sharma (42) offered another glimpse of his attacking instinct, standing tall to launch Saravana Kumar over long-off for six. The 20-year-old had supplied a bit of adventure in the final session on Tuesday, hitting Washington Sundar to deep mid-wicket for six before ducking under a bouncer from Deepesh and guiding it over the 'keeper's head for four.

Time was of the essence if Tamil Nadu was to push for a win, and new coach Yo Mahesh embodied that sense of urgency.



Innovative: Lomror's knock was embellished with some delightful strokes. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Like a football manager on the touchline, he was constantly on the edge. He paced the boundary, relayed instructions, and lived almost every ball on his feet.

When Sai Kishore trapped Kartik plumb in front, he was elated.

But Mahipal Lomror brought up his second fifty of the match (84, 170b, 7x4) and added 83 runs for the sixth wicket with Kukna Ajay Singh (32 n.o.).

Lomror's knock featured a scoop attempt against pace, a pull off Saravana Kumar to wide long-on for four, and back-to-back sweeps off Washington to deep square leg for fours. After lunch, he missed a sweep to be bowled by Washington, prompting Rajasthan to declare.

Tamil Nadu openers Jagadeesan (42 n.o.) and Sai Sudharsan (26 n.o.) put on an unbroken 73-run stand.

The scores:

Rajasthan — 1st innings: 363.
Tamil Nadu — 1st innings: 274.
Rajasthan — 2nd innings: Sachin Yadav b Sai Kishore 0, Rohan Rajbhar st. Jagadeesan b Sai Kishore 10, Sumit Godara c Sonu b Saravana Kumar 2, Karan Lamba b Sonu 13, Mahipal Lomror b Washington 84, Kartik Sharma lbw b Sai Kishore 42, Kukna Ajay Singh (not out) 32; Extras (b-2, lb-5, w-2): 9; Total (for six wkts. decl. in 70.1 overs): 192.
Fall of wickets: 1-0, 2-3, 3-25, 4-31, 5-109, 6-192.
Tamil Nadu bowling: Sai Kishore 26-3-50-3, Saravana Kumar 10-2-27-1, Washington 19.1-4-44-1, Sonu 7-0-21-1, Deepesh 6-0-38-0, Pradosh Ranjan Paul 2-0-5-0.
Tamil Nadu — 2nd innings: Sai Sudharsan (not out) 26, N. Jagadeesan (not out) 42; Extras (b-2, lb-3): 5; Total (for no loss in 23 overs): 73.
Rajasthan bowling: Suthar 12-4-24-0, Akash 2-0-2-0, Kukna 9-0-42-0.

RANJI TROPHY SCORES — ROUND ONE, FOURTH & FINAL DAY



Productive spell: Andhra's Lalith scalped five in Karnataka's second innings. K.V.S. GIRI

Elite: Group A: At Panaji: Baroda 472/8 decl. bt Goa 199 & 138 in 68 overs (Shivendra Bhujbal 46, Abhinav Tejrana 47, Mahesh Pithiya 4/66, Bhargav Bhatt 5/32). **Points: Goa 0(0), Baroda 7(7).**
At Srinagar: Madhya Pradesh 196 & 249/6 decl. in 80 overs (Shubham Sharma 106 n.o.) drew with Jammu & Kashmir 120 & 88/7 in 34 overs. **J&K 1(1), MP 3(3).**
At Nagpur: Vidarbha 428 & 175/3 decl. in 36 overs (Aman Mokhade 65, Dhruv Shorey 69 n.o.) bt Pondicherry 313 & 130 in 41.1 overs (Prasad Pawar 48, Harsh Dubey 4/29). **Vidarbha 6(6), Pondicherry 0(0).**
Group B: At Vijayawada: Karnataka 274 & 337/9 decl. in 103 overs (Manvanth Kumar 44, Karun Nair 155 n.o., Lalith Mohan 5/117) drew with Andhra 418 & 104/4 in 44 overs. **Andhra 3(3), Karnataka 1(1).**
At New Chandigarh: Assam 373 & 157/6 in 61 overs (Denish Das 45) drew with Punjab 478/6 decl. in 127 overs (Vihaan Malhotra 103, Harnoor Singh 54, Salil Arora 110, Emanjot Singh Chahal 114 n.o.). **Punjab 3(3), Assam 1(1).**
At Rajkot: Saurashtra 392 & 229/1 in 67 overs (Harvik Desai 68, Chirag Jani 127 n.o.) drew with Chhattisgarh 312. **Saurashtra 3(3), Chhattisgarh 1(1).**
Group C: At Jamshedpur: Jharkhand 587 drew with Kerala 395 in 127.5 overs (Abhishek P. Nair 126, Rohan Kunnummal 44, Salman Nizar 43, Aditya Sarvate 95, Manishi Singh 4/92, Utkarsh Singh 4/69) & 62/2 in 19.3 overs. **Jharkhand 3(3), Kerala 1(1).**
At Kalyani: Delhi 240 & 277 in 106.2 overs (Ayush Badoni 85) lost to Bengal 429 & 89/1 in 15.3 overs. **Bengal 6(6), Delhi 0(0).**
At Ahmedabad: Odisha 324 & 161 in 46.1 overs (Sandeep Pattnaik 65, Ninad Rathva 53, Siddharth Desai 5/36) lost to Gujarat 439 & 47/0 in 9.3 overs. **Gujarat 7(7), Odisha 0(0).**
At New Delhi: Maharashtra 333 & 141 in 56 overs (Ankit Bawne 48, Rajvardhan Hangargekar 43, Arjun Sharma 5/58) bt Services 227 & 120 in 63.3 overs (Vicky Ostwal 5/50). **Maharashtra 6(6), Services 0(0).**
Group D: At Lahli: Himachal Pradesh 253 & 113 lost to Haryana 296 & 74/3 in 18.1 overs. **Haryana 6(6), HP 0(0).**
At Mumbai (Brabourne Stadium): Railways 278 & 272/4 in 86 overs (Suraj Ahuja 53, Vivek Singh 58, Eshaan Goyal 53, Bhargav Merai 51) drew with Uttarakhand 470. **Railways 1(1), Uttarakhand 3(3).**
At Jaipur: Rajasthan 363 & 192/6 decl. in 70.1 overs (Mahipal Lomror 84, Kartik Sharma 42) drew with Tamil Nadu 274 & 73/0 in 23 overs (N. Jagadeesan 42 n.o.). **Rajasthan 3(3), TN 1(1).**
Plate: At Rangpo: Sikkim 245 & 291/7 in 96.1 overs (Parth Palawat 66, Gurinder Singh 100 n.o.) drew with Meghalaya 395. **Sikkim 1(1), Meghalaya 3(3).**
At Nadiad: Mizoram 183 & 295 lost to Manipur 251 & 228/7 in 71.2 overs (Johnson Singh 51, Jotin Pheiroijam 105 n.o.). **Mizoram 0(0), Manipur 6(6).**

Sai Sudharsan gathering info before the tour down under

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
JAIPUR

Sai Sudharsan said on Wednesday that the National selectors had asked him to play in the Ranji Trophy as part of his preparation for India's upcoming tour of New Zealand.

Having been on India-A duty in Puducherry, he arrived here "at 10.40 p.m." on the eve of Tamil Nadu's Ranji Trophy opener against Rajasthan (October 10).

"There was a day's break between games in Puducherry. On that day (October 10), our manager told me that the selectors had asked me to play the Ranji Trophy.

"After the first day's play here, I spoke with Pragyan Ojha (interim chief National selector). He said it would be good for the upcoming New Zealand series – for preparation and all. That was the clarity from their side."



Sai Sudharsan. S. PRASANNA VENKATESAN

He has been "watching a lot of old videos" of India's Tests in New Zealand to understand the conditions and how best to bat there.

"I have gathered a little information. It will be a bit windy, and there will be good bounce. It will be almost similar to England, but there will be a bit more lateral movement.

Grabbing knowledge

"Sachin *paaji* has scored there, so I watched his batting. I watched Dravid sir's batting. I try to grab knowledge from that and execute whatever is possible for me," he said.

On missing the Test series in Sri Lanka because of a toe stress fracture, the 24-year-old said: "I wasn't disappointed because I believe everything good is ahead of us. The last few injuries have been freakish, but because of them, I've probably gotten better with my habits and have a better understanding of how to take care of my body... how much I bat and things like that".

Patient Mulani lives on hope

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Shams Mulani has spent the better part of five years knocking on the doors of the Indian team. The Mumbai left-arm spinner has piled up wickets, contributed with the bat and recently earned the Player-of-the-Series award in India-A' multi-day series against Australia-A. Yet, a senior India call-up remains elusive.

The 29-year-old, however, is in no mood to let the wait get the better of him.

"I am really proud to be playing for Mumbai, and I enjoy playing. There is a different pressure altogether because of the bench strength we have. You cannot afford to lack anywhere when you are playing for Mumbai," Mulani said after helping the 42-time champions begin their Ranji Trophy campaign with an innings-and-155-run victory over Chandigarh at the Wankhede Stadium.



Mulani. EMMANUAL YOGINI

"I don't take any game for granted. I try to perform in every game and give my best to the team. The door has not opened yet, but I am a patient guy. I will keep working hard and putting up performances. Hopefully, one day it opens."

Closing in on 300 First Class wickets, Mulani is gradually transitioning from a seasoned domestic professional to a veteran of the circuit. His spin partner Tanush Kotian, also an all-rounder, finds himself in a similar position, with both continuing to make their case through consistent performances.

Support structure

Mulani admits that disappointment is natural when opportunities pass by, but credits the support of his teammates and coaches for keeping him grounded.

"There are times when you feel you should have got a chance on a tour. You might get disappointed somewhere, because that is human nature.

"But my job is to keep performing for Mumbai. I am proud to do that, and I will continue doing so," he said.

The left-arm spinner has also sought feedback from coaches, including those with India-A, on what he needs to do to reach the next level.

BFI's internal battle intensifies

Sports Bureau
KOLKATA

In a retaliatory move, Boxing Federation of India (BFI) president Ajay Singh has suspended secretary general Pramod Kumar, who earlier moved a no-confidence motion against the federation chief, on various grounds.

In a letter issued on Tuesday, Ajay said several enquiries are pending against Pramod, who was earlier served a show-cause notice, "with respect to various acts and financial decisions taken by him."

In response, Pramod suspended Ajay on Wednesday.

India's skill and Australia's expertise — charting a joint gameplan

Lavanya L
CHENNAI

At Khel Connect, a symposium organised by the Australia India Institute (AII) and funded by the Australian Government Department of Education, educators, sporting administrators and industry leaders from both countries met over two days this week to discuss closer collaboration in high performance, community engagement and commercial expertise.

"This symposium is really about bringing two forces together by pairing Australia's deep expertise with India's scale, ambition and talent," AII CEO Lisa Singh said.

"There is growth in sports consumption tech as well. India can greatly contribute there," Anupam Goswami, league commissioner of Pro Kabaddi League, added.

Rob Aughey, Head of Discipline, Exercise and Sports Science at Federation University, called for short, targeted 'coach the coach' programmes.

"Three-year courses are impractical because rapid advances – especially in sports technology – make the training obsolete by the time participants finish," Aughey, whose research collaborators include FIFA, said.

Olympian Hakimuddin Habibulla, who swam for India at the 2000 Sydney Games, highlighted a major gap in coaching fundamentals.

"Coaches assume players already know the basics, and high stakes leave little room to teach foundational re-learning –breaking the transition from grass-roots to elite levels," he added.



Enriching experience: The participants and panellists at the symposium held at IIT Madras.

Aadhithya Chakravarthy, Head of Performance at FC Madras, shed light on decision errors in a data-driven world.

"Academies often evaluate players based on current ability rather than long-term potential, frequently discarding late bloomers for early maturers. Long-term patience is crucial," he explained.

"High-performance systems don't humanise athletes, making community sport its necessary counterpart. Consequently, our focus is making sports permissionless," Nandan Kamath, managing trustee of GoSports Foundation, advocated.

Rekha Dey, Partner at Tanjun Associate LLP, called for greater livelihood options to make sports viable to pursue at a community level, something Arun Vasu, president of the Indian and Asian Surfing Federation, corroborated.

Prof. Mahesh V Panchagnula, founder and head of the IIT Madras Center of Excellence on Sports Science and Analytics, placed the onus on schools to make sports a graded subject to help foster a more holistic culture that could turn profitable.

Meanwhile, Vik Singh, Trade and Investment Commissioner for Austrade in South Asia, said exchange relationships between the two countries need to move on from being one-sided.

With India hosting the 2030 Commonwealth Games and bidding for the 2036 Summer Games, major event capability and innovation took centre stage.

Dr. Sheila Nguyen, former Head of Sustainability for the 2023 FIFA Women's World Cup, cautioned against drawing on community resources without a plan to leave a legacy.

"We are distracted by ticket sales, broadcast numbers, and money spent. We need to broaden our perspective on hosting big events.

"They are more than nation-building exercises; they are also community-building exercises.

"If infrastructure improves, it can improve all the services around that facility and force people to upgrade, but it needs to be done with intention," she said.



I would love to push myself to try and win another Major

The 13-time PGA Tour winner feels that it is an important time for the sport globally and India is key to its development, is willing to constantly tweak his game in order to stay relevant with the modern times

INTERVIEW

Justin Rose

Ashwin Achal
NEW DELHI

This is Justin Rose's second visit to India. The first was a good 22 years ago, when the English golfer played a skins game at DLF Golf and Country Club in Gurgaon. "That was back in the day before DLF became the DLF of now," Rose said.

Rose's own journey over the last decades has seen tremendous highs. A 13-time winner on the PGA Tour, Rose hit the peak in 2013 when he won the U.S. Open, his first and only Major title. In September 2018, Rose rose to the World No. 1 spot, becoming only the fourth English golfer to reach those great heights after Nick Faldo, Lee Westwood, and Luke Donald.

At 46, Rose has lost none of his competitive spirit. Now ranked 18th on the Official World Golf Ranking list, Rose has had a good year, winning the Farmers Insurance Open in February with a tournament-record score of 23-under par.

In April, Rose led the Masters by two shots in the final round, but back-to-back bogeys saw him finish tied for third. Now in New Delhi to compete in the DP World India Championship, Rose is keen to add to his trophy cabinet. A self-confessed fan of Indian food, Rose plans to enjoy a tasty Tandoori meal along the way.

The South Africa-born Englishman spoke on a range of topics at a press conference in Delhi Golf Club. Excerpts:

How important is it for an event like this to come to India, where there is so much interest in golf?

It is fantastic to be playing golf in this region. It's a country that is exploding in many, many ways, and I think that there is a commitment to golf here, with great sponsors and backers. This is an important time for golf to grow all around the world. What a field they have assembled here. Hopefully, that creates the interest that will help golf grow in this area.

You wanted to spend your 40th birthday in India, but it did not work out because of the COVID-19 restrictions. Tell us about your connection with India.

I have accumulated some Indian friends through the years. From what I've noticed, Indians are very proud of their country. Anybody who has any sort of influence here in India really wants to share it and show you the magic of India. I live in England, so of course I love Indian food. I'm not sure how authentic we make it in the U.K., but the national dish is chicken tikka masala. It is the most ordered dish in England. I am a big fan of Indian food.

What are your views on the course?

I can't tell you too much because I haven't been on the golf course yet. But I've spoken to my friend, Tommy Fleetwood, and guys who were here last year. It's a very unique golf course – very traditional and very old-school. There is no real need for distance off the tee. The driver stays in the bag. The DGC is a 250-yard, good second-shot type of golf course. Long and mid irons will be the most important part this week. Getting on the fairways and greens will be a huge premium.

What keeps the fire burning after so many years of competing at this top level?

That's a great question. Yes, I have been able to build a nice resume, but I've only achieved those high levels once. I would love to push myself to try and win another Major championship. But it's more than that. I want to play golf now for the memories. In order to build the memory bank, you have to keep putting yourself in the biggest situations in golf, whether that be down the stretch in Majors or on the first tee of Ryder Cups... I'm playing for those big moments.

The kids on the tour these days are so good. The strength and depth is so strong that I feel it's taking more discipline for me to stay relevant and continue to push myself to be a better player.



That is really the goal. Can I be better next year? I'm 47 next year. That shouldn't be possible, but I think it is possible. It is a personal battle, I suppose.

You came so close to winning the Masters this year but finished third. How do you recover and get back on the horse again?

This year, I turned up at Augusta with a sense that people were rooting for me because I have come so close to winning in the past. You can sense the sort of frustration of the crowd that you haven't been able to win, but you can't let that become part of your own story. I can only control my own performance and how I break down the golf course.

I've been incredibly close. I've had three runner-up finishes at the Masters. This year felt like a second-place finish, although it was a third. I feel like I played well enough to win the tournament, so my mindset would be to do nothing different.

The modern game has become increasingly driven by power and athleticism. How do you evolve as a player without losing the qualities that made you successful?

That's a really great question. I guess that's my job, especially this off-season. I have to try and figure out if there are some gains to be had, if I can push myself physically, and if there are some power and distance gains to be made. I also have to be realistic that pushing too hard at my age in certain areas comes with risks.

What has made me a great player through the years is being able to work my way around tough golf courses, plan my strategy, and, obviously, handle the mental side.

These are the things that I need to continue to do to stay strong. I am capable of driving the ball well enough to be incredibly competitive. My short game needs a little bit of work, but I know I have it in me. My putting has shown an uptrend in the last five or six years. If I can just piece it all together, I don't need to do much differently.

But yes, the game has shifted, no doubt. You see many college players coming out on tour now with 180-mile-an-hour ball speed. When I first arrived on tour, John Daly was the only one with 180-mile-an-hour ball speed. He was the outlier. Now it's the average. I fit somewhere below that average, but not by much. I need to compete by being consistent in everything.

You went on a Ryder Cup scouting trip. Talk to us about the process.

It was the first opportunity for (Team Europe captain) Luke Donald to get the group together. It was an important trip for players who haven't played the Ryder Cup before. It was good for rookies to be around the team and feel the energy of a Ryder Cup.

Luke talked a little bit about how he envisions the strategy and the plan for the next year or so. It was more of a boys' trip – casual golf, a nice dinner, and a little bit of discussion. It wasn't very intense.

You are a cricket fan. You played many pro-ams with Brian Lara. Will you use this week to play some cricket and meet a few cricketers?

I hope the energy of cricket comes through here in India. I know (former England cricketer) Kevin Pietersen quite well. We live in the same area back in England. I know he's also a big name and brand over here. I think he'll be around the golf tournament this week. If we can have some fun along the way, that will be great.

Perhaps you can get some batting practice...

Yes, sure, I can do some batting and maybe bowl my famous googly too (laughs).